

UPSC ESSENTIALS

October 2025 Issue



LETTER TO ASPIRANTS

Dear Aspirants,

Is the UPSC exam just about collecting facts? You know it is not. It's about what you read, how you think, and the quality of your preparation. So ask yourself: will what you are reading today give you an edge? As you go through this issue, try to find that answer, section by section, just as you have done month after month. Success in UPSC comes from smart effort, and this magazine is here to help you stay on course.

The *Cover Story* examines the GenZ protests in Nepal and India-Nepal relations, offering valuable insights into regional politics. *Express Edge* covers a wide range of topics — from the Hindu temples and Vivekananda's global influence to geopolitics at the UNSC and the EU's India strategy. You will also find articles on environment, economy, society, and polity, including clean air science, rural livelihoods, consumerism, urban development, and GST 2.0.

In *UPSC Focus*, explore India's rising cybercrime challenge and the government's response. *Essays Simplified* invites you to reflect on 'Contentment is natural wealth, luxury is artificial poverty,' encouraging original perspectives. The *Ethics* section highlights the role of civil servants as growth enablers and tackles ethical dilemmas faced by young District Magistrates. Finally, stay updated with current affairs pointers from September and test yourself with a practice quiz to boost exam readiness.

Aspirants, news never stops. UPSC preparation is about consolidating, filling gaps, and staying consistent. This issue is your power boost to keep pushing forward, because success is defined not just by ambition but by consistency.

Please share your thoughts with me at **manas.srivastava@indianexpress.com**.

Until next month,
Manas Srivastava

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COVER STORY

Turmoil in Nepal: GenZ Protest and India-Nepal Relations

Written by **Roshni Yadav**



Nepal's GenZ protests have been drastically different from previous waves. (Image: Abhishek Mitra)

INTRODUCTION

Nepal on September 12 installed former Supreme Court Chief Justice Sushila Karki, 73, as the interim Prime Minister, days after protests over corruption and social media bans rocked the Himalayan nation. Karki is the first woman to head the country's government. President Ram Chandra Poudel also dissolved Parliament. The country will hold elections on March 5, 2026, to elect the next government and prime minister. Nepal had its last legislative elections in 2022.

Calling Nepal "a close neighbour, a fellow democracy and a long-term development partner", India welcomed the formation of the interim government. As a neighbouring country of India, Nepal has always played a crucial role in India's "neighbourhood first" policy. Therefore, it is important to understand the recent events in Nepal from a broader perspective.

(Relevance: UPSC Syllabus Mains Examination: General Studies-II: India and its neighbourhood– relations. From time to time questions have been asked on India and its neighbouring countries in the UPSC mains examination. These questions covered India's relations with neighbouring nations such as Sri Lanka, Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Pakistan,

China and the Maldives. The focus has been on India's efforts in maintaining peace and stability, as well as addressing challenges stemming from political crises, terrorist activities, and regional security issues in neighbouring countries. In this context, understanding Nepal's Gen Z protest becomes essential.)

What were the reasons behind the recent youth-led 'Gen Z protests' in Nepal?

September 8 and 9 marked two major days in Nepal's modern political history, which saw a Gen Z-led movement against social media bans and corruption that ended up toppling the government after the mostly leaderless protests spilled over into Kathmandu's streets. Some of the reasons behind the Gen Z protests in Nepal were:

1. From Social Media Bans to 'Nepo Baby' Backlash and Stirring Fears Over Remittances

A couple of months ago, some Facebook pages, including one called Next Generation Nepal, began to post on the grim political situation in Nepal and the massive corruption in high places. No specific individuals appeared to be promoting the posts, but it was clear that most of them belonged to a generation that was born between 1996 and 2012, the cohort known as "Generation Z", or 'Gen Z'.

The young people, teens and those in their 20s, expressed their anger and frustration at the corrupt political system — and the immunity that politicians who have run Nepal by turns since the republic was created in 2008 have given themselves from investigation or accountability. The criticism especially targeted the extravagant lifestyles of the children and wards of senior politicians, and expressions like 'Nepo Babies' and 'Nepo Kids' trended online.

A couple of weeks ago, the government banned 26 social media platforms, including prominent ones like Facebook, WhatsApp, Instagram, X, and YouTube, for failing to register with the authorities by a certain deadline. The digital ban took away the primary avenue that Gen Z was using to vent, comment, and seek solidarity among themselves and greatly aggravated their anger.

The frustration boiled over on September 8, when large numbers of young people came out on the streets

in response to a government ban on social media. The **ban ignited fears that speech could be curtailed for Nepal's**



Nepal's Gen Z protests erupted on September 8, with scores of youngsters storming out onto the streets. (Photo credits: AP/PTI)



Protesters stand atop the Singha Durbar, the seat of Nepal's government in Kathmandu, during a protest. (AP Photo/Niranjana Shrestha, ANI)

30 million people and cut off some two million Nepali workers, a major source of remittances, abroad from their families. Nepal's economy is heavily reliant on remittances, which amount to over 33 per cent of Nepal's Gross Domestic Product.

2. Lack of jobs and opportunities

In an article, 'Jobs to inequality to corruption: What lit the fuse in Nepal' in NYT, Bhadra Sharma and Alex Travelli write- "The country's biggest slow-burning crisis centers on jobs. Getting one is a herculean task in Nepal, a mountainous nation of 30 million sandwiched between India and China. According to the Nepal Living Standard Survey published by the National Statistics Office in 2024, the unemployment rate was 12.6 per cent, more than a point higher than it was five years earlier.

Those figures tend to understate the severity of the problem. They represent only participants in the formal economy, leaving out the majority of Nepalis, who work without officially reported jobs, mostly in farming. And the unemployment is heavily concentrated among younger adults who hold out hope for real jobs."

3. High Corruption

The social media ban is emblematic of the larger churn in Nepal. The youth, especially, were increasingly frustrated with the same set of 70-plus leaders, all facing corruption allegations, coming in and out of power since the country became a democratic republic in 2008. In 2024, Nepal was ranked 107 out of 180 countries in Transparency International's corruption rankings.

As The Indian Express has reported earlier, almost all senior leaders in Nepal are under some sort of corruption cloud. It has been a practice since 2006 to grant immunity to politicians against investigation if a "policy decision", which is essentially a decision by the cabinet, is taken to that effect. Thus, scandals, typically involving collusion among elected politicians and supposedly independent officials, feed the resentment of youth.

Thus, the social media ban may have been the immediate trigger that lit the fuse; the protests expanded rapidly into a larger campaign against corruption, inequality and unemployment.

What have been the outcomes of the 'Gen Z protests'?

The GenZ protests have been drastically different from previous waves since they were loosely organised across multiple cities and did not have a single central organising group. All activity was coordinated through social media platforms, including Discord. ABC News Australia reported that the movement was not prepared for a quick outcome.

The GenZ protesters did not put forth any specific demands other than the lifting of the ban on social media, which was fulfilled on the evening of September 8. In more general terms, they sought an end to



Nepal President Ramchandra Paudel administers oath to former Chief Justice, Sushila Karki, as interim Prime Minister of Nepal, in Kathmandu. (Photo: AP)

corruption, social inequality, and the lack of job opportunities.

As the protests intensified, Prime Minister Khadga Prasad Oli resigned on September 9. The President accepted the resignation and also dissolved Parliament. Former Supreme Court Justice Sushila S. Karki was sworn in as Nepal's interim Prime Minister on September 12. The manner of Karki's appointment has generated curiosity, with protesters flocking to the messaging app Discord to cast an informal vote in her favour.

Discord

Discord is an instant messaging platform with VoIP (Voice over Internet Protocol, or simply Internet calling) capabilities, which allows its users to communicate through text messages, voice and video calls, and media sharing. Users may share messages privately through personal messages, or in virtual community chat rooms called "servers", which are accessible through invitation links.

One Discord server with over 100,000 members became the focal point, watched on Nepalese national TV and livestreamed on news sites. Oli's resignation on September 9, as well as the removal of the cabinet, created a void that the citizens were eager to fill, and this server was centre stage to the deliberations that followed.

On September 15, Nepal's Interim Prime Minister Sushila Karki appointed four new ministers to her cabinet, taking its strength to eight. The Nepal constitution provides for a maximum cabinet strength of 25. However, Karki recently suggested that her interim cabinet may have only 11 members. The interim government will run till the next general election scheduled for March 5.

What is the status of India-Nepal relations?

India-Nepal relations are defined by deep-rooted people-to-people links as well as commonalities in religion, language and culture. India and Nepal share a 1,751 km long border (across 5 Indian states: Sikkim, West Bengal, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand).

The age-old civilisational and cultural ties that exist between India and Nepal are exemplified by the people-to-people link between both the countries. Nepal is a priority partner of India under its 'Neighbourhood First' policy. The **India-Nepal Treaty of Peace and Friendship (1950)** is an important foundation of the bilateral relations. The cooperation between India and Nepal can be seen in various sectors.

Cooperation

1. Defence Cooperation: India and Nepal have long-standing and extensive mutually beneficial cooperation in the field of defence and security. India's military connection with the Himalayan country goes back to the reign of Maharaja Ranjit Singh, whose army in Lahore enlisted Nepalese soldiers called Lahure, or soldiers of fortune.

India and Nepal also have the long-standing tradition of awarding the honorary rank of general to each other's army chief. The strong relations between both the armies have been further cemented via the **Gorkha Regiment**. Around 32,000 Gorkha soldiers from Nepal are serving in the Indian Army as of June 2024. Notably, British India raised the first battalion of the Gorkha Regiment as the Nasiri regiment on April 24, 1815.

The Gorkha regiments recruit a large number of troops from Nepal. A citizen of Nepal can take the National Defence

Academy or Combined Defence Services exams and join the Indian Army as an officer. **Exercise Surya Kiran** is the annual joint military exercise between India and Nepal.

2. Connectivity and development partnership: India has a long history of development cooperation commencing from the 1950s onwards. It is the largest developmental donor of Nepal, with the major portion of developmental assistance focused on large-scale infrastructure projects under grants, necessary for the rapid development of Nepal, in the field of priority sectors such as health, education and connectivity. Some of the major projects undertaken and completed with the Government of India grant assistance include Gauchar Airport (presently Tribhuvan Airport) and the East-West Highway.

3. Cooperation in the Power Sector: An important area of cooperation in the India-Nepal bilateral relations is the collaboration in the power sector. This cooperation in the energy sector has been expanded with the commissioning of the **Motihari-Amlekhgunj Petroleum Pipeline (MAPL)** in 2019, which is the first-ever cross-border pipeline in South Asia. The **Joint Vision Statement on Power Sector Cooperation** issued on 2 April 2022 also laid out a comprehensive roadmap for bilateral cooperation in the sector. Significant cooperation in the power sector is already visible, and the export of electricity from Nepal to India reached around 650 MW in 2023.

4. Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief: India has been a long-standing partner of Nepal during emergencies and crisis situations. India was the first responder when a devastating 7.8 magnitude earthquake struck Nepal on 25 April 2015, and India carried out its largest disaster relief operation abroad (**Operation Maitri**). Nepali nationals in conflict zones have been evacuated along with Indian nationals under the Government of India's evacuation efforts under '**Operation Ajay**', '**Operation Ganga**', etc.

5. Economic Cooperation: India is Nepal's largest export destination, receiving an overwhelming 67.9% of its total exports. Nepal's exports mainly constitute edible oil, coffee, tea and jute. Nepal's main imports from India are petroleum products, iron & steel, cereals, vehicles and parts, and machinery parts. There are about 150 Indian ventures operating in Nepal engaged in manufacturing, services (banking, insurance, dry port, education and telecom), the power sector and the tourism industry.

6. Cultural Exchanges: India and Nepal share an organic cultural link. The Nepal-Bharat Library was founded in 1951 in Kathmandu as the first foreign library in Nepal with the objective to enhance and strengthen cultural relations and information exchange between India and Nepal. The B.P. Koirala India-Nepal Foundation was set up in 1991 to foster educational, cultural, scientific and technical cooperation between India and Nepal.

Beyond the wide area of cooperation between both the nations, there also persist some issues of dispute, such as:

1. Territorial Dispute: The dispute over the historical accuracy of a geographical territory is one that has been brewing between the two neighbouring countries for the past several decades now. The bone of contention is about a 372 sq km area that includes **Limpiadhura**, **Lipulekh**, and **Kalapani** at the India-Nepal-China trijunction in Uttarakhand's Pithoragarh district.

The Nepal-India border was delineated by the **Sugauli Treaty of 1816**, under which it renounced all territory to the west of the river Kali, also known as the Mahakali or the Sarada river. The river effectively became the boundary. The terms were reiterated by a second treaty between Nepal and British India in 1923. The rival territorial claims centre on the source of the Kali.

Nepal's case is that the river originates from a stream at Limpiyadhura, north-west of Lipu Lekh. Thus, Kalapani, Limpiyadhura, and Lipu Lekh fall to the east of the river and are part of Nepal's Far West province in the district of Dharchula.

New Delhi's position is that the Kali originates in springs well below the pass, and that while the Treaty does not demarcate the area north of these springs, administrative and revenue records going back to the nineteenth century show that Kalapani was on the Indian side, and counted as part of Pithoragarh district, now in Uttarakhand. Both sides have their own British-era maps as proof of their positions.



The Anglo-nepalese war came to an end with the signing of the Sugauli treaty. The treaty delimited the boundaries of Nepal, as it stands today. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

2. India-China-Nepal: Since the 1962 war with China, India has deployed

the Indo-Tibetan Border Police at Kalapani, which is advantageously located at a height of over 20,000 ft and serves as an observation post for that area. Nepal calls it an encroachment by the Indian security forces. Nepal has also been unhappy about the China-India trading post at Lipu Lekh, the earliest to be established between the two countries. Shipkila in Himachal followed two years later, and Nathu La only in 2006.

3. Madhesi Protest: India's tacit support for a blockade of the landlocked country during protests over the new Constitution in Nepal by the Madhesi community was an inflection point in the relationship.

4. Big Brother Syndrome: Indo-Nepalese relations have a history of highs and lows, with India offering patronage and Nepal resenting it – a sort of 'big brother and small neighbour syndrome'.

At the same time, the neighbours are bound intimately by civilisation, culture, religion, and interdependence dictated by geography.

In the context of recent protests, what should be India's policy towards Nepal?

In the backdrop of Nepal's Gen Z protest and its outcome, a natural question has arisen: what should be India's policy toward Nepal now? To develop not only a comprehensive but also a balanced approach to this question, **we need to understand two different sides of the debate on this topic.**

India must reset Nepal Policy

Constantino Xavier writes- "Nepal's political revolution this week reminds us that, more than any foreign hands, the recent crises in South Asia are symptoms of a massive economic, demographic, and political churning across the region.

India will have to deal with this turmoil, not only by defensively minimising risks but also by actively supporting the transformation of its neighbouring countries. It has done so in Sri Lanka, after its worst financial crisis in 2021. It promises to re-engage with a new leadership in Bangladesh after the elections in 2026. Until then, India must focus all its attention on supporting a crucial transition towards a new, more democratic and developed Nepal...

Prime Minister K P Sharma Oli's resignation marks the end of a generation of leaders who have worked both with and against India through every possible constellation and coalition since 2006. Oli's last incarnation turned out to be

particularly difficult for New Delhi.

Thus it marks a turning point also for India-Nepal relations... While it remains unclear who will lead the transition and in what direction, the current context offers an overall opportunity for India to reset its Nepal policy. As it did in the past, whether in 1951, 1990, or 2006, New Delhi can facilitate another step towards the dream of a stable Nepal through a more federal democracy and inclusive development.

To achieve this, India will have to deploy the power of its diplomacy coupled with much political tact to both understand and cater to the aspirations of a new generation of Nepali leaders. Five challenges stand out.

First, India must deepen its engagement with a new generation of Nepali leaders, both within but also beyond the traditional big parties.

Second, India will have to resist the temptation to equate state stability with political personalities.

Third, India will have to show much tact and sensibility to engage with Nepal without being seen to interfere in Nepal. This is a tough task: Since 1947, India has always been perceived by its smaller neighbours as a regional hegemon, an elephant that is capable of both productive and destructive effects, whether through the power of intervention or inaction.

Four, and most important: India will have to double down on economic interdependence with Nepal. As seen in Sri Lanka or Bangladesh, political transitions are usually harbingers of economic slowdown: Whoever takes power in Kathmandu in the next few weeks will be in dire need of financial assistance to keep the economy running and to buy themselves time on the political street. Yet, New Delhi should see this as an opportunity to accelerate its successful connectivity strategy with Kathmandu. For the last few years, India has been able to deliver more, faster, and better support to Nepal's development aspirations.

Beyond the political, it is this delivery-oriented economic dimension in India's Nepal policy that will eventually bring the biggest dividends for both sides. Nepal's ambitions to become a middle-income country rely on more, not less, Indian trade and investments.

To make the relationship truly "special," as leaders on both sides like to profess, India will have to prove its mettle as a reliable partner to provide Nepal with multiple solutions across the technology and digital domains; the transportation, energy, and climate sectors; and the health and education systems."

First, peace on the streets

Manjeev Puri writes- "Nepal has been on the boil the past few days with the protesting youth showing signs of mobocracy, humiliating senior politicians with acts of violence, and torching government buildings. For Prime Minister K P Sharma Oli, who appeared invincible only a few days ago, there was little choice but to resign and be whisked away to a safe place by the armed forces.

What next? First, peace needs to be restored on the streets. Balen Shah and other young leaders have appealed for this, as did the Army Chief of Nepal, and the protesters seem to be paying heed, with some people even participating in street clean-ups. The Army has enforced a light curfew and brought major political leaders to the cantonment. It will surely play a critical role in the coming days — they have to restore law and order, but without heavy-handedness.

A default position in Nepali politics is directing ire towards India. In the context of the protesters' violence, suggestions are being made that the instigators were monarchists, and some have hinted at Indian involvement. New Delhi has rightly issued an appeal for peace in Nepal and underlined the importance of stability, peace, and prosperity

in the country.

Nepal needs political leadership, and this must have representation from the youth....Stability in the country should be of utmost importance to its people. That is also critical for India, given its historical ties with Nepal and its people.”

Express View: Quake in Nepal

“This is not the first time in the recent past that youth-led movements have toppled regimes in India’s neighbourhood. Last year in Bangladesh, anti-quota protests snowballed into a full-fledged anti-government uprising that ended Sheikh Hasina’s 15-year rule. In Sri Lanka, in 2022, corruption and economic mismanagement that led to soaring inflation and acute food and fuel shortages sparked a revolt that brought down the Rajapaksa family. India should continue to monitor the situation in its neighbourhood and remain vigilant.

In the wake of the turmoil in Nepal, New Delhi should keep a close watch on how the political situation in the country unravels. It should be alert to a Bangladesh-like regime change and be ready to safeguard India’s interests amid the flux.”

Post Read Questions

Prelims

(1) Consider the following statements: (UPSC CSE 2020)

1. The value of Indo-Sri Lanka trade has consistently increased in the last decade.
2. “Textile and textile articles” constitute an important item of trade between India and Bangladesh.
3. In the last five years, Nepal has been the largest trading partner of India in South Asia.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

2. Consider the following pairs: (UPSC CSE 2016)

	Community sometimes mentioned in the news	In the affairs of
1.	Kurd	Bangladesh
2.	Madhesi	Nepal
3.	Rohingya	Myanmar

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 3 only

3. Kalapani, Lipulekh and Limpiyadhura are the disputed territories between:

- (a) India and Bhutan
- (b) China and Nepal
- (c) India and China
- (d) India and Nepal

Mains

What is the significance of the India-Nepal relationship? Discuss the key difficulties and prospects in the India-Nepal border dispute.

Prelims Answer Key

1. (b) 2. (c) 3. (d)

(**Sources:** www.mea.gov.in, Nepal PM selected via Discord, What led to the ‘GenZ’ agitation, In Nepal’s remittance-dependent economy, why the social media ban ended up having an outsized impact, India’s military ties with Nepal, Significance of Lipulekh for India, Protests against India in Nepal: The big brother syndrome?, First, peace on the streets, India must reset Nepal Policy, Express View: Quake in Nepal)

EXPRESS EDGE

History & Culture

How Hindu temples survived political upheavals and philosophical shifts

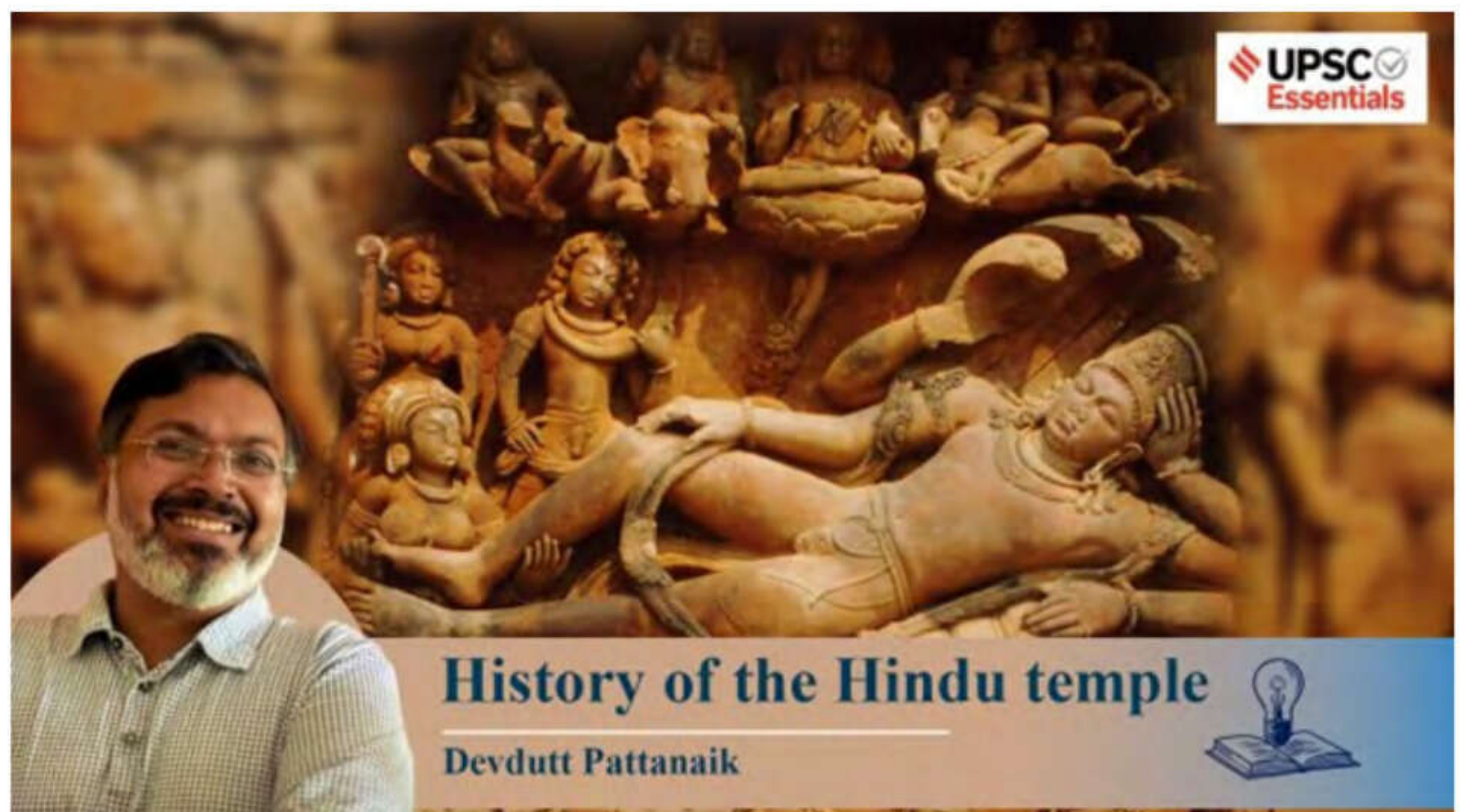
It was only around 2,000 years ago that we began to see the first sculptures of Hindu gods in Mathura. But Hindu temples have not remained static for millennia, and have evolved over time to adapt to all kinds of challenges and shifts in philosophies.

Written by **Devdutt Pattanaik**

The Hindu temple, as we know it today, is not 5,000 years old. In the earliest times, people did not worship their deities in enclosed sanctuaries or with sculpted images. Instead, the divine was experienced directly in nature – trees, animals, rivers, mountains, and rocks all served as sacred forms.

It was only around 2,000 years ago that we began to see the first sculptures of Hindu gods in Mathura. Interestingly,

images of Shiva, Vishnu, and the Goddess also appear on Kushan coins from the same period, though scholars debate whether these are truly Hindu deities or representations shaped by Zoroastrian and Greek influences.



*At Deogarh near Jhansi, we find one of the earliest Vishnu temples made entirely of stone.
(Wikimedia Commons)*

From nature worship to image worship

By about 1,800 years ago, around 200 AD, Mathura sandstone sculptures clearly show Hindu deities in recognisable forms. Here we see Shivalingas, sometimes with faces carved on them (Mukhalingas), as well as images of Vishnu, Krishna, and Balarama. These were not yet housed inside temples as we know them. Instead, they were placed in sacred groves, often near rivers, and worshipped in open spaces, much like earlier natural shrines. This phase shows us the gradual transition from nature worship to image worship.

The next step was to enclose these images within structures. At Bhitargaon in Uttar Pradesh, dating to around 500 AD, we find a brick temple where images were placed inside a sanctum. At Nachna in Madhya Pradesh, a Shiva temple was built that attempted to replicate the ecosystem of the Himalayas—its roof shaped like a mountain, and river goddesses Ganga and Yamuna carved at the doorway.

At Deogarh near Jhansi, we find one of the earliest Vishnu temples made entirely of stone. The temple features iconic images of Vishnu reclining on the serpent Ananta, and Vishnu riding Garuda with four arms, panels from the life of Rama and Krishna. These are the beginnings of classical temple architecture.

Rock-cut and freestanding temples

This phase was followed by the era of monumental rock-cut temples after 600 AD. Here, the art became truly gigantic. The caves of Ellora and Elephanta, the temples of Pattadakal in Karnataka, and the rock-cut carvings of the Shore Temple at Mamallapuram near Chennai all showcase grand depictions of Shiva and Vishnu. These were not just places of worship but also declarations of royal power, carved directly into mountains and cliffs, as if to demonstrate that kings could shape the very earth.

By the 8th century, we see even more ambitious projects. At Ellora, the Kailasanath Temple was carved out of a single rock to resemble a mountain palace for Shiva. This period also gave rise to freestanding temples, built stone by stone rather than carved from rock. These appear in Hampi and Pattadakal in Karnataka, as well as in Kanchipuram, home to the famous Kailasanath Temple.

The freestanding temple marks the shift from experimental forms to enduring architectural styles. By the 10th century, temple architecture exploded in complexity: curvilinear ‘nagara’ styles of the north, and pyramidal ‘vimana’ style of the south. Temples were built on Tantric mandalas, functioning not only as houses of gods but as centres of ritual power. Within them, priests performed Tantric rites to attract wealth, protection, and fortune.

These early temples were very different from the devotional shrines most of us are familiar with today. They were closer to ritual laboratories, where geometry, art, and mantra combined to create zones of cosmic energy.

How temples survived change and invasions

Later, with the rise of the Bhakti movement, temples changed once again. The focus moved from secret Tantric rituals to public participation. People were encouraged to sing, dance, and actively worship. This is when great Vaishnava temples such as Jagannath in Puri and Srirangam in Tamil Nadu became popular. Here, the temple became the people’s house of God.

Contrary to popular belief, many temples were built in India in the centuries immediately after the attack on the Somnath temple by Mahmud of Ghazni in the 11th century. The famous Khajuraho temple complex, for example, was built in the 11th century. It was later abandoned when the trade route shifted. The Lingaraj temple complex of Bhubaneswar was also built around this time. Mansingh, Akbar’s Rajput general, built the Govindraj temple at Vrindavan in the 16th century. It was later vandalised by Aurangzeb in the 17th century.

When Muslim warlords did attack temples, people often shifted to small portable images of deities housed in private homes or relocated to safe haveli-style residences in Rajasthan. In Bengal, during the 17th century, new terracotta temples dedicated to Krishna appeared, reflecting both local artistic traditions and devotional needs.

A fresh wave of temple construction came with the decline of the Mughal Empire and the rise of the Marathas. Leaders such as the Bhonsles and the Holkars built Hindu temples, especially dedicated to Rama, in places like Nashik, Gwalior and Kashi.

Thus, the Hindu temple has not remained static for millennia. It has constantly evolved and survived all kinds of challenges and shifts in philosophies.

Post read questions

- 1. In the earliest times, how was the divine experienced before the emergence of enclosed sanctuaries and sculpted images?**
- 2. How did the transition from nature worship to image worship shape early Hindu religious practice?**
- 3. How did temples change with the rise of the Bhakti movement?**
- 4. While the freestanding temple marked the shift from experimental forms to enduring architectural styles, what other major architectural styles emerged in later centuries?**
- 5. Hindu temples have not remained static for millennia, and have constantly evolved and survived all kinds of challenges and shifts in philosophies. Elaborate.**

(Devdutt Pattanaik is a renowned mythologist who writes on art, culture and heritage.)

Why Vivekananda's Chicago speech marked India's first moral presence in global discourse

Digvijay Divas, observed annually to mark Swami Vivekananda's historic speech at the World Parliament of Religions in Chicago on September 11, 1893, provides an occasion to reflect on the enduring relevance of his ideas for rethinking India's engagement with the conflict-ridden world.

Written by **Dileep P Chandran**

As India aspires to become a leading player in an increasingly volatile global order, while simultaneously grappling with issues like communalism, social and economic inequalities, and ethnic clashes, Vivekananda's teachings offer a lens through which to revisit the foundational questions of national unity, tolerance, and universal humanism.

Digvijay Divas, observed annually to mark Swami Vivekananda's historic speech at the World Parliament of

Religions in Chicago on September 11, 1893, provides an occasion to reflect on the enduring relevance of his ideas for rethinking India's engagement with the conflict-ridden world.

Sharing the speech, Prime Minister Narendra Modi wrote on X, "This speech by Swami Vivekananda, delivered in Chicago on this day in 1893, is widely regarded as a watershed moment."

Vivekananda's speech at Chicago was not just a spiritual call for tolerance and mutual respect, but had a profound impact on national imagination, politics, education, and international relations as well.

Spiritual inclusivity and universality of divine

Beginning with the historic salutation, "Sisters and Brothers of America", Vivekananda, in his first address at the World Parliament of Religions, articulated his belief in a universal religion and affirmed all religions as true. Tolerance and universal acceptance were two predominant themes in his speeches.

He asserted that Hinduism, as the 'mother of religions', had taught the world the principle of tolerance and highlighted



Swami Vivekananda at the Parliament of World's Religions in Chicago in September 1893. (Image source: Wikimedia Commons)

India's long tradition of providing shelter to refugees and the persecuted of all religions and nations.

But Vivekananda also warned the world that sectarianism, bigotry, and fanaticism would fill the earth with violence and despair, undermining the progress of civilisations. He argued that holiness, purity, and charity are not the exclusive possessions of any church. To affirm his convictions in the unity of religions, Vivekananda recited passages from the Gita that emphasise the spiritual inclusivity and universality of the divine.

Champion of India's spiritual regeneration

Vivekananda was hailed as the great champion of India's spiritual regeneration following his historic speech in Chicago and the subsequent three years of lectures and teachings abroad. His call for spiritual unity gave vital momentum to the idea of spiritual nationalism in the early phase of India's national movement.

In another speech at the World Parliament of Religions on September 19, 1893, Vivekananda said, "unity in variety is the plan of nature, and the Hindu has recognised it." He categorically stated that persecution and intolerance would have no place in polity.

Being one of the first exponents of spiritual nationalism, Vivekananda instilled in the masses a sense of national pride in India's ancient civilisation while envisioning a spiritual oneness. His works aimed at national awakening and Hindu self-formation without undermining the unity that transcends boundaries. He prioritised service to the poor over preaching of religion, and envisioned the youth – endowed with physical strength and moral vigour – as the torchbearers of nation's reawakening.

An architect of modern Indian nation

Vivekananda proclaimed that all divisions are illusory and unreal. He taught that the inherent unity of mankind was the essence of the highest spiritual Truth that he had realised. He proposed spiritual oneness as solution to the material hardships of the colonised. As a monist, Vivekananda believed in the inner unity of human beings and sought to awaken their dormant spirit.

As an exponent of practical Vedanta, he prioritised selfless service over any social divisions that often lead to social conflicts. He constantly reminded the masses that brotherhood should define human relationships within the nation. The lower castes, poor, illiterate, ignorant, as well as cobblers and sweepers, he insisted, are bound by the spirit of brotherhood in India.

In addition to the moral upliftment of Indians, Vivekananda also emphasised the physical well-being of the downtrodden. For this reason, he is hailed both as an architect of the modern Indian nation and a torchbearer of national integration.

Issues like communalism, regionalism, caste discrimination, and sub-nationalism, which pose threat to national integration, can be fundamentally addressed at their root if one grasps the essence of Vivekananda's teachings which is built on the idea of spiritual oneness. This vision of natural human unity that extends beyond the nation lays the foundations for the Indian version of internationalism and universal humanism.

What Nehru says about Vivekananda's nationalism

Notably, Vivekananda's celebrated address at the World Parliament of Religions in Chicago is often considered India's first moral presence in global discourses. Throughout his series of lectures, he asserted the long legacy of India in assimilating diverse cultures across the world and thereby called for spiritual harmony and tolerance. He categorically affirmed that India had always been a land of refuge to persecuted religions, irrespective of their national identities. In

his historic speech, Vivekananda declared:

“I am proud to tell you that we have gathered in our bosom the purest remnant of the Israelites, who came to Southern India and took refuge with us in the very year in which their holy temple was shattered to pieces by Roman tyranny. I am proud to belong to the religion which has sheltered and is still fostering the remnant of the grand Zoroastrian nation.”

As Jawaharlal Nehru once observed, Vivekananda’s kind of nationalism naturally evolved into Indian nationalism, which was inseparable from internationalism. Vivekananda offered the world assimilation over destruction, harmony and peace over dissension, and service over conflict. Renunciation and service constituted the core of his national ideal.

Vivekananda’s historic messages enable India to assert a significant presence in global dialogues. Like Gandhi and Buddha, he may be projected as a symbol of India’s global identity, as a messenger of peace and harmony, while his teachings at the World Parliament of Religions could also constitute one of the foundations of India’s foreign policy principles.

Reclaiming Vivekananda’s historic teachings

To sum up, Vivekananda’s teachings on ethics, unity, service, and harmony remain profoundly relevant to address contemporary challenges like global conflicts, religious rivalries, and regional divides. His spiritual and political ideas continue to inspire national unity and global harmony.

Transcending the religious and national boundaries, his thought was catholic and tolerant in spirit and sought to discover the fundamental unity of nations and explore the universality of religions. These historic teachings can strengthen India’s national integration and help it reaffirm its leading role as torchbearer of universal moral principles like humanism and peaceful dialogue in a volatile global order.

Indeed, Vivekananda’s messages and teachings have enduring value for human progress, international dialogues, and the pursuit of world peace.

Post read questions

- 1. How did Vivekananda’s Chicago address shape India’s moral and cultural presence in global discourse?**
- 2. Why did Vivekananda place such importance on the role of youth in national reawakening?**
- 3. In what ways did Vivekananda’s concept of “spiritual nationalism” contribute to the shaping of India’s freedom movement?**
- 4. How did his emphasis on service and renunciation differ from other strands of nationalism emerging in colonial India?**
- 5. How did Vivekananda’s message transcend the boundaries of religion and nation to articulate a vision of universal humanism?**

(Dileep P Chandran is an Assistant Professor at the Department of Political Science in P M Government College, Chalakudy, Kerala.)

International Relations

Why UNSC often mirrors geopolitical divides rather than global consensus

As the UN celebrates its 80th anniversary, it inspires both pride and doubt. It is still the only organisation with near-universal membership, and remains valuable for diplomacy, especially for smaller states. But why is there a growing sense that the global body is facing a legitimacy crisis? How does this flag the urgency for reforms?

Written by **Ajay Darshan Behera**

When the United Nations (UN) convenes on September 9 in New York for its 80th General Assembly, it will be more than a ritual. It will call attention to how much the organisation has influenced world politics, and how much it now struggles to remain relevant.

Established in 1945 after the Second World War, the UN was designed to replace the failed League of Nations. The League had collapsed in the

1930s after proving powerless to prevent aggression by Japan, Italy, and Germany. The reason for its failure was its lack of enforcement and the reluctance of great powers to be committed to its regulations.

Resolving not to allow that failure to be repeated, the founders of the UN created a more powerful organisation. They gave it universal membership, wider powers, and a Security Council with actual clout. By granting veto rights to the five permanent members – the United States, the Soviet Union (now Russia), Britain, France, and China – they hoped to keep the major powers engaged and prevent the new organisation from suffering the same fate as the League.



The true test for the UN is if it can overcome its shortcomings and reflect the world as it is today, rather than as it appeared in 1945. (Reuters)

Promise and power games

Liberal scholars have long characterised the UN as a bold experiment in cooperation. Institutions, in their view, can ease mistrust, establish rules, and provide states a framework for dialogue. Occasionally, the UN has lived up to this promise. It has organised peacekeeping missions, dispensed humanitarian aid, and given smaller nations a platform

where their voices were heard.

There is evidence to support such optimism. UN agencies have worked on global health, food security, and refugee crises. Peacekeepers have kept conflicts in check before they spread. The General Assembly, however symbolically, has provided smaller states with the opportunity to shape debates. For liberals, even this imperfect exchange represents an advance, proof that dialogue can temper rivalry.

Realists, however, view it differently. For them, the UN is not a forum of justice but an expression of power. The veto given to the five permanent members keeps major powers at the centre while tying the organisation to their rivalries. During the Cold War, Washington and Moscow paralysed the Council. Nowadays, Russia and China veto action to defend their allies, and so does the US for Israel. From Ukraine to Gaza to Taiwan, the Security Council often mirrors geopolitical divides rather than global consensus.

The realists are not worried about this. States, they maintain, act in their interests, not morality. They will invoke the UN when it suits them and circumvent it when it does not. The US invasion of Iraq in 2003, undertaken without Security Council endorsement, and the North Atlantic Treaty Organization's campaign in Kosovo in 1999, launched without UN authorisation, serve as grim reminders that when power and principle clash, power usually prevails.

A view from the Global South

To most in the Global South, the UN has never delivered on its promise of equality. The Charter spoke of equal sovereignty, but in reality, the system has continued to be lopsided. Africa, Latin America, and South Asia are still underrepresented in the Security Council. No African or Latin American state has a permanent seat, and India – the biggest democracy in the world – is still outside the inner circle. Decisions are still shaped largely by the same powers that designed the system in 1945.

This imbalance is not merely one of numbers. Constructivist thinkers remind us that it is also about whose histories, identities, and voices are treated as legitimate in shaping global rules. When weaker states are subjected to intervention while stronger ones are shielded, the South perceives this as hypocrisy. Some wars are condemned, others ignored. Some human rights abuses are pursued relentlessly, while others are quietly forgotten.

The impact of all this has been corrosive. The selective application of norms has discredited and weakened the UN's moral authority. For most of the Global South, calling for reform is not merely about securing seats or votes. It is about recognition – being recognised as rule-makers, not just rule-takers.

As the UN celebrates its 80th anniversary, the question is whether it can adapt to this demand. If it fails, countries from Asia, Africa, and Latin America will turn to alternatives like BRICS and the African Union to make their voices heard.

Multilateralism in retreat

The marginalisation of the UN is a symptom of a broader shift in world politics. Power is not confined to one centre any more. The new forums, such as the G20, BRICS, SCO and other regional groupings, provide meaningful avenues for negotiation. Bilateral arrangements or loose coalitions are normally the preference of the great powers, particularly when issues of international crises, whether it is the war in Ukraine or Gaza or the South China Sea, become too contentious for the UN to manage.

Realists see nothing unusual in this. Institutions, they maintain, are instruments of states. When convenient, they are accepted; when inconvenient, they are ignored. Liberals take a more cautious view, warning that this trend undermines cooperation and makes crises harder to resolve. Constructivists introduce a complicating factor: legitimacy. If nations cease to regard the UN as equitable or representative, they will channel their efforts into other forums.

At the heart of this decline is the veto. Its defenders argue that it avoids confrontation between great powers. Its critics argue, in return, that it paralyses the Council and causes delay in facing up to pressing crises. In practice, it has too often eroded trust in collective security.

Decades of debates on UN reforms have led nowhere. Proposals to include India, Brazil, South Africa, or others as permanent members fall on deaf ears. The permanent five jealously guard their privileges, keeping the UN's structure frozen in 1945 while the world has changed dramatically.

Balance sheet and future prospects

For all its shortcomings, the UN has made a difference. Its agencies have vaccinated millions, rebuilt societies shattered by war, and helped develop a corpus of international law. It has provided a stage where debates could replace confrontation, and where small states, often voiceless elsewhere, could speak as equals.

Yet the record is inconsistent. The UN failed to prevent the genocides in Rwanda and Srebrenica. It stood by during the invasion of Iraq and the destruction of Syria. Efforts to reform its structure have gone nowhere. Each time a major power bypasses it, the organisation's credibility weakens further.

Looking at the future, one can think of three possibilities. One, the UN continues as it is – flawed but functional. It will continue to provide aid, monitor human rights, and serve as a forum for dialogue, though it will remain weak in addressing major crises. Two, it could decline further, sidelined by regional groupings and ad-hoc coalitions, leaving global governance fragmented and leaderless.

Three, though least likely, is meaningful reform: expanding the Security Council, constraining the veto, and increasing the representation of the Global South. Such a change would make the UN more representative, but it would require the permanent five to surrender privileges, something history shows they rarely do.

After eight decades, the UN inspires both pride and doubt. It is still the only organisation with near-universal membership, and it remains valuable for diplomacy, especially for smaller states. But without reform, it risks sliding into irrelevance. For the Global South, the stakes are high. They view the UN not only as an arena of power but as one of the few forums where they can press for a more equitable order.

UN's true test: Keeping pace with reality

To sum up, the UN in its 80th year is a symbol of hope and also a reflection of power politics. It embodies the dream of collective security, yet it also reflects the persistent reality of state rivalry. Its track record is neither glorious nor insignificant. It is a story of partial successes and deep frustrations.

The coming General Assembly meeting will not resolve these contradictions. But it can remind the world that abandoning the UN is not an option. In an era of global pandemics, climate change, and economic shocks, no single power or small group can manage alone. The UN is still the sole organisation with universal membership and universal legitimacy, however imperfect.

The true test will be if it can overcome its shortcomings and reflect the world as it is today, rather than as it appeared in 1945. If it fails to do so, its eightieth anniversary might be remembered less as a tribute to resilience and more as the moment the world realised that the UN's promise is slipping away.

Post read questions

- 1. From Ukraine to Gaza to Taiwan, the UN Security Council often mirrors geopolitical divides rather than global consensus. Do you agree? Support your answer with examples.**
- 2. Liberal scholars have long characterised the United Nations as a bold experiment in cooperation, while realists see it as not a forum of justice but as an expression of power. Evaluate.**
- 3. For most of the Global South, calling for Security Council reform is not merely about securing seats or votes. It is about recognition – being recognised as rule-makers, not just rule-takers. Comment.**
- 4. The reform process in the United Nations remains unresolved, because of the delicate imbalance of East and West and entanglement of the USA vs. Russo-Chinese alliance. Examine and critically evaluate the East-West policy confrontations in this regard.**
- 5. The Global South views the UN not only as an arena of power but as one of the few forums where they can press for a more equitable order. How does this flag the urgency for UN reforms?**

(The author is a Professor at MMAJ Academy of International Studies, Jamia Millia Islamia, New Delhi.)

Could focus on Russia derail progress on EU's new India strategy?

At its core, the EU's new India strategy is based on five pillars, including trade, the green transition, and connectivity. But could linking it to issues like India's oil purchases from Russia risk jeopardising not just the potential trade agreement but also many promising initiatives outlined in the otherwise well-thought-out strategy?

Written by **Gulshan Sachdeva**

A few days ago, the European Commission unveiled a new strategy to strengthen trade, investment, technology, defence, connectivity, and its global partnership with India. While announcing its India strategy on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's birthday, European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen stated, "With this, we are taking the partnership to the next level."



In an uncertain global trade environment, India and the EU have also committed to concluding their trade deal by the end of this year. (File)

Prime Minister Modi welcomed the European Union's (EU) move, calling it a "shared commitment, shared goal, and shared responsibility."

Although the EU's new strategy builds on its 2018 India strategy and the substantial progress since 2004, when India and the EU established their Strategic Partnership, the timing of the announcement is particularly significant. India's relations with the United States are facing difficulties, positive developments are emerging in India-China ties, and negotiations on the Ukraine war are at a crucial stage.

In an uncertain global trade environment, India and the EU have also committed to concluding their trade deal by the end of this year. They plan to hold a summit early next year and announce a new roadmap after the expiry of the current Roadmap 2025. So, the issues outlined in the strategy paper clearly point to the future direction of EU-India relations.

New momentum in India-EU ties

Since the 13th EU-India Summit in 2016, which took place after a gap of few years, there has been a new momentum in India-EU ties. The *Agenda for Action 2020* and *Roadmap 2025* have been adopted. Several visits by Prime Minister Modi to European capitals, the Indo-French Rafale deal, new strategic partnerships with Italy, Greece, and Poland,

India–Nordic summits, the establishment of the Connectivity Partnership, and the Trade and Technology Council (TTC) have all deepened India’s strategic engagement with the EU.

Prime Minister Modi’s virtual meeting with all 27 EU leaders in 2021, and the recent visit of the European Commission President accompanied by more than 20 Commissioners, further underscore the importance of this partnership. This despite the fact that Indian and European perceptions about the Ukraine war differ significantly.

The EU’s 2018 India strategy had already acknowledged India’s impressive economic growth and modernisation, its engagement with diverse partners, and its important geopolitical role. The 2025 strategy welcomes India’s rise as a global power, considers it a vital partner, and asserts that “India’s success benefits the EU, just as the EU’s success benefits India.”

Five pillars of EU’s new India strategy

It also considers India a key stakeholder in multilateralism and global governance. While they may not align on every issue, both are pluralistic democracies committed to strategic autonomy, economic resilience, international stability, and a rules-based international order.

The strategy proposes a new EU–India strategic agenda based on five pillars:

- The first, the Prosperity and Sustainability pillar, focuses on trade, investment, and the clean energy transition.
- The second, the Technology and Innovation pillar, supports digitisation, critical emerging technologies, and research cooperation.
- The third, the Security and Defence pillar, aims to deepen security engagements and defence industrial cooperation. The Connectivity and Global Issues pillar emphasises effective global governance, strengthening connectivity, and promoting cooperation in third countries.
- The fifth pillar focuses on enabling the other four by promoting mobility, skill development, and mutual understanding.

As the core of the India–EU partnership is economic, the strategy’s primary focus is on the first and second pillars. Last year, bilateral trade in goods and services was close to \$200 billion. Cumulative EU FDI inflows into India reached EUR 140 billion in 2023, with around 6,000 EU companies operating in the country.

Similarly, Indian companies are making significant investments and acquisitions in EU markets. With considerable untapped potential, both sides aim to conclude Free Trade Agreement (FTA) negotiations by the end of 2025. They have engaged in trade and investment negotiations for years, marked by alternating phases of optimism and stalled progress. Since 2022, both sides have been negotiating three separate deals covering trade, investment, and geographical indications.

Why negotiations remain challenging

In the current phase, shifting global and Asian geopolitics, along with the weaponisation of tariffs under the Trump administration, are pushing both sides toward greater compromises to finally seal the deal. India’s recent agreements with Australia, the EFTA countries, and the UK also provide useful templates.

Yet, negotiations remain challenging. Both the EU and India are tough bargainers, and several critical issues still need resolution. While both sides express growing optimism, caution remains, as issues related to mobility and the EU’s

carbon tax could pose challenges.

The strategy outlines numerous bilateral initiatives to support the EU's 2050 and India's 2070 net-zero commitments, particularly in renewables and the circular economy. Cooperation is also expected in economic security, with a focus on critical minerals and the semiconductor sector. Collaboration on Digital Public Infrastructure projects, including their extension to third countries, is explicitly mentioned.

To enhance Defence Industrial cooperation, an industry-led EU–India Defence Industry Forum is proposed. Connectivity initiatives are aligned with the EU's Global Gateway and India's MAHASAGAR initiative. The India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) is emerging as a flagship example of collaboration.

Russia focus risks derailing EU's India strategy

A significant portion of the strategy is also devoted to promoting cooperation in third countries through existing multilateral initiatives and triangular projects. It also proposes strengthening institutional mechanisms via new dialogues in areas such as agri-food policy, aviation, energy import diversification, education and skills, oceans and fisheries, and space. Currently, more than forty dialogues are already active across a wide range of areas.

The EU has been, and will remain, a key partner in India's ambitious modernisation journey – through trade, investment, and technology. At the same time, India's large and growing economy, with several globally competitive sectors, holds strong appeal for Europe. Despite these convergences, an excessive focus on the Ukraine war and Russia by some within the EU risks derailing promising proposals outlined in the strategy.

Recent comments by EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas on India's purchase of Russian oil and its participation in military exercises have already drawn a strong reaction from New Delhi. Linking such issues to the potential trade deal could jeopardize not just the agreement itself but also many other promising initiatives contained in the otherwise well-thought-out strategy.

Post read questions

- 1. The EU's new India strategy asserts that "India's success benefits the EU, just as the EU's success benefits India." Comment.**
- 2. The European Union's new India strategy is based on five pillars. As the core of the India–EU partnership is economic, the new strategy primarily focuses on which pillars?**
- 3. India and the European Union have engaged in trade and investment negotiations for years, marked by alternating phases of optimism and stalled progress. Analyse the factors driving the two sides towards greater compromises to finally seal the deal.**
- 4. Evaluate the thorny issues in the negotiations over India-EU Free Trade Agreement.**
- 5. Could linking the EU's new strategy to India's oil purchases from Russia risk jeopardising not just the agreement but also many promising initiatives outlined in the otherwise well-thought-out strategy?**

(Gulshan Sachdeva is Professor at the Centre for European Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University and Chief Coordinator, DAKSHIN – Global South Centre of Excellence, RIS at New Delhi.)

Environment & Ecology

Cleaner air, longer lives: What does science say?

Written by **Arunangshu Das**

In a recent study on air pollution, two participants, Monu and Aamya from New Delhi, were equipped with air sampling filters for monitoring air quality in their daily environments. While Aamya is from an affluent background, Monu comes from an underserved community. At the end of the study, Monu's filter was visibly much darker than Aamya's. The study showed that poverty disproportionately increases the exposure level of air pollution.



Air pollution has emerged as a subject of inquiry in all disciplines. (Source: Freepik)

In a different context, Ella Kissi-Debrah, a bright nine-year-old from suburban Britain, died due to her 27th asthma attack triggered by pollution. She used to live near a notoriously congested and polluted roadway. She had her first attack at the age of seven.

Scientists emphasise that personal stories like Ella's resonate more deeply than statistics, helping to expose the human toll of air pollution. Similar accounts of Kristina from Utah and Monu and Aamya have drawn sympathy, yet the conflict between development and clean air persists. But what does science say about the causal relation between air pollution and life expectancy?

How do we know air pollution truly causes harm?

Air pollution is as old as fire itself. Early humans likely suffered from smoke in enclosed and poorly ventilated caves, though its causes were not understood. As the society evolved and experienced the process of modernisation, there emerged organised political system and then there was the industrial revolution (1750-1914). But the industrial revolution also caused widespread air pollution.

For many profit-seekers, however, air pollution was viewed as a natural consequence of wealth generation and often termed as "smells like money to me". Official recognition came much later. The US enacted the Air Pollution Control Act (1955), the Clean Air Act (1963), and the Air Quality Act (1967). The UK introduced its Clean Air Act in 1956 and established a national monitoring system by 1961.

In 1970, the US strengthened these efforts by creating the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) and setting national air quality standards. India followed with the Air (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act of 1981, which created pollution control boards to regulate emissions.

Communities and policymakers often ask how we know that air pollution truly causes harm – a question that science needs to answer carefully. Epidemiology provides this evidence by collecting data, designing observational studies, and applying statistical analysis to link exposures with health outcomes. Since direct experiments on humans are impossible, researchers rely on health data collected during naturally occurring pollution events, such as temperature inversions that trap pollutants in the air.

Cross-sectional studies, for instance, offer a snapshot of disease burden at a given point in time. Outcomes of interest are typically modelled using generalised linear models: logistic regression for binary outcomes (yielding odds ratios) or linear models for continuous outcomes (yielding mean differences). However, such studies cannot determine whether exposure preceded disease.

Air pollution and increased mortality risk

The foundation for regulatory monitoring of air pollution was laid by the Harvard Six Cities Study, a long-term cohort investigation that followed participants over time. Using survival analysis, it demonstrated that chronic exposure to air pollution was strongly associated with mortality from lung cancer and cardiopulmonary diseases.

Case-control studies, in contrast, begin with individuals who already have a disease (cases) and compare them with those who do not (controls), looking retrospectively at prior exposures. To reduce bias, cases and controls must come from comparable backgrounds. While such studies demonstrate statistical associations, they still fall short of establishing causality.

Case-crossover studies examine health outcomes during pollution events, such as temperature inversions, by comparing individuals' exposure in a "hazard period" (just before death or hospitalisation) with their exposure during control periods when there is no pollution. This within-person design eliminates confounding from fixed traits like genetics or socio-economic status, making it a powerful quasi-experimental approach. Using US Medicare data from 2000 to 2012, Harvard researchers showed that exposure to PM_{2.5} and warm-season ozone was significantly associated with increased mortality risk.

Can statistical association alone prove causality?

No statistical association alone can prove causality. However, if air pollution truly harms health, its reduction should yield improvements. Such abrupt changes can be modelled as interruptions in statistical analysis. Interruptions can be interventions or policy shifts or even seemingly minor events like workers' strike at a plant.

The quasi-experimental interrupted time-series (ITS) approach is a powerful method for analysing such events. By controlling for background, time trends, seasonality, and weather, ITS can reveal whether mortality counts related to different diseases including influenza/pneumonia, cardiovascular and other respiratory diseases can deviate from what would have been expected in the absence of the interruption.

For example, a copper smelter strike across the Southwest US reduced sulphate aerosols and lowered mortality by 2–4 per cent, while the temporary closure of the Geneva steel plant in Utah Valley was linked to a sharp decline in hospital admissions, both captured through ITS analysis.

A related approach, regression discontinuity, exploits sharp policy-driven contrasts in exposure. Under China's Huai River policy, cities only on north of the Huai river received free or highly subsidized coal for heating, creating a clear north-south spatial divide in pollution levels. Analysis revealed that a 42 $\mu\text{g}/\text{m}^3$ increase in PM_{2.5} north of the river reduced life expectancy by 3.1 years, while no such effect was observed to the south.

Deterioration of body organs and systems

Advanced statistical approaches like difference-in-differences allow stable cross-sectional differences to be controlled for as if by design to strengthen causal interpretations of increased life expectancy against reduction in air pollution. Many of these techniques have emerged from different disciplines.

Like Quasi-control groups replicate natural experiments but have control groups who are not exposed, and instrumental variables are largely derived from econometrics where certain variables are associated with treatment (here air pollution) but not with outcome (mortality). This approach further reinforces causality. Epidemiologists also use Bradford Hill criterion to establish causation. Furthermore, to establish this association, a deep dive into the inherent biological mechanism is imperative.

Frontline studies on animal models and cell lines have established that air pollution is associated with deterioration of several body organs and systems. The heart is affected through altered cardiac autonomic function, increased arrhythmia risk, coronary artery disease, and myocardial infarction. The lungs experience oxidative stress, inflammation, infection, and cancer.

In the blood, particulate accumulation causes platelet aggregation, disrupts fibrinolysis, and accelerates thrombolysis. Vascular effects include endothelial dysfunction, vasoconstriction, hypertension, atherosclerosis progression, and plaque vulnerability. Air pollution also triggers systemic inflammation and oxidative stress, increases inflammatory cytokines, and suppresses growth factors, which impairs tissue injury repair. Finally, the nervous system is disrupted.

Air pollution as a subject of inquiry across disciplines

The picture remains incomplete: air pollution has emerged as a subject of inquiry in all disciplines, from ecology to economics where air pollution is an allocation problem in which polluters retain profits while externalising costs onto exposed populations.

Social scientists highlight its inequitable burden: poorer communities often lack the resources for prevention or treatment, while ethnic minorities in the US and Europe, particularly native and Hispanic populations, face disproportionate exposure and limited social protection. These communities are also likely to be less informed and aware of air pollution.

These inequalities are reflected in personal stories – Ella's family, lacking awareness and mobility, remained in a polluted neighbourhood, whereas Kristina's family in Utah could relocate and secure timely medical care.

Debates over air pollution often reflect conflicting positions. Polluters prefer a three-way stand – first, there is mostly no air pollution, second, if it is there, it's not solely because of them, and third, even if it is, there are too many uncertainties to do anything about it.

Economists and governments often hold the Kuznets curve mentality: pollution will initially rise with progress, then stabilize, and finally decline. Scientists frequently limit themselves to reporting data and outcomes in lieu of publication.

But evidence underscores urgency of action

Yet the evidence underscores the urgency of action. Meeting the World Health Organisation’s global PM2.5 standard would add 1.8 years to average life expectancy, while the US EPA estimated that a \$65-billion investment in cleaner air in 2020 yielded benefits of nearly \$2 trillion.

While lifelong smokers inhale fine particles in kilograms and lose on average a decade of life, exposure equivalent to a small pouch of fine particles in lifetime due to air pollution can still reduce life expectancy by nearly three years – demonstrating the severe health impact even at lower doses.

It is true that we will not be dead, just as we often perceive in an apocalyptic pollution scenario. But we would do well to remember the last lines from T. S. Eliot’s *The Hollow Man*: “This is the way the world ends..., not with a bang but a whimper”

Post read questions

1. How does air pollution function as both a scientific and social problem, particularly in the context of environmental justice?
2. Socioeconomic status and ethnicity intersect to influence exposure to and protection from air pollution. Do you agree?
3. How do biological mechanisms linking air pollution to diseases of the heart, lungs, blood, vasculature, and nervous system strengthen the case for causality?
4. Why can statistical associations alone not establish causality in air pollution research, and how do quasi-experimental designs attempt to address this limitation?

*(Case studies, statistics and details of analysis are summarised from the book, **Particles of Truth: A Story of Discovery, Controversy, and the Fight for Healthy Air (2025)** by C. A. Pope III and D. W. Dockery.) (Dr. Arunangshu Das is the Principal Project Scientist at the Centre for Atmospheric Sciences, Indian Institute of Technology, Delhi.)*

Hydrogen trains for a truly green and sustainable form of transportation

The strategic rollout of hydrogen trains could become a cornerstone of India's Atmanirbhar Bharat vision, driving a cleaner, greener, and more resilient future. But what logistical and infrastructural bottlenecks does India face in deploying hydrogen trains efficiently.

Written by **Kannan K**

Recently, Indian Railways successfully tested the first hydrogen-powered coach or driving power car, marking a key milestone in the national transporter's quest to build India's first hydrogen-powered train.

Hydrogen-powered trains have also emerged as a promising technological innovation in the global quest for decarbonisation. Effective deployment of Hydrogen fuel

trains has the potential to pay significant dividends, particularly for India, which has one of the world's largest rail networks and an ambitious target of net-zero carbon emissions by 2070.

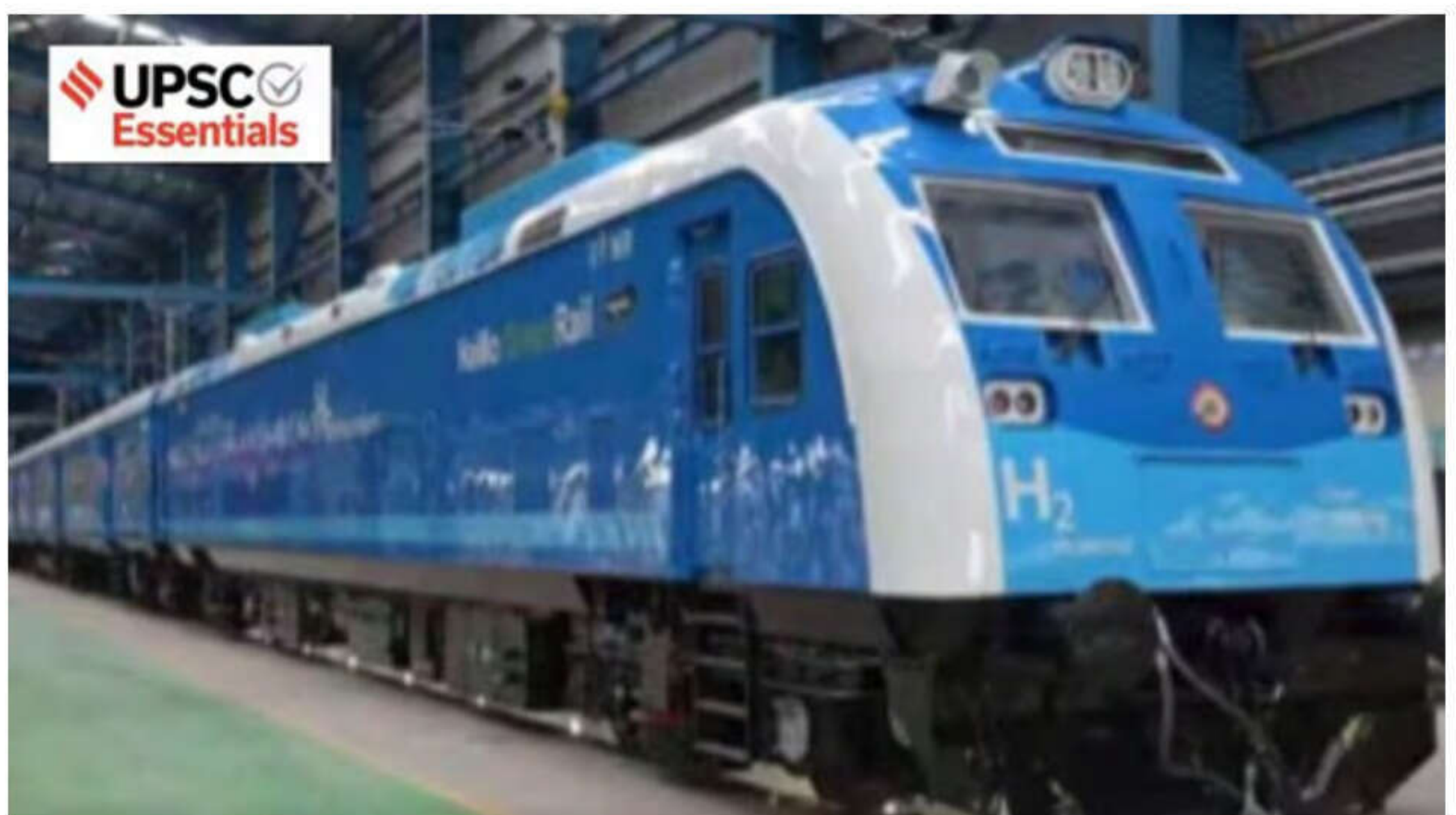
In comparison to the traditional diesel-electric locomotives that still dominate large sections of the railway network, hydrogen trains – often referred to as 'hydrail' or 'H-trains' – provide a viable, zero-emission alternative.

Towards green, sustainable transportation

Hydrogen trains are electric trains with an onboard power source, unlike conventional electric trains that are powered via overhead wires. They use HFC (Hydrogen Fuel Cell) technology, which generates energy through the electrochemical reaction of compressed hydrogen with atmospheric oxygen, emitting water vapour as the sole byproduct. This makes the system a zero-emission mechanism at the point of use.

The electricity produced by the fuel cell is stored in batteries, which provide additional power during acceleration and climbing inclines. Hydrogen trains also employ regenerative braking technology, which captures the kinetic energy (motion energy) generated during braking and converts it into electricity to recharge onboard batteries.

Powered by Green Hydrogen – which is produced via the electrolysis of water using renewable energy with near-zero GHG emissions – Hydrogen Fuel Cell technology can ensure that these trains are truly a green and sustainable form of transportation.



India's hydrogen-powered engine is set to be the most powerful in the world. (Image: Ministry of Railways)

Hydrogen trains support energy security

Hydrail offers significant advantages, including:

- The elimination of smoke emissions from fuel combustion, leading to reduced noise and air pollution.
- Hydrogen trains can operate on both electrified and non-electrified routes, bringing greater operational flexibility in deployment.
- Hydrail will be particularly suitable for routes where catenary electrification (overhead wiring system used by electric trains) is either unfeasible or prone to damage and disruption.
- Hydrogen trains can be refuelled in around 20 to 25 minutes, surpassing the recharge time required by battery-electric trains.

In the Indian context, particularly with the target of net-zero emissions by 2070, hydrogen rails offer a decarbonisation path to Indian Railways, which has been a major consumer of fossil fuel. In 2023-24, it reduced fuel consumption for traction purposes by 136 crore liters as compared to 2018-19.

While the initial investments are high, hydrail deployment can prove cost-effective, particularly on non-electrified routes, by avoiding the massive expenditure required for overhead electrification infrastructure. Further, it reduces dependence on imported diesel, thereby contributing to India's energy security and balance of payments.

Logistics, infrastructure, and finance

Despite these advantages, hydrogen trains come with its set of unique challenges, such as:

- Hydrail has a substantially high initial cost of production compared to both electric and diesel trains.
- It requires the development of an extensive system for hydrogen production, storage and distribution – an infrastructure that is largely absent in India today.
- The massive refueling stations and machinery needed to support the substantial fleet of hydrogen trains present another logistical and financial challenge.

These factors suggest that direct electric trains remain more suitable for India's electrified, mainstream routes, especially if the electricity supplied through the overhead wires is from clean sources. Moreover, the highly flammable nature of hydrogen requires adherence to strict safety standards from production to storage and refuelling, necessitating further investment in safety infrastructure and training for railway personnel.

In addition, the use of hydrogen fuel cells involves converting electricity to hydrogen (through the process of electrolysis where electricity from sources like solar or wind is used to split water into hydrogen and oxygen that produces green hydrogen) and then back to electricity, making the overall efficiency of hydrogen trains lower than that of electric trains powered by overhead lines.

Currently, nearly all hydrogen produced in India is derived from fossil fuels (grey hydrogen), while large-scale green hydrogen production (generated from renewable sources) is in its early stages. This presents a significant obstacle to achieving true decarbonisation of transport through hydrail.

Hydrail to be a cornerstone of Atmanirbhar Bharat?

Nevertheless, hydrogen trains represent a significant step in India's journey towards becoming a sustainable and decarbonised nation. These trains offer a green alternative, particularly on routes in remote and hilly regions. The introduction of hydrogen trains is part of India's quest to build a strong indigenous hydrogen ecosystem, and is directly aligned with the National Green Hydrogen Mission (NGHM) and the Hydrogen for Heritage initiative.

This would require a well-structured strategy that leverages India's growing Renewable Energy (RE) capacity to scale up green hydrogen production to bring down costs.

Further, an effective, efficient and decentralised system of hydrogen infrastructure, with emphasis on storage and refuelling – similar to the Hydrogen Highways project under the NGHM – would help. For these goals to materialise, large-scale investment in research and development will be crucial to advance fuel cell technology, improve efficiency, and enhance safety standards.

The realisation of India's hydrogen goals, both the establishment of a robust hydrogen ecosystem that positions the country as a global leader in production and the deployment of a fleet of trains offering clean, long-distance mobility, will require policy interventions with a long-term vision that keeps abreast of the technological advancements in this evolving field.

To sum up, becoming a global leader in green hydrogen innovation would significantly boost India's energy security and economic prosperity. Notably, the efficient and strategic deployment of hydrail, complemented by a strong domestic hydrogen manufacturing ecosystem, has the potential to be a cornerstone of India's Atmanirbhar Bharat vision for a cleaner, greener, and more resilient future.

Post read questions

1. **Hydrogen-powered trains have emerged as a promising technological innovation in the global quest for decarbonisation, and have the potential to contribute to India's 2070 net-zero target. Evaluate.**
2. **How does the efficiency of hydrogen fuel cell trains compare with that of electric trains in terms of energy conversion and lifecycle emissions?**
3. **What is a regenerative braking system? How does it help improve the performance and sustainability of hydrogen rail systems?**
4. **How does the use of green hydrogen versus grey hydrogen affect the overall decarbonisation potential of hydrogen trains?**
5. **The introduction of hydrogen trains is part of India's quest to build a strong indigenous hydrogen ecosystem, and is directly aligned with the National Green Hydrogen Mission (NGHM) and the Hydrogen for Heritage initiative. Discuss.**

(Kannan K is a Doctoral candidate at the Centre for Economic and Social Studies, Hyderabad)

Economy

How non-farm primary activities sustain livelihoods in rural India

Rural households in India are increasingly diversifying their income sources through non-farm primary activities like livestock rearing, fisheries, and forestry. These sectors not only strengthen the rural economy but also contribute to health and nutrition. But how does the government support these activities?

Written by **Ritwika Patgiri**

The primary sector in India provides employment to 44 per cent of the labour force while contributing less than 20 per cent to the country's GDP. The primary sector is defined as the economic sector that produces goods by exploiting natural resources like land, water, forests, mines, etc. Agriculture is one of the most important primary sectors.

However, while agriculture's share in employment has fallen slowly, its share in GDP

has declined relatively faster. It underlines the slow nature of structural transformation of the Indian economy. As a result, agriculture is no longer the primary driving force of the economy. What remains hidden, though, is the role of the non-agricultural primary sector in most discussions on the Indian economy.



Non-farm primary activities are an important source of income for agricultural as well as landless households. (Bhupendra Rana)

Non-farm activities as diversification strategy

As per the official categorisation of economic sectors, the non-farm or non-agricultural primary sectors and activities include mining and quarrying, fisheries, forestry, and animal husbandry. The importance of each of these sectors becomes clearer when examined individually.

For example, the fisheries sector provides employment to around 28 million people, many of them from marginalised and vulnerable communities. Similarly, around 20.5 million people are employed in livestock-related activities. The livestock sector's contribution to agriculture and allied sector Gross Value Added (GVA) has increased from 24.38 per cent in 2014-15 to 30.23 per cent in 2022-23, and it accounts for around 5.50 per cent of total GVA as of 2022-23.

Non-farm primary activities are an important source of income for agricultural as well as landless households. At the

same time, the sector contributes to food security by providing a source of affordable and nutritious food.

For instance, the livestock sector is considered to be more egalitarian than crop cultivation as many landless rural households can engage in animal rearing. Thus, non-farm primary activities serve as a diversification strategy and are seen to be playing a key role in poverty-reducing growth.

Factors driving pluriactivity

Evidence suggests that rural households in India are increasingly becoming pluri-active and are engaged in a range of economic activities – crop production, animal husbandry, non-farm self-employment, casual farm as well as non-farm labour, and migration.

The NABARD All-India Rural Financial Inclusion Survey 2021-22 highlighted that for farm households, crop cultivation is the main source of income and contributes one-third of their monthly earnings. However, these households also engage in government or private services, wage labour (both farm and non-farm), and other enterprises. Animal husbandry or livestock rearing alone accounts for 12 per cent of their income.

This diversification of income sources is driven by multiple factors, such as reducing risks, coping with shocks, and addressing seasonal factors. For example, studies have found that rural households sell their cattle or other livestock during the non-agricultural season, or use livestock earnings to finance migration to urban areas during the off-season. Thus, non-farm and allied activities act as a form of insurance for farmers during the non-agricultural season or against vagaries of nature like drought and other natural calamities.

Technology and physiography

Historically, farmers integrate agriculture with some of these non-farm primary activities in mutually reinforcing ways. With the adoption of Green Revolution technology and farm mechanisation, the use of animal labour in farming has declined.

However, there are studies showing an increasing productivity in the livestock sector, especially in states that benefited most from the Green Revolution. At the same time, states that benefited from both the Green Revolution and the White Revolution, there was a noted rise in high milk-yielding cattle.

In addition to technology, physiographical conditions also shape non-farm primary activities. For instance, fisheries thrive in regions with long coastlines and large rivers, while mineral rich areas act as hubs for mining activities.

But in the mineral-rich regions like Chhotanagpur, mining activities often result in the grabbing of indigenous land along with the displacement of the tribal population. Expansion of mining activities has contributed to land degradation, pollution, and agrarian distress. Thus, while primary non-farm activities are crucial for development, they are also deeply embedded in India's ecological and socio-economic contradictions.

Gender and caste-based dimensions

It is also important to understand who carries the labour for such non-farm primary activities. For instance, much of the work in livestock is carried out by women, and hence, the growth in the livestock sector is seen as empowering for women. However, official statistics often undercount women's contributions. At the same time, there are many women who often dismiss such work as "nothing", resulting in the underreporting of their contribution to the livestock economy.

Notably, non-farm primary activities also have distinct caste-based dimensions, according to some studies. For instance, landless households, in contrast to dominant-caste households, are more likely to treat animal husbandry as an income-generating source. In fisheries, there is a significant presence of marginalised communities, which exposes them to distinct forms of vulnerabilities and economic shocks. For instance, the Kaibartas of Assam – the fishing community without access to cultivable land – had to diversify in other non-farm jobs due to declining income from fishing.

Policy interventions in non-farm primary sector

India is the largest producer of milk in the world, the second largest producer of eggs, and the fifth largest producer of meat. The primary non-farm sector is, thus, crucial to the economy and to health and nutrition. Sectors like livestock, fisheries, and forestry sustain millions of landless and marginal farmers, providing them with cash income, insurance against agricultural shocks, and a foothold in wider markets.

Recent policies have been targeting these primary non-farm activities. The Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY) is one such example. The PMMSY intends to improve fish production and the productivity of the fisheries sector through technical and financial support. Similarly, there are insurance schemes for animal rearing. Training on vaccination of animals and other awareness generation have also been introduced at the district level for farmers.

However, there are some instances when such policy intervention didn't yield the desired result. For instance, the Samanwita Project introduced in Orissa (now Odisha) in the 1980s aimed to create a range of cross-bred cattle to increase milk production. However, the project produced only eight cross-bred cows while decimating the local bull population. Likewise, the proposed Kylleng-Pyndengsohiong (KPM) Uranium Mining Project in Meghalaya has found significant resistance from the local community due to serious environmental as well as health concerns.

These experiences highlight that while policy interventions in the non-farm primary sector have the potential to improve productivity and resilience, they also carry risks if they ignore local ecologies, community practices, and social contexts. Therefore, integrating local knowledge, respecting ecological limits, and recognising the role of the real “workers” in these sectors are essential to active desired outcomes.

Post read questions

1. What are non-farm primary activities? How are these activities related to physiographic features in India? Discuss with suitable examples.
2. Discuss the role of non-farm primary activities in diversifying rural household income and reducing poverty.
3. How have the Green Revolution and White Revolution shaped the trajectory of livestock development in India?
4. Evaluate the ecological and social contradictions associated with mining as a non-farm primary activity.
5. Evaluate the role of government interventions such as the Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY) in strengthening non-farm primary activities.

(Ritwika Patgiri is a doctoral candidate at the Faculty of Economics, South Asian University.)

Society

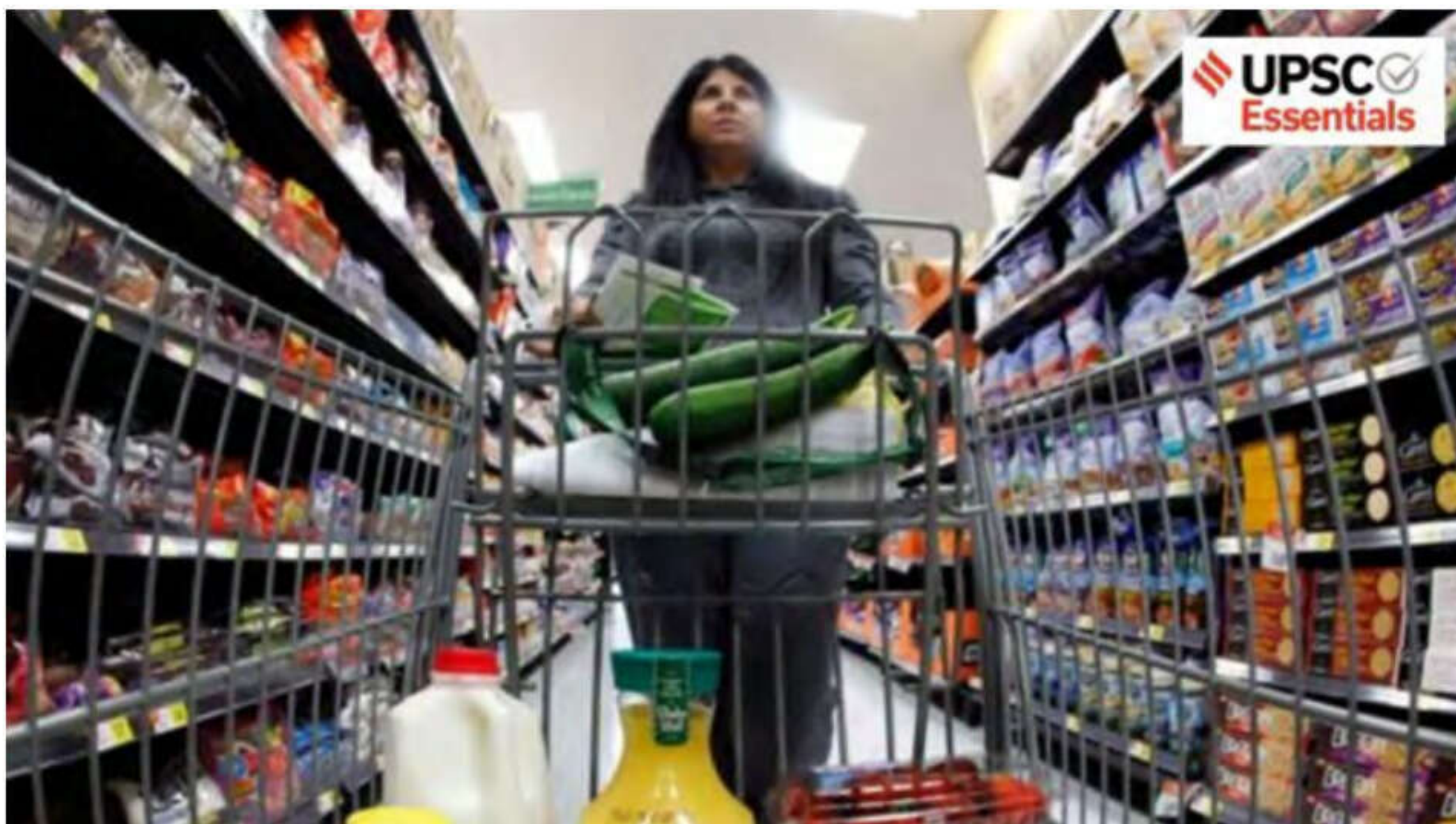
How consumerism links ‘who we are’ to ‘what we have’

In its pursuit of promoting uniform and standardised consumption patterns across the world, globalisation paves the way for markets to turn citizens into consumers by linking consumption with identity, ownership, and happiness. But is globalisation just about consumerism?

Written by **Irfanullah Farooqi**

Consumption has been integral to human societies for as long as one can remember. However, given its umbilical link to production, as human beings moved towards a more complex and expanded scale of production, consumption too acquired new layers.

When we speak of consumer culture, we are referring to a phenomenon that, relatively speaking, is not so old. It signifies an extraordinary spread of a way of life oriented towards promised luxury, abundance, pleasure, and happiness. While extravagance and consumption of luxuries existed in the ancient world, it was only in the 18th century that these traits went beyond society’s elites.



With production catering to a global market, globalisation thrives on the creation of what critical theorist Herbert Marcuse aptly called “false needs”. (Reuters)

Riding on the spectacular success of economic and political revolutions, the modern age gave birth to a class of consumers driven by an excitement for the ‘new’. By the time we get to the post-war western world, a consumerist way of life – one characterised by an unquenchable thirst for more – has firmly taken hold.

In his comprehensive and celebrated essay “Consumer Culture: An Introduction”, published in the journal *Theory, Culture & Society* in 1983, Mark Featherstone rightly points out, “the consumer way of life with its promise of abundance, luxury, unlimited pleasure and happiness does have a peculiarly compulsive quality ..”

Let us look at how this consumer culture is connected to globalisation and in what ways the process of globalisation intensifies its grip across countries worldwide.

Development of a ‘global culture’

Globalisation was initially understood and explained as an economic phenomenon. Early deliberations revolved around factors such as:

— Free movement of goods and services.

- The emergence of a new global economic order.
- The internationalisation of trade and finance.
- The growing power of transnational corporations.
- The enhanced role of international economic institutions.

In short, globalisation was all about intensification and extension of economic relations across the world. However, subsequent reflections on globalisation, particularly with respect to its politics, began to look into its impact in the domain of culture, especially in relation to the Global South.

With production catering to a global market, globalisation thrives on the creation of what critical theorist Herbert Marcuse aptly called “false needs”.

In cultural terms, globalisation refers to the ways in which cultural flows expand and accelerate across the world. In this respect, one can also think about the development of ‘global culture’. But critics of globalisation refuse to be impressed by this narrative and draw our attention to how it often results in an undesirable standardisation of culture.

George Ritzer’s widely cited book, *The McDonaldization of Society: An Investigation Into the Changing Character of Contemporary Social Life*, offers an insightful reading of this homogenising trend in the realm of food consumption.

Globalisation’s association with and promotion of consumerism can be rightly understood by looking at the massive proliferation of media during the past two-three decades. Initially, it was considered a positive development because transnational media networks were expected to inform people about the real issues and concerns of remote and marginalised cultures. This awareness, it was held, would prove vital for desirable human solidarities and a transnational sense of belonging.

Over time, however, as media ownership became increasingly concentrated in the hands of big capitalists, its role largely changed. It is found largely invested in shaping our identities and desires. The massive advertisement industry has successfully reduced us to consumers by persuading us to buy in excess and discard way more often than needed.

Does globalisation thrive on “false needs”?

In its pursuit of promoting uniform and standardised consumption patterns across the world, globalisation links consumption – almost as a matter of principle beyond subsistence – with happiness. Buying becomes the primary marker of achievement. Historian William Leach, in his 1993 classic book, *Land of Desire: Merchants, Power, and the Rise of a New American Culture*, observes:

“The cardinal features of this culture were acquisition and consumption as the means of achieving happiness; the cult of the new; the democratisation of desire; and money value as the predominant measure of all value in society.”

Every brand store has glass walls with hundreds and thousands of items on display. One need not even step inside the store to be enticed. The idea behind display – usually on a grand scale – is to unleash the consumer within us, to activate an irresistible temptation to possess.

Notwithstanding the complicity of globalisation in reducing us to consumers, the process has also indirectly led to some awareness of this very pathology, or what Walter Benjamin called the logic of “mechanical reproduction”.

With production catering to a global market, globalisation thrives on the creation of what critical theorist Herbert Marcuse aptly called “false needs”. Advertisements play an exceptionally crucial role in accelerating the adoption of these needs across sections of society. A good advertisement works by evoking the enchanting ‘could be’ by acquiring the product. In one of Nokia’s early advertisements, actress Priyanka Chopra signs off with a statement that captures it rather well: “It is not just a phone. It is who we are”.

Apple iPhone offers a perfect example of how the desire to acquire works through complex registers of achievement, peer pressure, and necessity. The desire to buy the latest iPhone on the day it was launched – something that kept

hundreds of people camped or queued outside the Apple stores the night before – remains inexplicable despite being promisingly theorised.

This pathological brand consciousness keeps us perpetually driven towards having and, to borrow from Erich Fromm, keeps us distant from being. The terms of everyday life get more and more determined by what we have, and not by who we essentially are. In fact, consumerism in its advanced formats links ‘who we are’ to ‘what we have’.

Is globalisation just about consumerism?

Scholars of globalisation generally agree that it is a contradictory process. For instance, if we look at globalisation’s impact on our society, it has contributed to both prosperity and poverty, led to both creation and loss of jobs, brought awareness of women’s rights and, at the same time, facilitated commodification of their bodies, caused environmental degradation, and also paved the way for massive transnational environmental movements.

Against this backdrop, the answer to the question, ‘is globalisation just about consumerism’ is a qualified yes. There is no denying that globalisation has played a pivotal role in expediting consumerism by democratising the desire to consume. What was earlier associated with upper classes has now become a perceived ‘necessity’ across other classes as well.

Brands perpetually stir our status consciousness and often succeed in convincing us about the sheer need for commodities under the guise of desirable upgrades. To an extent, globalisation has also been instrumental in putting in place an idea and philosophy of progress defined by the endless replacement of the old with the new. Its success lies in convincing us that the iPhone 17 is new until the iPhone 18 is mentioned in tech news.

Notwithstanding the complicity of globalisation in reducing us to consumers, the process has also indirectly led to some awareness of this very pathology, or what Walter Benjamin called the logic of “mechanical reproduction”. There are transnational movements and campaigns for the marginalised that are only possible because of the interconnectedness globalisation has facilitated. Across several nations of the world, there have been concerted attempts at not letting market forces succeed in making people recognise themselves through commodities.

While it requires no genius to identify the multiple ways in which globalisation exacerbates consumerism, what is needed is a perceptive reading of the phenomenon to understand the complexities of its impact and influence. As globalisation paves the way for the market to turn citizens into consumers, societies grapple with new sets of questions pertaining to equality, rights, freedom, development, progress, and so forth. It is in this dynamic unfolding of the market-society interface that we must try to make sense of new social upheavals in the face of consumerism’s upgraded versions.

Post read questions

1. **Do you think that globalisation results in only an aggressive consumer culture? Justify your answer.**
2. **How has globalisation contributed to the democratisation of desire across different social classes?**
3. **Is globalisation ultimately more about consumerism than cultural exchange? Why or why not?**
4. **As markets increasingly turn citizens into consumers, what new social upheavals are emerging?**
5. **Can transnational movements counterbalance the homogenising tendencies of globalisation?**

(Irfanullah Farooqi is an Assistant Professor at the Indian Institute of Management Kozhikode.)

Why urban development needs to be both inclusive and sustainable

After liberalisation, economic reforms were mostly carried out in the formal sector, sidelining the informal sector, which employed more than half of the urban population. As cities expand unevenly, informal workers face rising living costs, displacement, and greater vulnerability, creating a condition called ‘poverty paradox’.

Written by **Ritwika Patgiri**

Every year during the monsoon season, reports of Indian cities battling floods have become the norm. Such reports reflect poorly on urban infrastructure, particularly their drainage systems. There are also concerns about other aspects of urban infrastructure like health care and education.

Data reveals that nearly half of India’s urban population lives in slums, which often lack access to safe drinking water, sanitation facilities, or durable housing. Urban poverty is, therefore, not only about deprivation of income but also deprivation of secure living conditions and basic services.



The paradox of poverty can be defined as a situation in which countries that experience economic growth find large sections of people trapped in poverty. (File)

Urban poverty and inequality in India

Recent data suggests that both urban poverty and inequality have declined in India, but the data needs a closer examination. For instance, between 1955 and 1975, urban inequality (indicated by the Gini Coefficient 1) increased from 0.392 to 0.416, while rural income Gini increased from 0.341 to 0.388.

By 1995, both rural and urban income inequality declined, with rural Gini falling to 0.376 and urban Gini to 0.390 – a relatively modest decline compared to rural areas. In the post-liberalisation period, the urban Gini coefficient rose to 0.455 by 2005, while rural areas indicated a similar rise in inequality. By 2023, the rural Gini coefficient declined to 0.405 while urban Gini coefficient fell sharply to 0.382, after a peak of 0.532 in 2020.

Two important things should be noted here. First, urban inequality rose sharply after the liberalisation of the Indian economy in the early 1990s. Economic reforms spurred growth in sectors like banking and Information Technology, and poverty declined from 36 per cent in 1993-94 to 26.1 per cent in 1999-2000.

However, these reforms were mostly carried out in the formal sectors of the economy. As a result, the urban informal sector – which employed more than half of the urban population – couldn’t reap the benefits of those reforms. Informal workers faced displacement, rising living costs, and greater vulnerability as uneven urban growth continued to persist.

Second, the period between 2005 and 2020 saw tremendous growth in urbanisation, increasing rural-urban migration, and the rise in the number of slums and slum dwellers. The construction sector boomed and created the majority of the non-farm jobs. However, such jobs are precarious, low-paying, and uncertain.

Poverty paradox

Thus, better opportunities were created for some sections of the society through private investment, banking, digitisation, etc, while leading to casualisation of other non-farm work. Informal workers like street vendors are also vulnerable to displacement.

Migrant workers in cities often lack access to health care and education, which make them more vulnerable to deprivation. For instance, workers from states like Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, and West Bengal who migrate to metro cities like Delhi are largely absorbed into the informal sectors and remain concentrated in informal dwellings.

Neha Dixit's *The Many Lives of Syeda X* depicts these vulnerabilities of informal migrant workers who are pushed into numerous but precarious odd-jobs. Such migrant workers are also more likely to be land-poor or belong to marginalised communities.

This can also be understood with the help of the concept of the 'poverty paradox'. The paradox of poverty can be defined as a situation in which countries that experience economic growth find large sections of people trapped in poverty. This is mostly visible in middle-income countries like India and China where the rise of a country's income per person does not automatically eradicate poverty for the poorest.

Urban development and smart cities

Therefore, urban development needs to be about inclusivity and sustainability. The Smart Cities Mission was launched in 2015 with the goal of developing 100 smart cities across the country between 2019 and 2023. The project was officially shut down in March 2025.

A smart city refers to an urban area or unit that utilizes digital technologies, data-driven solutions, and efficient resource management to improve the quality of life of its residents. It is also referred to as "intelligent city", "digital city", or "knowledge city".

Smart cities are deemed to be sustainable and address the challenges of urbanisation. They offer business opportunities and attract investments from multi-national corporations, real estate developers and investors.

A smart city is also linked to digitalisation and technology as well as job creation, with a belief that technological progress can advance social justice. Smart cities are seen as a gateway in achieving the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals, such as:

- Promoting sustained and inclusive economic growth.
- Making cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient, and sustainable.
- Promoting peaceful and inclusive societies for sustainable development.

The Smart Cities Mission seeks to renovate existing cities and provide facilities like housing, clean water, power, and transport.

While the idea of smart cities rests on inclusivity, heavy infrastructure – such as urban highways or flyovers – may not necessarily lead to poverty reduction. For example, a comparative study of two provinces in China found that the province that built accessible roads for poorer and remote populations achieved greater poverty reduction. Improved road networks and bus routes helped the poor better connect with urban areas, explore jobs, migrate, and receive

information.

On the other hand, the province that invested heavily in building highways and freeways did not fare well in reducing poverty. This province also focused on tourism through the building of bigger hotels and resorts, but ignored community-driven tourism. While the urban highways and freeways connected the capital city of the province with other major cities, they excluded the poorer sections of the population. The province witnessed economic growth but without poverty alleviation.

Towards sustainable urban growth

India has invested heavily in its Smart Cities Mission but the project has not yielded the desired benefits. Only 18 cities out of 100 have completed all their projects. However, all 100 cities, according to data, have fully functional Integrated Command and Control Centres, which help city officials in making real-time smart decisions. Over 84,000 CCTV cameras have been installed across these cities to monitor public spaces and reduce crime. Water pipelines are also being monitored to minimise water leakages, while eco-friendly transportation, smart classrooms, and e-health centres and clinics are also being promoted.

The Government of India has also launched several policies and schemes targeting the urban population, including Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation (AMRUT), Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana – Urban (PMAY-U), and National Urban Learning Platform. These initiatives aim to improve housing, water supply, sanitation, and proper drainage and sewage systems. However, the real impact of these policies and their coordination with the Smart Cities Mission remains unclear.

Digitization, information technology, private investment, banking, and highways and freeways are often seen as important markers of urban infrastructure and development. However, understanding the inherent structure of the society is also important for policy makers. Better jobs for the poor, accessible roads for the marginalised sections, affordable health care and education, and inclusive transportation are equally essential for sustainable urban development. In addition, precise data and surveys on urban areas would be crucial to understand how cities fare across these indicators.

Post read questions

- 1. Inequality in the ownership pattern of resources is one of the major causes of poverty. Discuss in the context of ‘paradox of poverty’.**
- 2. How do highways and freeways differ from accessible local roads in terms of their impact on poverty reduction?**
- 3. How can informal workers and migrant populations be better integrated into urban planning policies?**
- 4. Are smart cities inherently inclusive? How can smart cities contribute to achieving the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)?**

(Ritwika Patgiri is a doctoral candidate at the Faculty of Economics, South Asian University.)

Polity

GST 2.0 and the evolving dynamics of fiscal federalism

The nature of centre-state financial relations has undergone significant transformations with institutional and systemic reforms. But why have concerns over revenue sharing or borrowing restrictions often resulted in debates on fiscal federalism and autonomy?

Written by **Dileep P Chandran**

Even as the Union Government pursues fiscal reforms to enhance state participation, states are increasingly voicing concerns over fiscal centralisation. For instance, the recent GST slab rationalisation has ignited debates over fiscal autonomy, with some states raising concerns over potential revenue losses and demanding adequate safeguards.



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Union Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary and Revenue Secretary Arvind Shrivastava during the 56th GST Council meeting, in New Delhi, Wednesday, Sept. 03, 2025. (PTI Photo)

But why are states demanding greater fiscal autonomy, and how is the union government responding to it? A brief overview of the evolution of centre-state fiscal relations, alongside the recent developments, will help us understand this.

Evolution of centre-state fiscal relations

Articles 268 to 293 of the Indian Constitution govern the distribution of financial powers between the Union and state governments. The Seventh Schedule of the Constitution (Article 246) delineates the tax base between the centre and states. The Finance Commission, under Article 280, has been bestowed with the exclusive power to recommend the distribution of intergovernmental finance, including tax devolution and grants-in-aid.

The erstwhile Planning Commission, with overlapping functions, also played a decisive role in revenue allocation and disbursement of grants-in-aid to states. In addition, the Constitution provides for grants-in-aid to states from the consolidated fund (Article 275) and regulates state borrowings (Article 293).

The nature of centre-state financial relations had undergone significant transformations with institutional and systemic

reforms. However, despite these constitutional mechanisms intended to protect the rights of states in financial matters, concerns over revenue sharing or borrowing restrictions have often resulted in debates on fiscal federalism and autonomy.

Former RBI Governor Duvvuri Subbarao, in his reflections on India's fiscal federalism, traced the evolution of centre-state financial relations through three distinct phases.

— The first phase, described as 'docile federalism' (1947 to early 1970s), was characterised by the domination of the centre in decision-making, facilitated by the single party rule and centralised allocation of resources. During this formative phase, states remained heavily dependent on the centre despite their growing contributions to the national tax pool.

— The second phase, termed 'cooperative federalism' (1970s to mid-1990s), witnessed greater state involvement in economic decision-making and development planning.

— The third and ongoing phase (mid-1990s to present) described as 'combative federalism', is marked by frequent contention between the union and state governments. This trajectory highlights how the nature of financial relations between the centre and states has significantly changed alongside the broader reforms, moving from planned development to competitive federalism.

Impact of reforms on fiscal federalism

Developments such as the abolition of the Planning Commission and the formation of NITI Aayog in 2015 underscored a shift away from planned development towards institutional mechanisms for competitive federalism. The Governing Council of NITI Aayog has emerged as a deliberative platform for the political leadership in both the centre and states.

Similarly, the introduction of Goods and Services Tax (GST) in 2017 created a new institutional framework for greater participation of states in fiscal matters. However, the GST considerably curtailed states' control over revenue generation.

Critics argue that the GST regime has tilted the balance of fiscal authority in favour of the centre. For instance, the weighted voting system in the GST Council, in which the central government holds one-third of the total votes, has been viewed as inconsistent with the spirit of federalism. Thus, the centralisation of taxation powers erodes the fiscal autonomy of states.

However, in *Union of India versus Mohit Minerals Pvt. Ltd.*, the Supreme Court observed that recommendations of the GST Council are only suggestive, and thereby reaffirmed the state autonomy in fiscal matters.

GST slab rationalisation

The Covid-19 pandemic exposed the financial vulnerability of states that have been heavily dependent on central transfers. During this period, the Central government failed to disburse GST compensation, originally designed to offset revenue loss of states, citing the situation as an "Act of God". This deepened the trust deficit between the centre and states. Several states demanded an extension of the GST compensation period, which was set to expire in June 2022, citing financial stress caused by the pandemic.

However, the Union government rejected this demand, even though the GST Council had decided to continue the collection of the GST Compensation Cess until March 2026 to serve the debt incurred by the centre used for

compensating state revenue shortfalls during the Covid-19 pandemic.

The recent GST slab rationalisation has raised concerns among opposition-ruled states regarding the potential revenue loss. While states broadly agreed to ‘new generation GST reforms’ aimed at benefitting consumers, they expressed apprehension that such measures could undermine states’ fiscal autonomy unless adequately compensated by the centre. Karnataka Revenue Minister, Krishna Byre Gowda, cautioned that without adequate compensation, states would be reduced to “glorified municipalities”.

Eight opposition-ruled states also jointly demanded protection against future losses arising from the slab rationalisation. However, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman rejected these demands, clarifying that the impact of rate cuts would be equally shared between the centre and states. The Union government also expects that increasing consumption, spurred by lower tax rates, would offset the revenue shortfall in the long run.

Friction between centre and states

Although Indian states are often regarded as enjoying more autonomy in terms of spending power compared to their counterparts in many federal countries like Brazil and Indonesia, many have voiced concerns about the Union government’s reliance on cesses and surcharges, which fall outside the divisible tax pool. Consequently, the divisible tax pool had shrunk from 88.6 per cent in 2011-12 to 78.9 per cent in 2021-22.

States such as Tamil Nadu and Kerala have also raised concern over the rigid conditionalities attached to Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSS), which require them to contribute a larger share to CSS despite having little role in their formulation. This has accentuated a horizontal disparity among states.

In addition, Karnataka, Kerala and Tamil Nadu have been fighting with the centre over delays in the disbursement of essential aid in response to natural disasters. Fiscally stronger states have also been challenging the principles governing the grants-in-aid, which they call discriminatory.

Kerala has moved the Supreme Court to challenge the centre’s imposition of a Net Borrowing Ceiling (NBC) that restricts states from even open market borrowing. States have argued that invoking Article 293, the Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management Act, 2003, to curtail their borrowing amounts to encroachment on their fiscal autonomy.

The working of the Finance Commission, a constitutional body under Article 280, has long been a source of contention between the Union and state governments. For instance, some states, particularly southern states, questioned the terms of reference of the 15th Finance Commission for its adoption of 2011 census data as the basis of devolution. They argued that this approach would penalise states that had performed better in demographic and developmental indicators.

At the same time, some states are demanding that the 16th Finance Commission increase their share to 50 per cent from the current 41 per cent.

Towards consensus-driven federalism

Notwithstanding the evolution of financial relations between the Union and state governments – from the centralisation in the initial phase to cooperative fiscal federalism – states are constantly raising concerns over the centre’s encroachment on their fiscal space. These concerns, especially voiced by opposition-ruled states, underscore the urgent need for a consultative and transparent institutional mechanism, firmly grounded in the constitutional

provisions, to strengthen fiscal federalism.

A proper mechanism for coordination between the Finance Commission and GST Council is also essential, as opined by Y V Reddy, chairman of the Fourteenth Finance Commission. At the same time, the existing mechanisms for state consultation, like the NITI Aayog Governing Council and the GST Council, should not be reduced to arenas of political battle. Meaningful state participation requires not only institutional reform but also genuine political will.

Fiscal reforms that have implications for the federal balance must be built on consensus between the Union and state governments. Any undue advantage exercised by the centre over states, such as through measures like weighted voting, risks undermining the federal nature of institutions and deepening the trust deficit.

Fiscal federalism grounded in consensus and trust

Building trust needs to underpin both the design and implementation of fiscal reforms. The compensation to states for revenue losses incurred by states during the first five years of implementation of GST was a strong gesture of trust building while introducing structural reforms.

States' demand for compensation of losses arising from the slab rationalisation and capping of cesses and surcharges imposed by the centre needs serious and fair consideration by the Finance Commission in line with the constitutional mandate to protect fiscal federalism.

The one-size-fits all approach may not help address the problem of horizontal imbalance. For instance, small northeastern states are demanding a 25 per cent increase in tax devolution, considering their unique challenges, whereas Himalayan states like Uttarakhand seek compensation for ecological service costs and more weightage to forest cover in the tax devolution formula in line with a spirit of 'environmental federalism'.

While standardised solutions to states' fiscal problems are neither desirable nor feasible, the underlying spirit of future reforms needs to be fiscal federalism grounded in consensus-driven formulation and trust-driven implementation.

Post read questions

- 1. Examine the evolving pattern of Centre-State financial relations in the context of planned development in India. How far have the recent reforms impacted the fiscal federalism in India?**
- 2. Discuss how institutional reforms such as the abolition of the Planning Commission, the creation of NITI Aayog, and the introduction of GST have altered the nature of fiscal federalism in India.**
- 3. "The GST regime has strengthened cooperative federalism but weakened fiscal autonomy of states." Evaluate this statement with suitable examples.**
- 4. Why are states increasingly raising concerns about fiscal centralisation? Examine in light of recent debates over GST compensation, borrowing limits, and cesses and surcharges.**

(Dileep P Chandran is an Assistant Professor at the Department of Political Science in P M Government College, Chalakudy, Kerala.)

UPSC FOCUS

Issue at a Glance

India's Cybercrime Challenge : Rise and Response

Indians lose ₹1,000 crore every month to cyber frauds linked to Cambodia and other Southeast Asian countries, says an MHA report. How do cybercrimes pose a multidimensional challenge to India? What is the government's response? Let's simplify this current affairs issue and link it to the static UPSC syllabus.

Written by **Roshni Yadav**

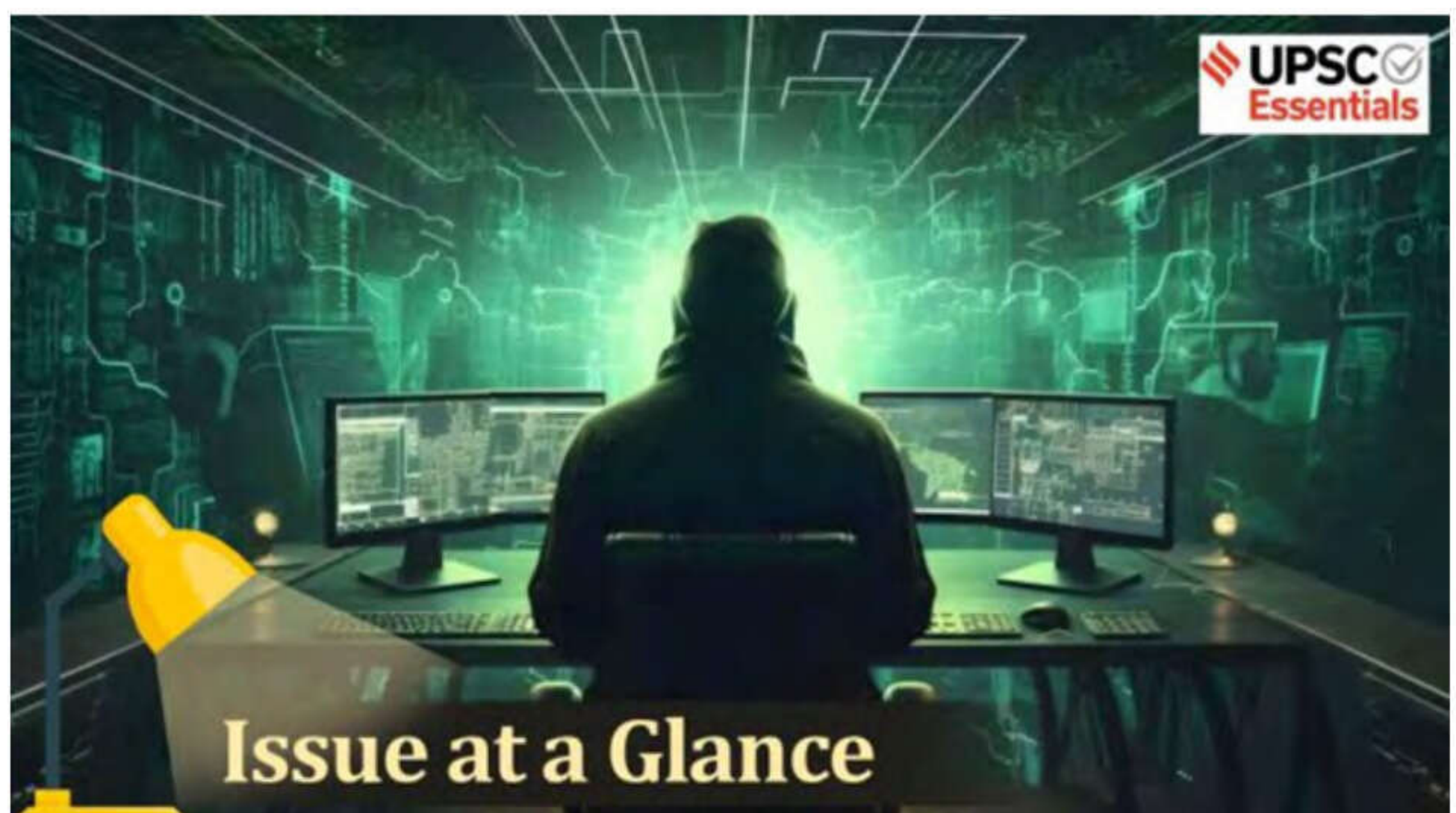
What is the issue?

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has estimated that a significant portion of the cyber scams targeting Indians come from Southeast Asia. It attributes over half of the approximately Rs 7,000 crore lost to online scams in the first five months of this year, January to May, to networks operating out of **Myanmar, Cambodia, Vietnam, Laos, and Thailand**. According to data compiled by the Indian

Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), a unit under MHA, these scams are often run from high-security locations, reportedly controlled by Chinese operators, where trafficked people, including Indians, are forced to work.

Given the rising cases of cyber scams and frauds, which present a big challenge to India on multiple fronts, it becomes essential to cover this topic comprehensively by linking it with the static portion of the UPSC syllabus.

(Relevance: UPSC Syllabus General Studies-II, III: Government policies and interventions for development in various sectors and issues arising out of their design and implementation. Challenges to internal security through communication networks, basics of cyber security. **Cybersecurity** is an important topic for the UPSC exam. Mains questions in General Studies-III have been asked on various elements of cyber security and India's comprehensive National Cyber Security Strategy.)



Cybercrime encompasses a wide range of malicious activities, including identity theft, financial fraud, hacking, cyberstalking, and the distribution of harmful software, among others.

What will you learn from this article?

1. *What are the various forms of cybercrimes prevalent in India?*
2. *What are the key causes behind the growing number of cybercrimes in India?*
3. *What measures has the government undertaken to address the growing threat of cybercrimes?*

Question 1: What are the various forms of cybercrime prevalent in India?

On July 1, the government's flagship 'Digital India' programme completed ten years. In the last decade, India has made transformational changes in the adoption of digital technology. It has emerged as the fastest-growing digital economy. As it continues to expand, it has become a way of life for citizens. But this digital revolution has also produced some challenges not only for policymakers but also for the security apparatus. These challenges come in different forms of cybercrime.

In general, cybercrime is defined as "any unlawful act where a computer, communication device, or computer network is used to commit or facilitate the commission of a crime."

Cybercrime has diversified and escalated in scope. Key forms of cybercrime include:

1. Phishing: It is a common type of cyberattack that targets individuals through email, text messages, phone calls, and other forms of communication. A phishing attack aims to trick the recipient into falling for the attacker's desired action, such as revealing financial information, system login credentials, or other sensitive information. Fundamentally, these threats exploit human psychology rather than technical vulnerabilities.

2. Ransomware attacks: It is a specific type of malware. It typically locks the system to prevent users from accessing their own system or personal files. Only after receiving a ransom demand by the attacker is the access regranted to the user, without which data is permanently lost or, in some cases, made publicly available.

India has witnessed a sharp 55 per cent hike in ransomware incidents, with 98 recorded attacks in 2024. The highest number of such activities was reported in May and October last year. The latest figures were revealed by the 'Ransomware Trends 2024: Insights for Global Cybersecurity Readiness' report released by CyberPeace, a non-profit organisation for cybersecurity.

3. Whale Phishing: Unlike the typical phishing scams, whale phishing, or spear phishing, is focused on specific individuals. The difference between whaling and spear phishing is that whaling exclusively targets high-ranking individuals within an organisation, while spear phishing usually goes after a category of individuals with a lower profile.

Deepfake

*According to the **Digital Threat Report 2024**, deepfakes and AI-generated content are "potent tools for intrusion, particularly in social engineering attacks...Deepfake voice and video allow cyber perpetrators to mimic the voices and appearances of executives, employees, or trusted partners." So, they constitute fake content—often in the form of videos but also other media formats such as pictures or audio—created using powerful artificial intelligence (AI) tools.*

4. Smishing: It is a cyberattack that targets individuals through SMS or text messages. The term is a combination of ‘SMS’ and ‘phishing’.

5. Vishing (short for voice phishing):

It consists of phone calls from fraudsters pretending to be officials, such as bank representatives, tricking victims into revealing OTPs or account details.

6. Cyber stalking: It is the use of electronic communication by a person to follow a person, or attempts to contact a person to foster personal interaction repeatedly despite a clear indication of disinterest by such person; or monitors the internet, email or any other form of electronic communication commits the offence of stalking.

7. Identity Theft: Identity theft happens when someone uses your personal information without your permission—such as your bank account number, and credit card information—to gain financial benefits or commit fraud. Thieves can use your information to access personal accounts, open up new accounts without your permission, make unauthorized transactions, or commit crimes.

8. Ponzi and Investment Schemes: Apps and websites promising unrealistic high returns, often operating without regulatory oversight, lure users into fraudulent schemes.

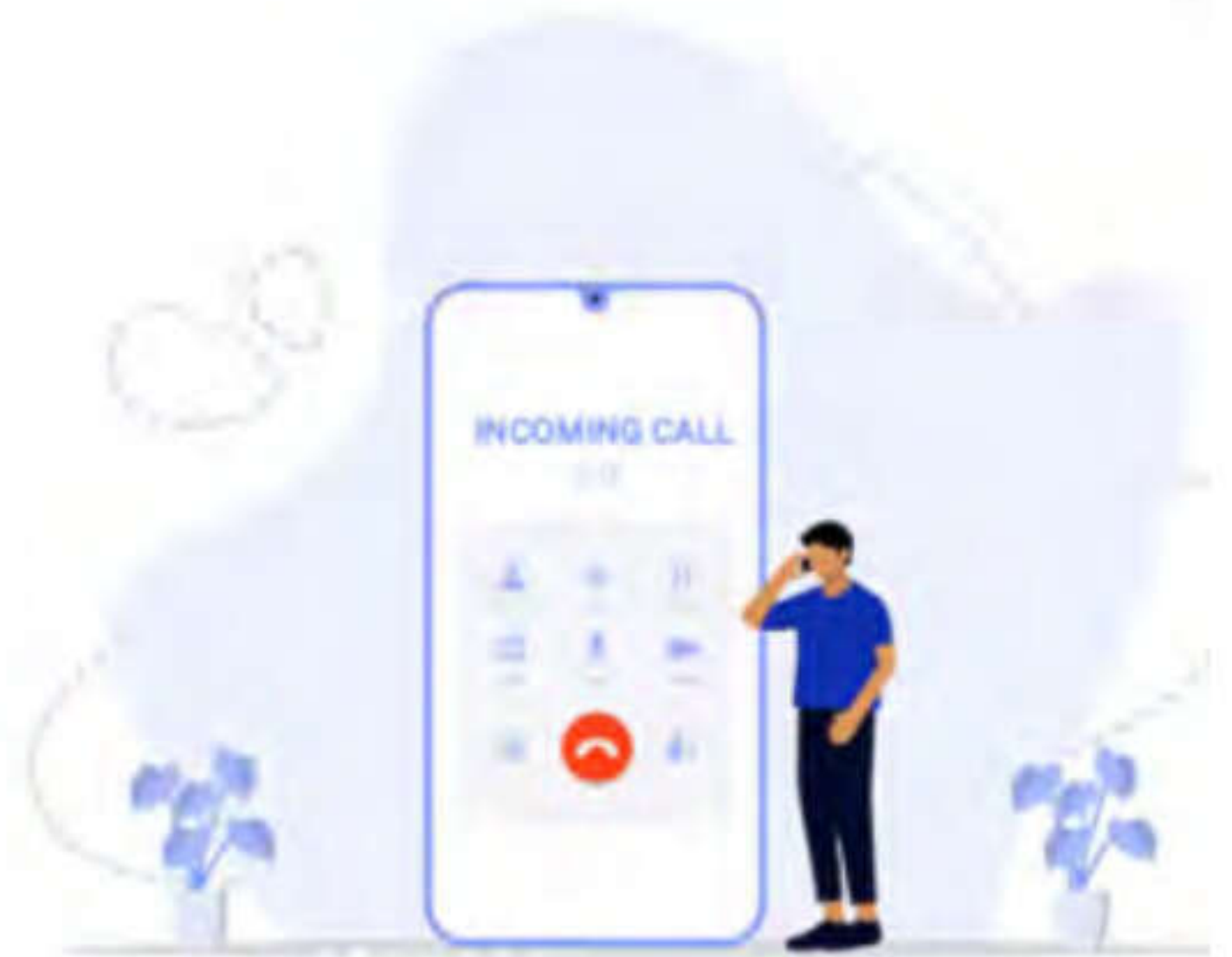
9. Trojan horse: It is a destructive program that looks as a genuine application. Unlike viruses, Trojan horses do not replicate themselves but they can be just as destructive. Trojans open a backdoor entry to your computer which gives malicious users/programs access to your system, allowing confidential and personal information to be theft.

Digital Arrest

A “Digital Arrest” scam involves fraudsters impersonating law enforcement via video calls, threatening fake arrests to extort money.

Digital arrests often begin with a simple call from an unknown number.

What follows is fear, panic, and in many cases — a complete wipeout of savings.



FatBoyPanel

FatBoyPanel is a mobile-first banking trojan that has been discovered across nearly 900 different applications, primarily targeting Indian users. The attack begins with social engineering: scammers pose as officials or trusted entities and approach users via WhatsApp. They then send a malicious APK, encouraging the user to install it. Once installed, the app gains access to sensitive data and steals one-time passwords (OTPs) to execute unauthorised transactions.

How AI adds to the cybercrime challenge

Cyber threats have transformed into sophisticated, AI-powered operations, meticulously designed to exploit human vulnerabilities. Ankita Deshkar of The Indian Express writes, “Latest attacks are becoming increasingly complex and

difficult to detect. These aren't just incremental improvements—they represent a fundamental reimagining of digital threat strategies.” She mentions Dr. Chiranjiv Roy, Global Head of Data Science, Machine Learning, and Applied Generative AI at C5i.ai, who lists some common threats. Here is the list:

- 1. Personalised phishing:** AI enables attackers to scrape social media profiles and create highly targeted phishing emails. For instance, a professional in Bengaluru might receive an email mimicking a local job portal, claiming to offer a high-paying job at Infosys.
- 2. Deepfake technology:** AI-generated voices and videos are used in vishing calls to impersonate trusted figures. For example, deepfake voice calls of CEOs have been used to authorise fraudulent financial transfers in Indian companies too.
- 3. Polymorphic malware:** AI-powered phishing campaigns can deploy malware that constantly evolves its code, bypassing traditional antivirus programs.
- 4. Chatbots for smishing:** AI bots mimic human-like interactions in messaging platforms like WhatsApp or Telegram, making fraudulent schemes more believable.

Ankita Deshkar concludes, “during the COVID-19 pandemic, cyber attacks reached new heights. Smishing attacks claiming to offer COVID-19 relief funds were common and led to widespread data theft.”

Question 2: What are the key causes behind the growing number of cybercrimes in India?

With the rapid digitalisation, exposure to cyber threats and digital risks has increased, which are getting sophisticated day by day. The surge in digital fraud is a matter of concern. Frauds present multiple challenges for the financial system in the form of reputational risk, operational risk, business risk and the erosion of customer confidence with financial stability implications. It also presents a security challenge. In this context, to tackle the cybercrime challenge, first understanding the factors contributing to the surge in cybercrimes in India is essential.

One of the primary reasons for the increase in cybercrime cases is the **exponential growth in the number of internet users**. As more people conduct their financial transactions, social interactions, and professional activities online, the opportunities for cybercriminals to exploit vulnerabilities have multiplied. The sophistication of cyber attacks has also evolved, with criminals employing advanced techniques such as phishing, ransomware, and social engineering to breach security measures.

Additionally, the shift to **remote work and increased online activities** expanded the attack surface for cybercriminals. Many individuals and organisations were unprepared for the rapid digital transition, leaving gaps in their cybersecurity defences that were easily exploited.

Another contributing factor is the **anonymity and borderless nature of the internet**, which allows cybercriminals to operate from any location, making it challenging for law enforcement agencies to track and prosecute offenders. **The lack of stringent cybersecurity laws and international cooperation** in some regions further complicates efforts to combat cybercrime.

Question 3: What measures has the government undertaken to address the growing threat of cybercrimes?

India has a comprehensive legal framework to address cybercrimes. **The Information Technology Act, 2000**, covers

offences related to phishing, smishing, and vishing, prescribing fines and imprisonment.

The three new criminal laws, namely, the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023, the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, and the Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, 2023, repealed the British-era Indian Penal Code, the Code of Criminal Procedure, and the Indian Evidence Act, respectively, and also address the evolving digital landscape and the growing threat of cybercrime.

Rameesh Kailasam writes, “The three laws enable the registration of electronic First Information Reports (FIRs) and establish electronic evidence as a primary form of proof. Under the BNSS, 2023, data collection is permitted for criminal identification. Additionally, it stipulates that all trials, inquiries, and proceedings may be conducted in electronic mode. The production of electronic communication devices, likely to contain digital evidence, will be allowed for investigation, inquiry, or trial.

The Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, 2023, appears to adapt to the digital age. It classifies electronic records as documents. Under the Indian Evidence Act, electronic records are classified as secondary evidence. However, under the new law, electronic records are categorised as primary evidence. It expands such records to include information stored in semiconductor memory or any communication devices (such as smartphones, and laptops).

The new laws facilitate the enhanced use of technology for efficient evidence collection and presentation. It is evident that these amendments to India’s legal framework will ease both investigation and the judicial process, particularly for cases related to cybersecurity.”

Other initiatives

The changing geopolitical and economic shifts have also compelled the Indian government to take active steps to evolve in cyberspace. Thus, beyond the legal framework, various other measures have also been taken by the government.

1. Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C): It was officially inaugurated by Home Minister Shri Amit Shah on the 10th of January 2020, to combat cybercrime in the country and strengthen the overall security apparatus to fight against cybercrime.

In September 2024, four I4C platforms—the **Cyber Fraud Mitigation Centre (CFMC)**, the **‘Samanvaya’ platform**, the **Cyber Commandos programme** and the **Suspect Registry**—were inaugurated by the Home Minister.

The **Central Suspect Registry** serves as a central-level database with consolidated data on cybercrime suspects from across the country. The **National Cybercrime Reporting Portal (NCRP)** has been tasked with establishing the Suspect Registry.

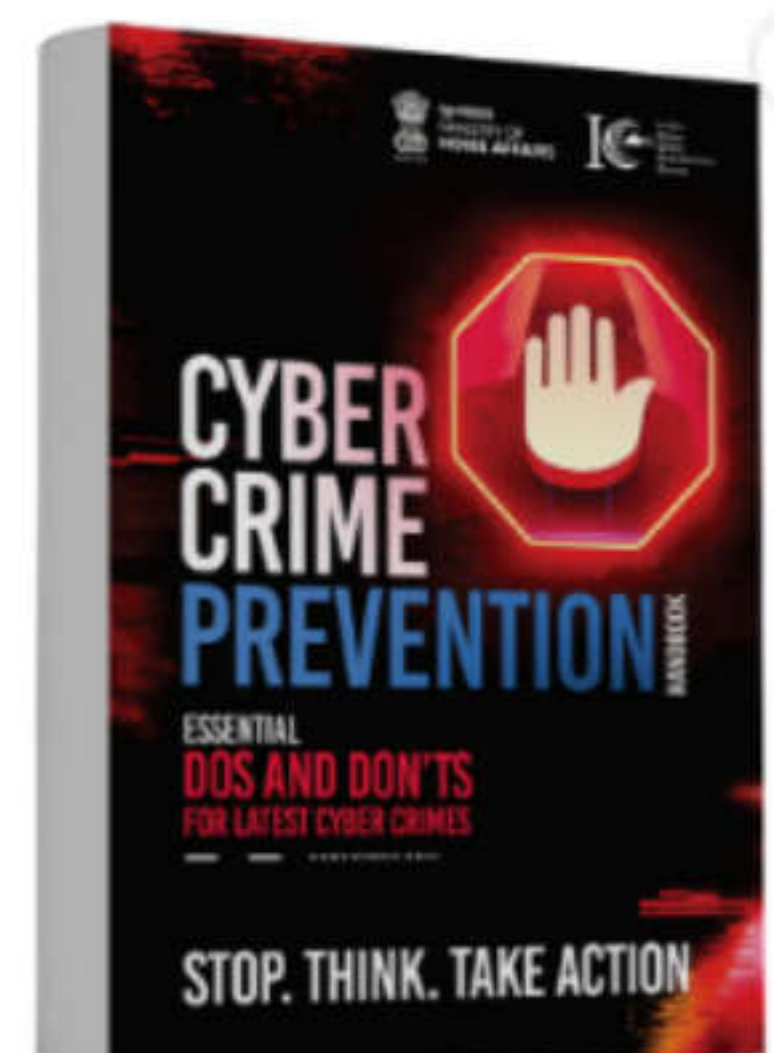
The **CFMC** focuses on addressing online financial fraud and scams. It looks to prevent cybercrimes by facilitating cooperation between various stakeholders such as major banks, payment aggregators, telecom companies, Internet



What about the govt?

A Home Ministry cybercrime handbook says:

- ✗ There's no such thing as 'digital arrest'
- ✗ Police never conduct video interrogations
- ✓ Report suspicious calls on cybercrime.gov.in



Service Providers (ISPs), central agencies, and local police on a single platform.

The **Samanvaya Platform**, also known as the **Joint Cybercrime Investigation Facilitation System**, is designed as a single repository of data pertaining to cyber crimes.

2. Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In): Under the provisions of section 70B of the Information Technology (IT) Act, 2000, the **CERT-In** is designated as the national agency for responding to cyber security incidents. The CERT-In plays a vital role in controlling cybersecurity incidents and coordinating incident response activities. It acts as the central agency for incident response, vulnerability handling, and security management in India's cyberspace.

3. Cyber Swachhta Kendra: The Cyber Swachhta Kendra is an initiative that focuses on detecting and removing malicious botnet programmes from computers and devices. It provides free tools for malware analysis and helps improve the security of systems and devices.

4. 'bank.in' domain for banks: To combat the increasing number of digital payment frauds, in February this year, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) announced the introduction of the 'bank.in', an exclusive internet domain for Indian banks. On 22nd April, the regulator decided to operationalise the '. bank.in' domain for banks. A domain name is used to find websites. It is considered a symbol of national identity on the global internet.

This exclusive internet domain for domestic banks will minimise cyber security threats and will help in strengthening trust in the country's digital banking and payment services. With the migration to the new domain, all banks in the country will have '.bank.in' as the domain name. Currently, banks are either using '.com' or '.co.in' as their domain name, which is more generic. The RBI has given banks time till October 31, 2025 to migrate to '.bank.in'.

5. National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal: It is an initiative of Government of India to facilitate victims/complainants to report cyber crime complaints online. The portal caters to all types of cyber crime complaints including complaints pertaining to online Child Pornography (CP), Child Sexual Abuse Material (CSAM) or sexually explicit content such as Rape/Gang Rape (CP/RGR) content and other cyber crimes such as mobile crimes, online and social media crimes, online financial frauds, ransomware, hacking, cryptocurrency crimes and online cyber trafficking.

6. Citizen Financial Cyber Fraud Reporting and Management System (CFCFRMS): It has been developed by the I4C and is operated by the respective state/UT, which brings together law enforcement agencies of states/UTs, banks and financial intermediaries on a single platform to take immediate action on the complaints regarding financial cyber frauds received through helpline number 1930.

7. New e-Zero FIR: I4C has introduced the new e-Zero FIR initiative to automatically convert cyber financial crime complaints with a cheating value above Rs 10 lakh, registered on the 1930 helpline or the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal (NCRP), into FIRs.



And what are banks doing?

Some have started using tools like *MuleHunter AI*, developed by the Reserve Bank Innovation Hub.

It helps flag suspicious transactions — and could soon allow customers to activate a 'kill switch' mid-transfer.



8. Sanchar Saathi: It is a citizen-centric initiative by the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) to empower mobile users and enhance their security. It offers various services, including tracing lost/stolen mobile devices, checking the number of mobile connections in one's name, verifying the genuineness of mobile handsets, and reporting suspicious international calls with Indian numbers. The portal also facilitates reporting of unwanted or fraudulent connections.

9. MuleHunter.AI: On 6th December 2024, the RBI announced that it has created an AI-powered model called MuleHunter.AI, which could reduce digital fraud by helping banks deal with the increasing problem of "mule" bank accounts. It has been developed by the Reserve Bank Innovation Hub.

In recent years, the government has also increased the budget allocation to cybersecurity.

However, challenges remain. There is a need for effective utilisation, transparency, and accountability in fund allocation. Collaboration between the government, industry, and academia is vital for a robust approach.

It is also imperative for individuals, organisations, and governments to prioritise cybersecurity. This includes investing in robust security infrastructure, conducting regular security awareness training, and implementing strict data protection measures. Additionally, fostering international collaboration to share intelligence and best practices is crucial for effectively combating cybercrime on a global scale.

What are mule accounts?

Much like a mule carries a load, these accounts are used to transfer stolen money. The account holders may be unaware, or they may knowingly lend their identities for small sums.

Post Read Questions

Prelims

(1) In India, it is legally mandatory for which of the following to report on cyber security incidents? (UPSC CSE 2017)

1. Service providers
2. Data centres
3. Body corporate

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 1 and 2 only
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

(2) In India, under cyber insurance for individuals, which of the following benefits are generally covered, in addition to payment for the loss of funds and other benefits? (UPSC CSE 2020)

1. Cost of restoration of the computer system in case of malware disrupting access to one's computer

2. Cost of a new computer if some miscreant wilfully damages it, if proved so
3. Cost of hiring a specialised consultant to minimise the loss in case of cyber extortion
4. Cost of defence in the Court of Law if any third party files a suit

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 2 and 4 only
- (b) 1, 3 and 4 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3 and 4

(3) The terms ‘WannaCry, Petya and EternalBlue’ sometimes mentioned in the news recently are related to (UPSC CSE 2018)

- (a) Exoplanets
- (b) Cryptocurrency
- (c) Cyber attacks
- (d) Mini satellites

Mains

What are the different elements of cyber security? Keeping in view the challenges in cyber security, examine the extent to which India has successfully developed a comprehensive National Cyber Security Strategy. (UPSC CSE 2022)

Prelims Answer Key

1. (d) 2. (b) 3. (c)

(Sources: Exclusive: Indians losing Rs 1,000 crore every month to cyber frauds, Knowledge Nugget | ‘.bank.in’ domain, A look at digital banking scams, FatBoyPanel?, Unmasking digital deception, cybercrime.gov.in, static.cybercrime.gov.in, Knowledge nugget: MuleHunter.AI, India stares at a steep cyber crime challenge. Is it prepared?,sancharsaathi.gov.in)

Essays Simplified

‘Contentment is natural wealth, luxury is artificial poverty’ — Why this UPSC CSE 2025 topic isn’t just looking for answers, but for your perspective

UPSC CSE 2025 Essay Paper: What does UPSC really want from you in the topic on contentment and luxury? It challenges aspirants to go beyond surface interpretation and engage with deeper moral and ethical reasoning. But it doesn’t stop there. Check out our expert’s model essay.

The UPSC CSE Essay Paper is known for its thought-provoking philosophical quotes, testing much more than just an aspirant’s knowledge. Take, for example, a quote from the UPSC CSE Mains 2025: “Contentment is natural wealth, luxury is artificial poverty.”

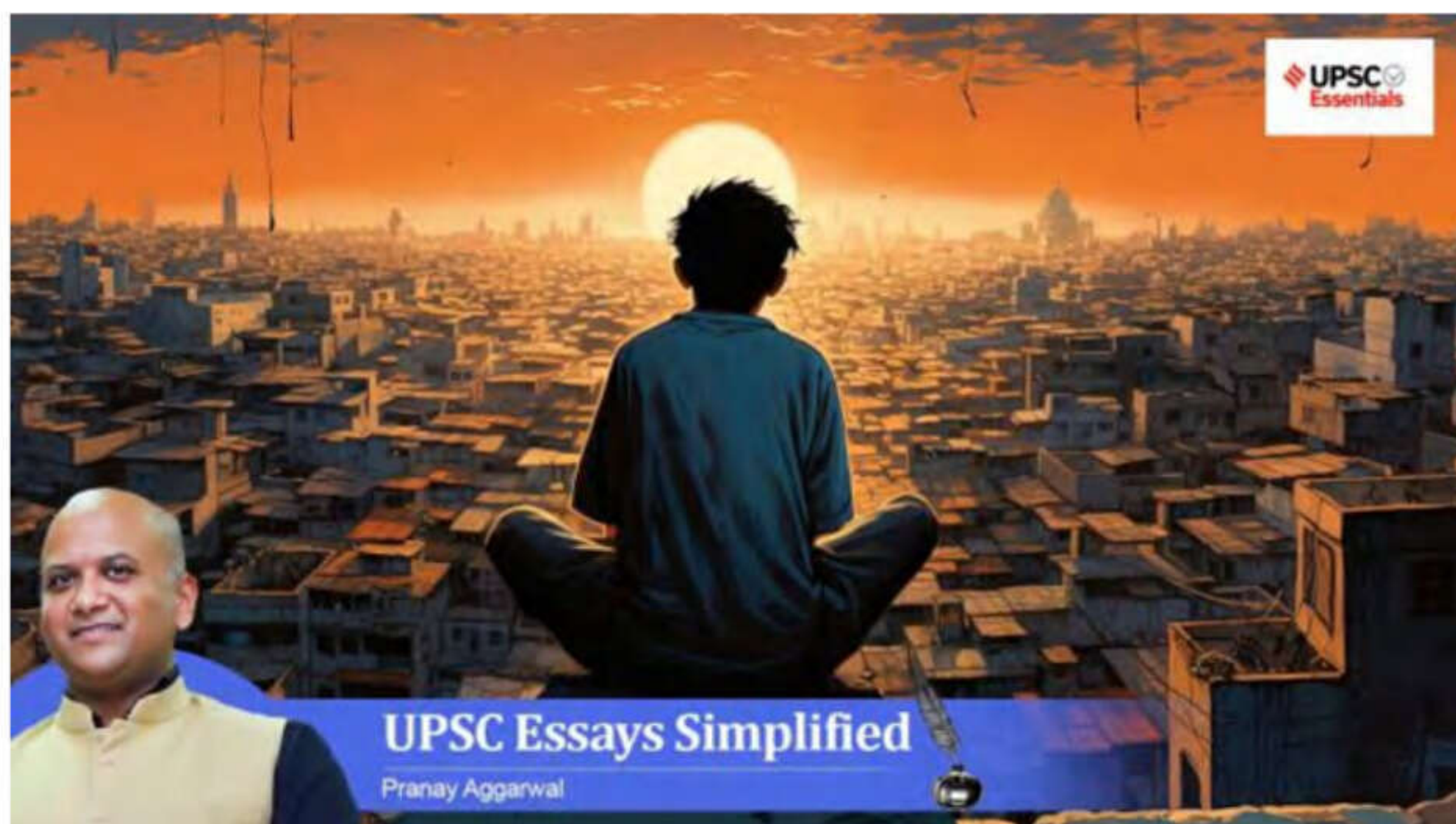
What contentment means to you? Should luxury be demonised? Attributed to Socrates, this quote explores the contrast between internal satisfaction and external

indulgence. It challenges aspirants to go beyond surface interpretation and engage with deeper moral and ethical reasoning. But it doesn’t stop there. The question also demands critical analysis of how the pursuit of luxury can paradoxically lead to a sense of lack or emptiness.

What is the real test? Relating timeless philosophy to real-life choices and societal trends. How would you approach that? How to start strong with a relatable contrast? How to weave in philosophy, psychology, economics, history, mythology, and current affairs? How to end with balance, nuance, and a call for detachment, not denial? Here’s a model essay by our expert:

Contentment is natural wealth, luxury is artificial poverty

By Pranay Aggarwal



UPSC in its essays checks whether you can think deeply, write clearly, relate abstract ideas to practical realities, and show a balanced, ethical worldview. (Image source: Freepik AI generated)

Isn't it ironic that some of the richest people in the world remain perpetually anxious and dissatisfied, while others remain secure in few material possessions? Wealth is not just our bank balances or the money in our pocket. It is what rests quietly in the mind. Contentment is that quiet wealth, a satisfaction with what one has and needing nothing more. Luxury, while may appear to be a sign of wealth, in reality is an insatiable hunger. Luxury breeds a poverty of calm and poverty of spirit, which no material abundance can cure.

Philosophical insights from diverse cultures have repeatedly warned against the trap of luxury. In Hindu philosophy, luxury is *Maya*, an illusion of ever-multiplying desires. Seductive as it is, luxury attracts and entices, promising abundance. However, it results in an endless chase. **Stoics** in ancient Greece also believed that it is not the man who has little, but the man who craves unendingly, who is poor. Prince Siddhartha too saw the luxuries of palace life as golden chains. As **Buddha**, he broke free from those chains and led a life of simplicity and contentment that produced inner wealth not just for him but millions.

Studies in **modern psychology** also show that beyond a certain income level, additional wealth and material possessions add little to one's life satisfaction. The idea of the **hedonic treadmill** suggests that while luxuries may provide a temporary high, people eventually end up as dissatisfied as before. Luxury also breeds anxiety and fear of losing status and possessions. Contentment, on the other hand, frees the mind from the tendency to perpetually measure oneself against others.

Luxuries breed resentment and envy amongst the less privileged. In fact, that's precisely what they are meant to. Veblen, in his writings, had highlighted how the rich often make purchases not for the intrinsic need that the object satisfies, but for 'conspicuous consumption' – to reinforce their superior status in society. Think of the time you bought an iPhone or a shirt of a premium brand. A cheaper phone or shirt would have met the same basic need, except for signalling your higher social status. Moreover, when a handful enjoy luxury, often the many are struggling for survival. Thus, luxury indicates socio-economic inequality. In contrast, modest living by the privileged make them more relatable and likeable.

Popular mythology also underlines how unchecked desire for **wealth can lead to ruin**. **Midas**, whose touch made everything gold, turned his blessing into a curse due to his greed for more. In Indian mythology, Vishwamitra demanded **Kamadhenu** from sage Vashishtha in return for unlimited wealth. The wise and content sage refused. When Vishwamitra tried to forcefully capture Kamadhenu, he lost his riches as well as dignity.

It is not just the stuff of legends, history also bears powerful testimony. **Luxury has toppled empires**. The ancient Romans and the French monarchy of the 18th century fell partly due to overindulgence. More recently, the violent overthrow of the government in **Nepal** was triggered by the vulgar display of wealth by the ruling elite.

However, when leadership and people value contentment, it leads to political stability and societal sustenance. In ancient times, the simple and disciplined **Spartans** outlived richer contemporaries. After the second world war, the Zen-inspired **Japanese** were able to rebuild their society. In India, leaders like **Shastri** and Gandhi, who lived simple and contented lives, inspired trust across party lines. Clearly, contentment is an invisible but important political and societal capital.

In **personal finance**, it is important to understand that luxurious living can lead to a **debt trap**. People who spend beyond their means may appear to be affluent, but lack financial security. One is reminded of an amusing anecdote. When **pop sensation Rihanna**, on the verge of bankruptcy, sued her wealth manager; he wryly responded: "Did she really needed to be told that if you buy stuff for money, you will be left with the stuff and not the money?". Simple and contented living promotes prudent consumption and frugal spending, stabilizing one's finances. No wonder that contentment is an important contributor to personal financial well-being.

Luxury costs us not only individually but also **collectively**. Consumption-driven lifestyles today can lead to reduced resources and prosperity available for future generations. As Bapu reminded us, the world has enough for everyone's needs but not enough for one man's greed. So, choosing contentment and moderation can preserve natural wealth for posterity.

Striking the Right Balance

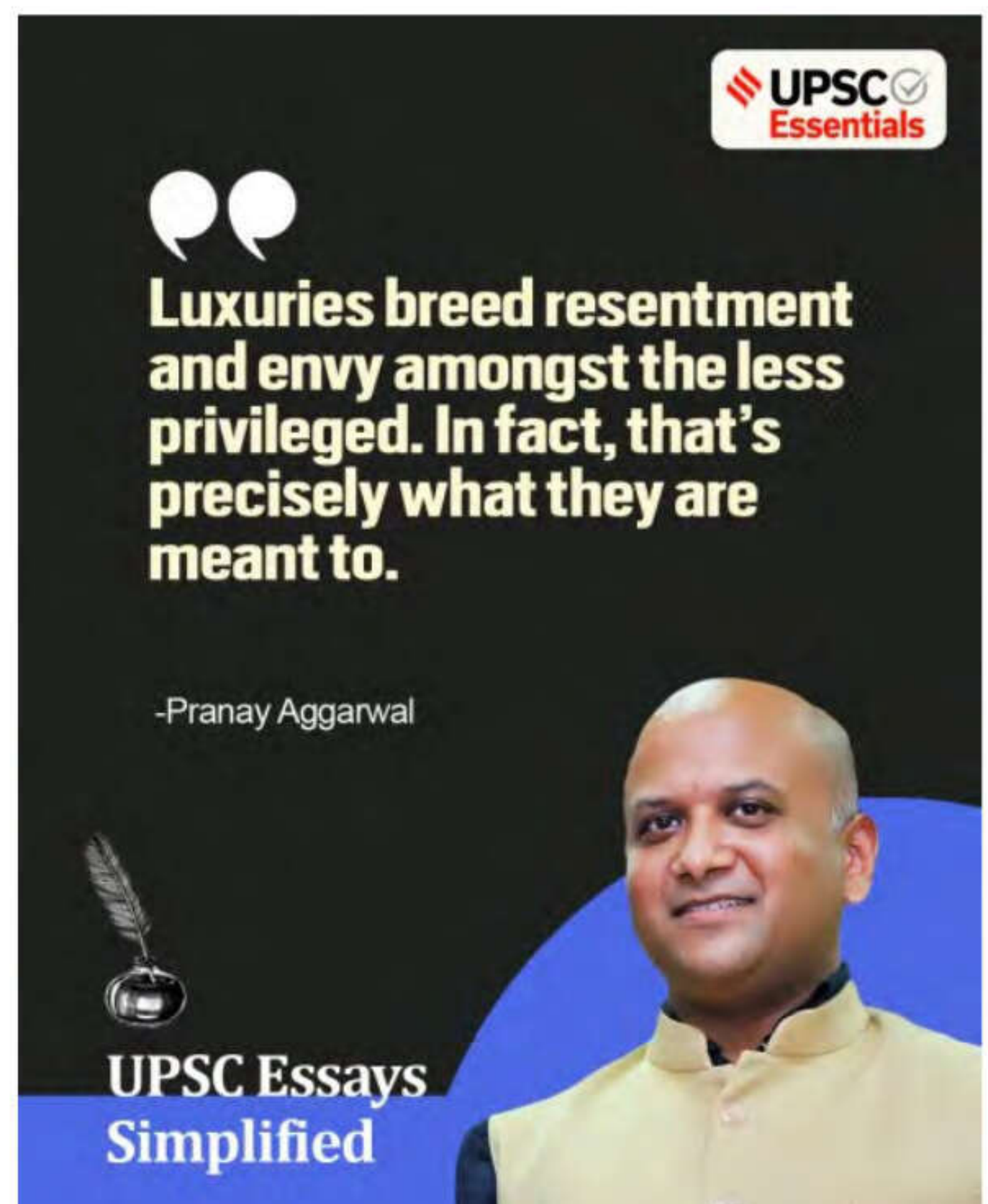
To be sure, **luxury is not 'evil' or inherently undesirable**. Luxury has spawned excellence in art and architecture. Indeed, the world would be poorer without the grandeur of the Kailasha temple or the Hathisingh Jain temple, or Gothic architecture, or the majestic pyramids. Luxury also can help to raise the standard of living of entire populations. What are once considered luxuries – like toilets, personal vehicles or mobile phones – over time become more common, advancing human civilization. As Swami Vivekananda reminded us, to an extent, material prosperity is also necessary for spiritual well-being. So, luxury, if properly moderated, can enrich life. Problem arises if luxury is idealized and relentlessly pursued for its own sake. It is a problem if it is an outcome of the accumulation of wealth in the hands of only a few, and results in envy in the hearts of many.

Equally, **contentment must not be confused with stagnation**. The contented can strive for growth, even excellence, but avoid insatiable greed. A content student studies not to out-do his peers, but from a genuine thirst for knowledge. A content office-goer does not reject the goal of increasing productivity, but avoids working himself to death for a fatter paycheck. The right balance needs to be struck between aspiration and contentment.

In the final analysis, contentment is liberating. Contentment cultivates calm, it creates character. Luxury chains one to external factors, leaving one perpetually dissatisfied. Perhaps the right attitude is that of vairagya, detachment – neither complete denial of, nor crazy obsession for material possessions.

POST READ REVIEW:

UPSC expects aspirants not just to decode the quote, but to offer a multi-layered interpretation. The philosophical depth of the essay is reflected in examples drawn from diverse traditions such as Buddhism, Hinduism, and Stoicism. The real flavour of the essay emerges when an aspirant moves beyond philosophy into history, governance, and psychological theories, connecting abstract ideas with real-life examples. At the same time, your wisdom is tested when you avoid taking an extreme position. Luxury is not always bad!



About our Expert: Pranay Aggarwal is an educator and mentor for aspirants preparing for UPSC Civil Services exam. With more than 10 years of experience guiding civil service aspirants, he is acknowledged as an expert on civil service exam preparation, especially on subjects like Social Issues and Sociology. He is the India representative on the Research Committee on Education, Religion and Political Sociology for UNESCO's International Sociological Association and a committee member of Indian Sociological Society and its committee on social movements. He is also the Convenor of Indian Civil Services Association, a think tank of senior bureaucrats.

UPSC Ethics Simplified

How and why Civil Servants should be 'enablers' of growth, not mere 'regulators'

UPSC echoed PM Modi's call for bureaucrats to be growth enablers in its Civil Services Mains 2025 Ethics question paper. Nanditesh Nilay, our ethicist, discusses this in light of the ethical foundations of civil services.

Written by **Nanditesh Nilay**

The Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) appears to be aligning its examination themes with current national discourse, often drawing from issues in the headlines or matters directly impacting the roles and responsibilities of civil servants.

A question in the UPSC Civil Services Mains Ethics paper for 2025 notably reflected this trend, appearing to draw inspiration from Prime Minister Narendra Modi's

address to civil servants earlier that year. The question read: "To achieve holistic development goals, a civil servant acts as an enabler and active facilitator of growth rather than a regulator. What specific measures will you suggest to achieve this goal?"

During the 17th Civil Services Day held at Vigyan Bhavan in April 2025, Prime Minister Modi urged bureaucrats to shift their approach—from being mere enforcers of rules to becoming proactive facilitators of growth. Emphasizing the rapid global changes underway, he highlighted the need for India's administrative machinery to evolve accordingly.

Reflecting on the past, PM Modi noted that the bureaucracy traditionally functioned as a regulator, often slowing down industrialization and entrepreneurship. However, he asserted that India has now moved beyond that mindset. The focus, he said, is on creating an enabling environment—one that supports enterprise, empowers citizens, and helps them navigate and overcome systemic barriers.

Internal and External controls

The context of administrative ethics has been discussed at length regarding the maintenance of ethical conduct through internal and external controls. Any bureaucrat has to work under the ethical framework of those controls. Both



A question in the UPSC Civil Services Mains Ethics paper for 2025 notably continued with the trend, appearing to draw inspiration from personalities like Prime Minister Narendra Modi's address to civil servants earlier that year.

internal and external controls are aimed to maintain integrity. While external controls comprise compliance of laws, regulations and administrative standards and can be of regulatory and audit nature, the internal mechanism is guided by virtues, values, and deontological ethics that elevate the means over ends to achieve a task, and even teleological ethics, which tends to elevate the ends over means. Kant has always advocated for his ideas of order and duty in governance, feeling that all higher-order rules concerned with achieving these ends must be guided by lower-order rules that dictate or govern the means.

Through the above argument, it can be deduced that a civil servant can act as an enabler and active facilitator rather than a regulator, and that irrespective of any situation. Deviating from that balancing act of means and ends can take things out of control, as we have witnessed through those visuals from Gen Z protests in Nepal. Through those internal factors, any kind of turmoil and the incipient panic of government officials on the road could have been avoided.

On the other hand, administrative evil looms large over decision-making when external control, apart from code and conduct rules, starts wielding its power on any bureaucrat. In other words, where a bureaucrat follows the rules and hierarchy of authority but fails to read the social and moral effects of their actions or decision-making. Policy decisions need to be executed with utmost sincerity and without bias or scorn, while addressing the larger cause of welfare in a democracy. Dennis F. Thompson, the political scientist, has argued that both an ethic of neutrality (decisions from politics) and an ethic of structure (decisions from higher up) obviate public-service ethics. That is because they don't hold the legitimacy of administrative and professional discretion.

From Regulation to Facilitation: Ethical Foundations of Public Service

How can administrators be enablers and active facilitators? According to the 2015 World Public Sector Report titled 'Responsive and Accountable Public Governance', responsiveness and accountability are two fundamental principles of governance which are key, cross-cutting enablers of development. They lead to a collective vision of sustainable development. Responsiveness to people needs an approach to identify present necessities. They also need to foresee future needs, and to plan policies accordingly. Accountability should be seen as the obligation of a government or organization to account for one's activities, accept responsibility for them, and to disclose the results in a transparent manner. Participation is another important aspect of governance. Citizens, as well as civil society organizations, need to be involved in the formulation, design and evaluation of public policies, programs, legislation and services related to administration. All the above suggestions will only be effectively carried out if the internal control and will is strong, ethical and civil servants adapt to new challenges and be solution oriented.

In a technology-driven world, human judgement and human values still hold a very important place especially in civil services. Hence, civil servants must always listen to people's voices and should be aware of their needs. Only coming up with policies and implementation of them won't suffice. Being an active enabler means that the policies on ground should be solution oriented serving the needs of the beneficiaries on priority. The scheme should reach the people and should have a real impact in their lives. This will ensure quality in governance.

A civil servant can only act as an enabler if the internal and external controls are well balanced, ethics as conduct facilitates the dictum of compliance, and decision-making doesn't find those influencers in the form of personality biases. To put it in Max Weber's phrase: *sine ira et studio* (without bias or contempt).

POST READ QUESTION:

Responsiveness and accountability as two fundamental principles of governance which are key, cross-cutting enablers of development. Discuss.

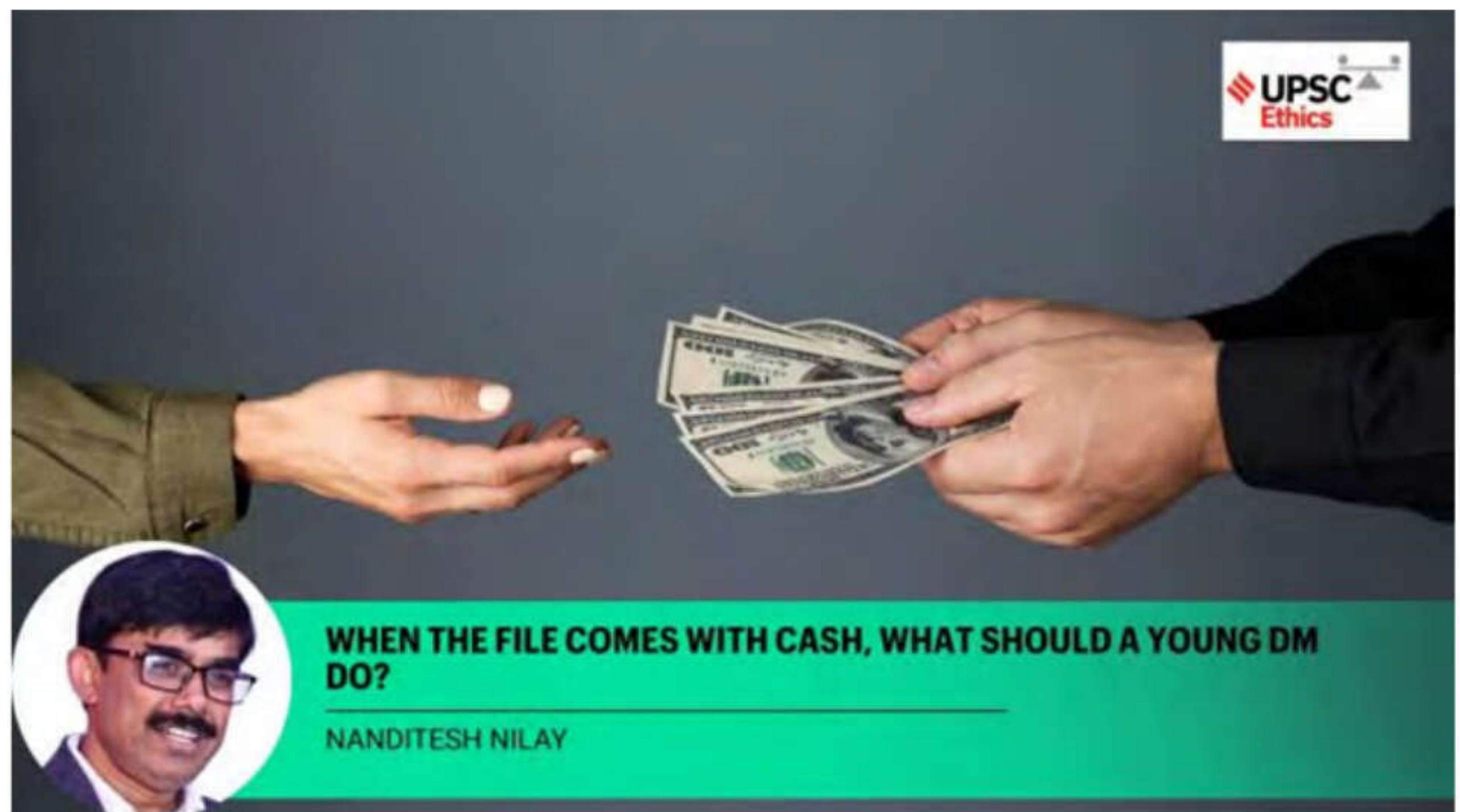
When the file comes with cash, what should a young DM do?

How should a civil servant respond to the first test of power? When young bureaucrats falter under the weight of temptation, Nanditesh Nilay, our ethicist, reminds us of the true meaning of power.

Written by **Nanditesh Nilay**

Often, we read news headlines about young civil servants — those who worked tirelessly to qualify for the services — being accused of corruption. The tempting nature of power needs to be addressed across all professions in general, and in the civil services in particular. UPSC has often framed questions and case studies, directly or indirectly, around this issue. However, what is often seen is that

aspirants tend to jump straight to legal frameworks or consequences when answering ethics questions, painting officials in black and white. Nanditesh Nilay, our ethicist, takes us to the core of the issue: **temptation**.



“Civil services are often seen as centers of power. But we must remember: power and ethics have something in common.” (Representational image: Freepik)

A Caselet

That was his first assignment as District Collector. It began with a case where a senior health department officer came to meet the newly appointed DM. The officer requested a meeting at the DM’s residence, citing personal issues that couldn’t be discussed in the office. The DM agreed. After sharing a few concerns, the officer left — but also left behind some money in a file, apparently related to a case awaiting approval.

The DM acted swiftly and decided to file an FIR against him. Some colleagues felt this was too extreme. Nevertheless, the FIR was filed, the officer was arrested, and eventually terminated from service.

Many, however, believed the DM had acted naively. The issue was systemic, and he should have simply returned the money with a stern warning.

When we examine recent instances of corruption, it becomes clear how deeply troubling they are for young professionals. They see young bureaucrats faltering under the weight of temptation. Often, the average citizen can clearly tell what should and shouldn’t be done — by officials in public life and by individuals in private. A list of “shoulds” may include ideals and ethical absolutes; the “should nots” must include all forms of unethical behavior—especially those temptations that erode integrity.

Temptation and Power

The Oxford English Dictionary defines temptation as “the action of tempting or fact of being tempted, especially to evil.” In this case, the officer tempted the DM, who chose not to succumb. Temptation carries both active and passive forms, and both involve a kind of moral distancing—a loss of wisdom, a separation from reason. A dinner party, a drink, or a gift may start innocently—just a cup of coffee—but can easily end in compromise.

Paul M. Hughes, in ‘The Logic of Temptation’, writes:

“Temptation is normally thought to be morally dubious, in part because it involves desiring what we think is immoral, imprudent, illegal, unaesthetic, or in some other way wrong or bad.”

Bribery is especially dangerous because it persuades and seduces, regardless of the risk of being caught. That’s why it’s essential to recognize subtle temptations in one’s habits, lifestyle, and desires. These seemingly small indulgences can undermine both the efficiency and the moral clarity of a public servant. The principles of Asteya (non-stealing) and Aparigraha (non-possessiveness) remind us of the need for self-awareness and restraint.

A mind that yields to temptation loses sight of the corrosive nature of greed and power—vices that often appear harmless or even colorless on the surface. Temptation which leads to corruption begins with a gift and ends with a compromise.

Civil services are often seen as centers of power. But we must remember: power and ethics have something in common—they both deeply influence our actions. Ethics can help rein in temptation, while unchecked power can act like a wild horse. Power naturally stirs desire, both noble and base.

Temptation can only be managed wisely through conscious habits and a regular reflection on the purpose of power. As Plato said, the idea of power is inseparable from “the good,” and the true measure of a person lies in what they do with that power.

To all young civil servants

It is important to develop a strong ethical foundation and maintain clear personal boundaries. Along with practicing transparency and accountability, surround yourself with honest people — and most importantly, reflect regularly on your role, purpose, and the power that this service entrusts to you.

Temptations that lead to corruption, if not overcome, become habits — and habits define the soul of governance. Let those habits be guided by integrity, not indulgence.

Post Read Question for UPSC CSE Ethics paper:

“The accomplice to the crime of corruption is often our own silence.” Do you agree?

(The writer is the author of ‘Being Good’, ‘Aaiye, Insaan Banaen’, ‘Kyon’ and ‘Ethikos: Stories Searching Happiness’. He teaches courses on and offers training in ethics, values and behaviour. He has been the expert/consultant to UPSC, SAARC countries, Civil services Academy, National Centre for Good Governance, Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), Competition Commission of India (CCI), etc. He has PhD in two disciplines and has been a Doctoral Fellow in Gandhian Studies from ICSSR. His second PhD is from IIT Delhi on Ethical Decision Making among Indian Bureaucrats. He writes for the UPSC Ethics Simplified (concepts and caselets) fortnightly.)

UPSC Current Affairs Pointers

Prelims Tidbits from the month of September

UPSC Current Affairs Pointers aim to help you consolidate your Prelims and Mains preparation. Take a quick look at key current affairs tidbits from September 1, 2025, to September 28, 2025 — curated especially for aspirants preparing for the UPSC, State PSC, and other competitive examinations.

Compiled by: **Khushboo Kumari**

Reports

(FYI: The data provided in these reports can be used to substantiate your Mains answer, add value to your answers, and create a broad understanding of the topic.)

- **Sample Registration Survey Statistical Report for 2023**

—Recently, the 2023 Sample Registration Survey carried out by the Office of the Registrar General & Census Commissioner, India (ORGI), was released.

—It is the largest demographic survey in the country, mandated to provide annual estimates of fertility as well as mortality indicators at the State and National level.

— It shows India's **Infant Mortality Rate (IMR)** dropped more than 37 per cent in the last decade, from 40 deaths per 1,000 births in 2013 to 25 in 2023.



India's IMR fell below the world average around 2021, and has been showing a faster decline than the global rate.[Representative image]

— India's **Total Fertility Rate (TFR)** has fallen for the first time in two years to **1.9 in 2023**. In 2021 and 2022, India's TFR remained constant at 2.0. **Bihar** reported the **highest TFR at 2.8**, while **Delhi** recorded the lowest at 1.2

— India's **Crude Birth Rate (CBR)**, the number of children born per 1,000 people in the population in a year, during 2023 stands at 18.4, exhibiting a decline of 0.7 points over 2022. Among the bigger States/UTs, the maximum CBR has been reported in Bihar (25.8) and the minimum in Tamil Nadu (12.0).

— In 2023, the **Under-5 Mortality Rate (U5MR)** for the Country has shown a decline of 1 point from 2022 (29 in 2023 against 30 in 2022).

— India's **Sex Ratio at Birth** has gone up by 3 points to **917 in 2021-23** from 914 in 2020-22. The highest Sex Ratio

was registered in Chhattisgarh (974) and Kerala (971), while Uttarakhand has the lowest (868).

(Source: Census.gov.in)

- ◆ **Total Fertility Rate (TFR):** According to the website of OECD, the total fertility rate in a specific year is defined as the total number of children that would be born to each woman if she were to live to the end of her child-bearing years and give birth to children in alignment with the prevailing age-specific fertility rates.
- ◆ **Crude Birth Rate (CBR):** According to the WHO, The crude birth rate is the annual number of live births per 1,000 population. It is generally computed as a ratio. The numerator is the number of live births observed in a population during a reference period and the denominator is the number of person-years lived by the population during the same period.
- ◆ **Infant Mortality Rate (IMR):** The infant mortality rate is the number of deaths of a baby that occur between the time it is born and 1 year of age out of every 1,000 live births.
- ◆ **Under-5 Mortality Rate:** It is the number of children who die by the age of 5 years, per 1000 live births.

● **World Mental Health Today and Mental Health Atlas 2024**

— The **World Health Organisation (WHO)** has published two reports – ‘World Mental Health Today’ and ‘Mental Health Atlas 2024.’

— According to the report, Suicide accounts for **one in every 100 deaths globally**. An estimated 727,000 people across all ages lost their lives to suicide in 2021, with one suicide death happening in over 20 suicide attempts.

— The most common mental disorders are anxiety and depressive disorders, which together accounted for more than two-thirds of all mental health conditions in 2021.

— Younger adults aged 20–29 years are estimated to have the largest increases (1.8 per cent) in prevalence since 2011.

— **Males** are estimated to more commonly have attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder (ADHD), autism spectrum disorders, and idiopathic disorder of intellectual development.

— **Females** are estimated to more often experience anxiety, depressive, and eating disorders.

● **India’s Climate Finance Requirements: An Assessment**

— The study, by Janak Raj and Rakesh Mohan of the Centre for Social and Economic Progress (CSEP), is the first-of-its-kind bottoms-up sector-specific assessment of requirements of climate finance in India.

— According to the study, an additional investment of about **\$467 billion between now and 2030** would be needed to enable a significant decarbonisation of four of India’s most emissions-intensive sectors - power, steel, cement and road transport sectors.

— The study assessed the steel sector’s requirement till 2030 as \$251 billion and that of cement to be \$141 billion.

— The power sector, which is already undergoing a rapid transformation due to deployment of renewables, would need about \$47 billion additional investment until 2030, while road transport would require \$18 billion, the study said.

— The authors said the cumulative **\$467 billion** would help India not just easily achieve its international commitments

for 2030 under the Paris Agreement, but advance much further on the road to low-carbon development.

● India's Cancer Map

— Key findings of an analysis by researchers from premier institutions, based on data collected from 43 cancer registries across the country between 2015 and 2019 — a period when 7.08 lakh cancer cases and 2.06 lakh deaths were recorded — provided a broader understanding of India's Cancer Map.

— Women accounted for a higher proportion of the total cancer cases (51.1%) recorded in the registries but a lower proportion of deaths (45%).

— **Oral cancer** has overtaken lung cancer as the most common type of the disease among men.

— The incidence of cancers was the **highest in the Northeast**, with the highest occurrence of cervical cancer, lung cancer in women, and oral cancer in women all reported from states in this region.

— **Breast and cervical cancers**, which together account for 40% of cases in women, are easier to detect early and have better outcomes.

● Global Innovation Index 2025

— The Global Innovative Index 2025 is published by the **World Intellectual Property Organisation (WIPO)**. It shows that R&D growth fell to 2.9 per cent in 2024 and is expected to drop further to 2.3 per cent in 2025.

— Switzerland is the world's most innovative country, followed by Sweden, the United States and others.

— Europe leads as the most innovative region, with 15 countries in the global top 25.

— India is ranked 38 and holds the **#1** spot among *lower-middle-income economies* and in the *Central and Southern Asia region*.

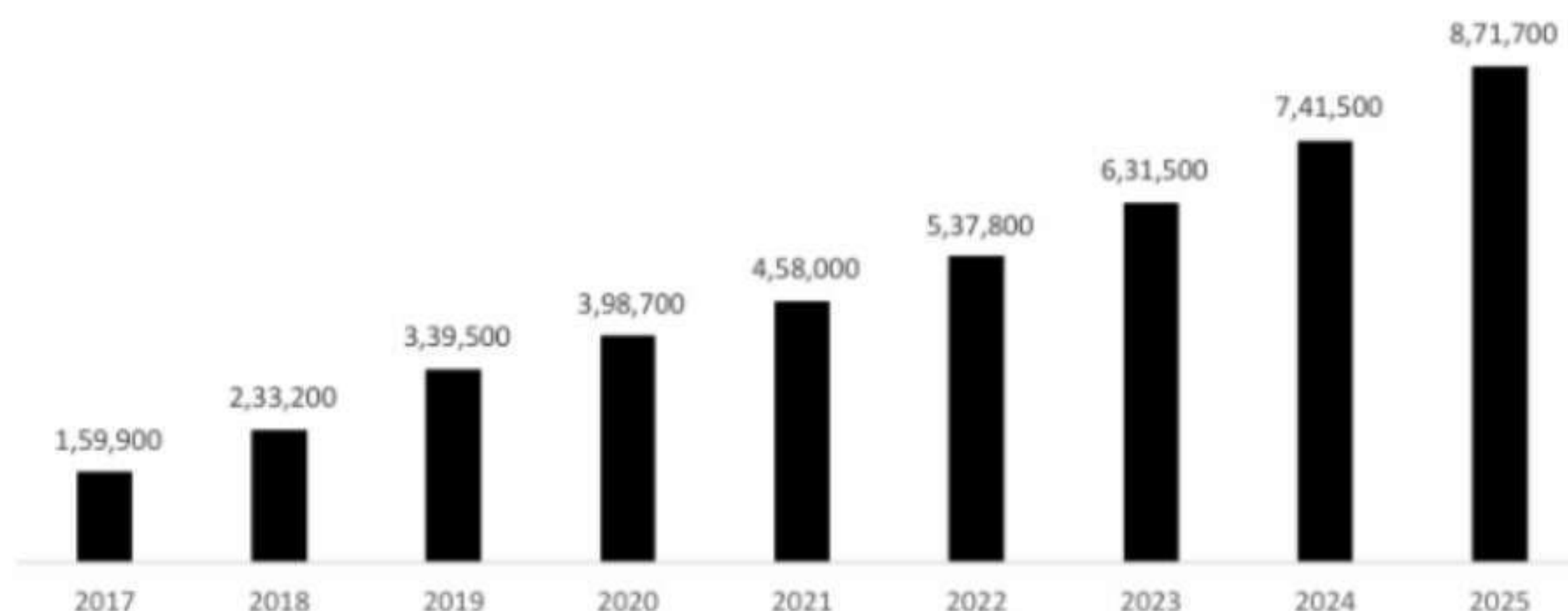
— India performs best in **Knowledge & Technology Outputs (#22)** and **Market Sophistication (#38)**, while its weakest rankings are in **Business Sophistication (#64)**, **Infrastructure (#61)**, and **Institutions (#58)**.

● Hurun India Wealth Report 2025

— According to the latest Mercedes-Benz Hurun India Wealth Report 2025, India is projected to have 871,700 millionaire families by 2025, each with a net worth of at least Rs 8.5 crore (US\$1 million).

— This marks a sharp jump from 159,900 in 2017 and 458,000 in 2021 — an increase of nearly 90 per cent over four years.

— Millionaire families now represent about 0.31 per cent of India's population. However, the report shows that wealth creation remains heavily concentrated.



Source: Hurun Research Institute; Mercedes-Benz Hurun India Wealth Report 2025

The number of millionaire families in India has increased over the years.

— Maharashtra has consolidated its position as the country's richest state, home to 178,600 millionaire families — a 194 per cent rise since 2021. Mumbai is at the top among the cities, followed by New Delhi and Bangalore.

● **World Trade Report 2025**

— According to the World Trade Report 2025 released by the **World Trade Organization**, artificial intelligence could boost the value of trade in goods and services by nearly 40% by 2040, but without adequate policies it could also exacerbate economic divides.

— Lower trade costs and enhanced productivity could drive substantial increases in trade and GDP by 2040, with global trade projected to rise by 34-37% under various scenarios.

● **CPCB Report on river pollution**

— The Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) assessment report released recently reviewed the water quality data from 2022 and 2023, covering 2,116 locations. The last assessment of identifying polluted stretches was carried out in 2022, using data from 2019 and 2021.

— According to the report, Polluted river stretches in India have **decreased marginally from 311 to 296**, with a reduction in most polluted stretches as well.

— It found that **296 river stretches were polluted** on 271 rivers across 32 states and Union Territories. Maharashtra continues to have the highest number (54) of polluted river stretches.

— Out of 296 stretches identified as polluted, 37 were classified as the most polluted, or Priority I. BOD concentrations exceeding 30 mg/L are categorised as Priority I or the most polluted stretches.

— These 37 stretches were identified across 14 states, with the highest number, five, in Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh, and Uttarakhand; four in Gujarat, and three in Karnataka.

A polluted river stretch refers to two or more polluted locations on a river in a continuous sequence.

Biochemical oxygen demand (BOD) is a key indicator of water quality. It measures the oxygen needed to break down organic matter. Any location/stretch of the river having a Biological Oxygen Demand (BOD) of more than 3mg/l is identified as polluted and unsuitable for outdoor bathing.

Art & Culture

● **Kolhan's Manki-Munda system**

— On September 9, the Ho tribe staged a protest in Jharkhand's West Singhbhum district against the Deputy Commissioner (DC), accusing him of interfering with their traditional self-governance system by removing village heads, known as Mundas.

— This conflict threatens a century-old balance between the indigenous governance system, the so-



Adivasis organised a march in Kolhan last week. (Special arrangement)

called Manki-Munda system, and the state administration in Ho areas of Jharkhand's Kolhan region.

— The **Munda**, or the **head of the village**, was responsible for resolving socio-political disputes at the village level. Each village had one Munda, appointed hereditarily.

— The **Manki** headed the **pir**, which generally consists of 8 to 15 villages. If cases were not resolved by the Munda, they moved upwards to the Manki.

— The Manki and Munda had no **responsibilities for revenue** or land-related issues. The system was purely an internal, self-governing mechanism, with no sovereign authority outside or the concept of paying taxes.

● **Jore Sahib**

— The Jore Sahib will be kept at the Patna Sahib Gurudwara, Union Minister Hardeep Singh Puri announced on October 4.

— The Jore Sahib, meaning holy or sacred shoes, are a pair of footwear belonging to Guru Gobind Singh, the last of the ten Sikh Gurus, and his wife Mata Sahib Kaur.

— It is considered a sacred relic as it is revered as the personal belongings once worn by the Sikh spiritual leaders.

— The pair of footwear, measuring 11" by 3½" for the right foot of the 'Dasam Pita', or Tenth Father, and 9" by 3" for the left foot of Mata Sahib Kaur, are sacred relics deeply revered in Sikhism.

— **Guru Gobind Singh**, the last human Guru of the Sikhs, founded the Khalsa Panth, or the community of the pure. He declared the **Guru Granth Sahib** as the eternal successor.

— He laid down a code of conduct for followers through the **five K's**: Kesh (uncut hair), Kangha (wooden comb), Kada (iron or steel wrist bracelet), Kirpan (sword), and Kachera (short breeches).

● **Global Ayyappa Sangamam**

— The Supreme Court on September 17 virtually gave the go-ahead for the Kerala government to conduct the Global Ayyappa Sangamam event at Pampa, the base station of the Sabarimala Temple.

— The Agola Ayyappa Sangamam, or the Global Conclave of Ayyappa Devotees, is organised by the **Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB)**, an autonomous body that administers 1,250-odd temples in southern Kerala.

— This board also administers the Sabarimala temple and this event aims to promote the Sabarimala Temple as a global pilgrimage centre.

● **Sarnath on the UNESCO radar**

— Ahead of a UNESCO team's proposed visit to Sarnath, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) will install what it is calling a "corrected" plaque that will credit a local ruler, and not the British, for preserving the holy Buddhist site.

— Earlier this year, India officially nominated



Sarnath for the **UNESCO World Heritage List** for the 2025-26 cycle — a move that could end its 27-year wait on the tentative list.

— Sarnath, roughly 10 km to the northeast of Varanasi, is where the Buddha is said to have delivered his first sermon in c. 528 BCE, and the place at which the Buddhist sangha (community) is said to have formed. The delivery of the first sermon is referred to as *dhammachakka-pavattana* (the turning of the wheel of dhamma).

— The credit for its “rediscovery”, however, goes to workers of Jagat Singh, the diwan of Raja Chait Singh of Benares, who were digging at the site to retrieve brick and stone for a new marketplace being built in his name.

● **Jamdani Saree**

— The first-ever Jamdani Exposition was organised at the National Crafts Museum.

— Jamdani is traditionally crafted from cotton, and is celebrated for its fine, airy texture and elegance. It is a centuries-old handwoven textile from the Bengal region.

— The name “jamdani” derives from the Persian words jam (flower) and dani (vase), describing its floral designs.

— In 2013, **UNESCO recognized Jamdani weaving as an Intangible Cultural Heritage**, underscoring its cultural and historical significance.



*Bangladeshi Jamdani sharee stal at Science sarees at a stall.
(Express File Photo: Partha Paul)*

● **Tripura Sundari Temple**

— Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the redeveloped five-century-old Tripura Sundari Temple at Udaipur in Gomati district on 22nd September.

— The Tripura Sundari Temple is one of the **51 Hindu shaktipeetha** shrines across the country, and attracts lakhs of devotees every year.

— The Tripura Sundari Temple was built by **Maharaj Dhanya Manikya Bahadur** in 1501 when Udaipur, then known as Rangamati, was the capital of the erstwhile Manikya kingdom.

— The temple is built atop a hillock resembling the back of a turtle. It is located 60 km from Agartala.

— According to Tripura Rajmala, the royal chronicle of the Manikya kings, Maharaj Dhanya Manikya Bahadur constructed the temple in 1501 following a ‘swapnadesh’ or divine commandment from the Supreme Mother or Aadishakti in his dream.

Events

• Semicon India 2025

— The ‘Semicon India – 2025’, aimed at catalysing India’s Semiconductor ecosystem, was inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at **Yashobhoomi in New Delhi**.

— Semicon India – 2025 is a three-day Conference, from 2nd to 4th September, focused on advancing a robust, resilient, and drive forward vision of the India Semiconductor Mission.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Minister of Electronics and Information Technology Ashwini Vaishnaw and Union MoS Jitin Prasada with others during the Semicon India 2025, at Yashobhoomi, New Delhi. (@narendramodi/X via PTI Photo)

— **India Semiconductor Mission:** It was launched in 2021 with a financial outlay of Rs 76,000 crore. So far, India has approved 10 semiconductor plants, including two fabrication facilities and eight packaging and testing facilities.

• Denotified and Nomadic Tribes Day

— It is marked annually on **August 31** to commemorate the repeal of the British-era Criminal Tribes Act, 1871, which criminalised nomadic, semi-nomadic and denotified tribes.

— Denotified tribes (DNTs) are communities that were ‘notified’ as being ‘born criminal’ during the British regime under a series of laws starting with the **Criminal Tribes Act of 1871**.

Commissions and Committees formed for DNTs

- ◆ The Criminal Tribes Inquiry Committee, 1947 constituted in the United Provinces (now Uttar Pradesh)
- ◆ Ananthasayanam Ayyangar Committee in 1949 (it was based on the report of this committee the Criminal Tribes Act was repealed)
- ◆ In 1965, an Advisory Committee constituted for revision of the SC and ST list under the chairmanship of B N Lokur referred to denotified tribes.
- ◆ A National Commission for De-notified, Nomadic and Semi-Nomadic Tribes (NCDNT) was constituted in 2006, headed by Balkrishna Sidram Renke. The Renke commission estimated their population at around 10.74 crore based on Census 2001.
- ◆ To compile state-wide Denotified, Nomadic and Semi-Nomadic Tribes (DNT/ NT/ SNT), a commission was established under Bhiku Ramji Idate. As per the report, over 260 extremely marginalised communities have never been identified or included in any of the reserved categories.

● **Gyan Bharatam International Conference**

— At the Gyan Bharatam International Conference organised by the Ministry of Culture in New Delhi, PM Modi said India still possesses the world's largest manuscript collection with approximately one crore manuscripts in its possession.

— The three-day event was being attended by around 1,100 participants, including conservation experts, scholars, historians, academics and custodians of manuscripts.

— Eight working groups deliberated on issues such as decipherment of ancient scripts such as Indus, Gilgit and Shankha; survey and documentation; digitisation tools; conservation and restoration; decoding manuscripts; and explore legal and ethical issues regarding access.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi visits an exhibition during the International Conference on Gyan Bharatam in New Delhi. (PTI)

— The first-ever international manuscript heritage conference — 'Reclaiming India's knowledge legacy through manuscript heritage' — coincided with the 132nd anniversary of Swami Vivekananda's historic address at the Parliament of the World's Religions held in Chicago in 1893.

— With the 400-crore Gyan Bharatam project, the government is aiming to create an institution on the lines of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) for the preservation and interpretation of India's manuscripts.

— It was in the Union Budget 2025-26 that Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman had announced a special mission for the survey, documentation, and conservation of India's manuscript heritage. Officials say the initial outlay for the mission is estimated at Rs 400 crore, but since it's not a time-bound project and will be institutionalised on the lines of the ASI, more funds can be allocated at a later stage.

— Launched as the 'Gyan Bharatam Mission', it intends to cover more than one crore manuscripts, officials say, adding that while the project will be headquartered in New Delhi, as part of the Ministry of Culture, regional centres will be set up across all states to ensure seamless coordination.

— Gyan Bharatam replaces the existing National Manuscripts Mission, which was launched in 2003, aiming to digitise all manuscripts in the country, but was moving at a slow pace.

● **Digvijay Divas**

— Digvijay Divas is observed annually to mark **Swami Vivekananda's historic speech** at the World Parliament of Religions in Chicago on September 11, 1893.

- **Hindi Diwas**

— September 14 is observed as Hindi Diwas, or Hindi Day, to commemorate the **Constituent Assembly of India making Hindi the official language** of the Union government.

— The Constituent Assembly chose Hindi as the official — not the national — language of the country after extensive discussions over three days. Discussions were also held over what script should the Union adopt, what script should the numerals be in, and what should be the status of English. Hindustani (Hindi with more Urdu elements) and Sanskrit were among those proposed as official languages.

— At length, the Munshi-Ayyangar formula — named after Drafting Committee members K M Munshi and N Gopalaswamy Ayyangar — was adopted as a compromise solution.

— As part of the Munshi-Ayyangar formula, Article 343 of the Constitution as adopted in 1950 said, “The official language of the Union shall be Hindi in Devanagari script. The form of numerals to be used for the official purposes of the Union shall be the international form of Indian numerals.”

— “Notwithstanding anything in clause (1), for a period of fifteen years from the commencement of this Constitution, the English language shall continue to be used for all the official purposes of the Union for which it was being used immediately before such commencement.”

— When the 15-year period came to an end, protests broke out over the fear of imposition of Hindi in large parts of non-Hindi speaking India, particularly in Tamil Nadu. The resistance resulted in the Centre passing the Official Languages Act, which stated that English would continue to be upheld as an official language along with Hindi.

- **International Literacy Day 2025**

— Celebrated on September 8, the theme for this year’s celebration was “Promoting Literacy in the Digital Era”, highlighting the pivotal role of digital technology in enabling reading, writing, numeracy, and lifelong learning skills across the country.

- **Operation Polo**

— September 13 marks the 77th anniversary of Operation Polo, the military operation launched by newly independent India to annex the state of Hyderabad. Led by Major General Jayanto Nath Chaudhuri, Operation Polo lasted less than four days and brought to heel the Nizam who had been resolute in his decision not to accede to India.

— Hyderabad’s ambition to remain an independent state after the British left, was a cause of major concern for the Indian government. If realised, it could cut off north India from the south. Reginald Coupland, a constitutional expert cited by historian Ramachandra Guha in *India after Gandhi* (2007), had aptly described the situation: “India could live if its Muslim limbs in the north west and north east were amputated, but could it live without its midriff?”

— Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel put it more bluntly, famously saying that an independent Hyderabad would constitute a “cancer in the belly of India”.

- **16th Combined Commanders’ Conference (CCC)**

— Prime Minister Narendra Modi on 12th September inaugurated the 16th Combined Commanders’ Conference (CCC) at the Army’s Eastern Command headquarters in **Kolkata**.

— The conference is organised **once every two years**. It is the apex forum that brings together the nation's top civilian and military leadership to chart the path of India's defence preparedness.

— It was last held in Bhopal in 2023, which was inaugurated by Modi.

— On the final day of the conference, India's top military hierarchy decided to form **three joint military stations** — the first in the country — and also agreed to merge the education branches of the three defence services into a single **tri-services Education Corps**.



Addressing the Combined Commanders' Conference in Kolkata, Singh said the nature of war has become sudden and unpredictable, making it difficult to foresee its duration (X/@rajnathsingh)

● **Blue Economy Conclave**

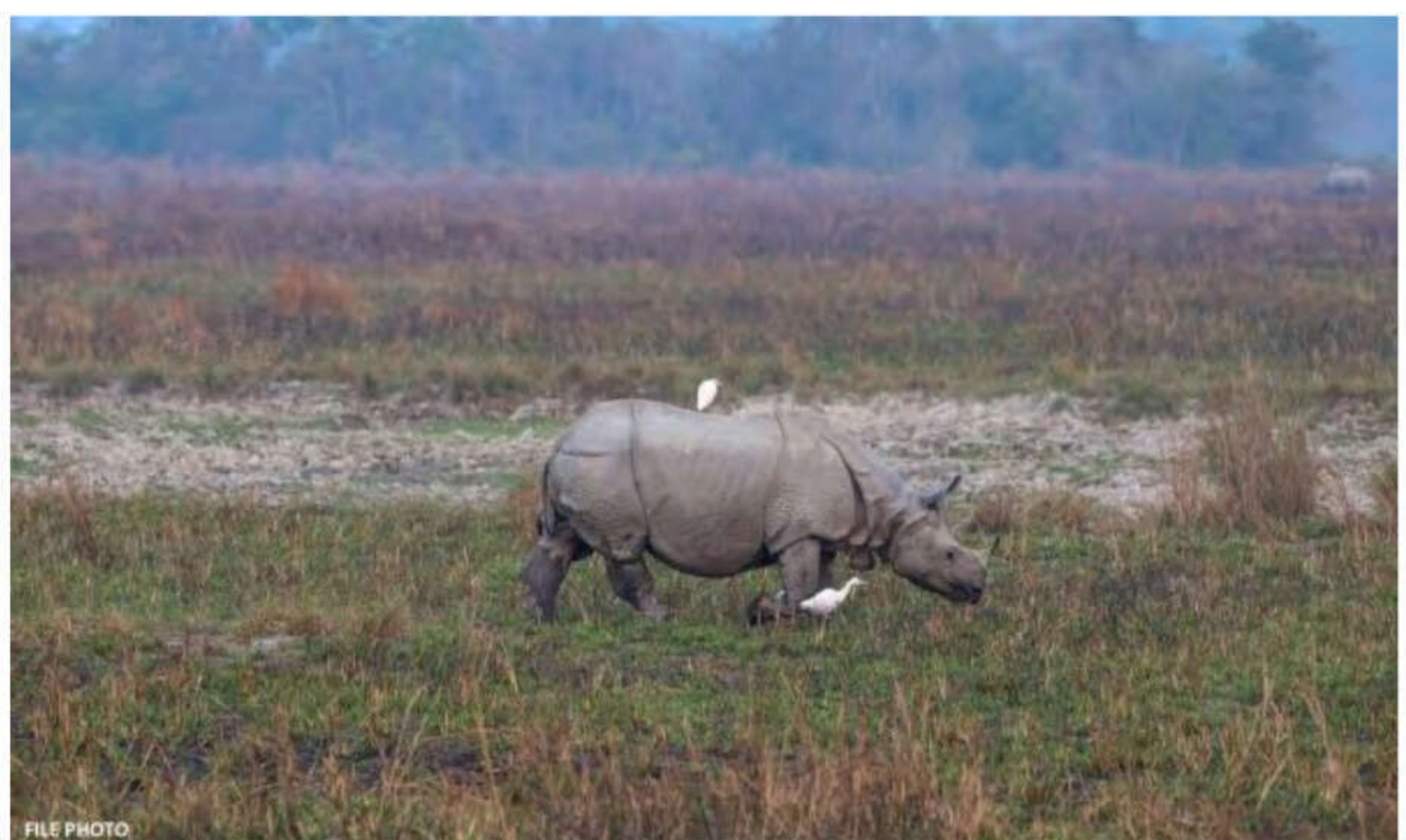
— A two-day blue economy conclave was organised in **Kerala** on September 18 and 19. Representatives from 29 European countries attended the Conclave.

— The conclave 'Blue Tides-Two Shores One Vision' is being organised by the State's Fisheries department in collaboration with the Union government and the European Union (EU).

● **World Rhino Day**

— World Rhino Day is observed on **September 22** every year. The day commemorates the global effort to protect rhinos and raise awareness to curb poaching. The word "rhinoceros" comes from the combination of two Greek words - "rhino" meaning nose and "ceros" meaning horn.

— The Indian rhinoceros (*Rhinoceros unicornis*) is found only in the Brahmaputra valley, parts of North Bengal, and parts of southern Nepal. The Indian rhino is listed as **vulnerable** (better than endangered, worse than near threatened) in the IUCN Red List.



India is home to a large number of one horned rhinos. (X/@@narendramodi)

— The **three species of rhino**—black, Javan, and Sumatran—are critically endangered in the IUCN Red List.

• World Tourism Day 2025

— World Tourism Day is being celebrated on **27th September** every year to highlight the importance of tourism in connecting people, fostering cultural exchange, and supporting economic development.

— The theme for this year is ‘Tourism and Sustainable Transformation’, which emphasises tourism’s power to promote positive change.

— The day commemorates the adoption of the United Nations World Tourism Organisation statutes in 1970. It was celebrated for the first time in the year 1980.

• Antyodaya Diwas 2025

— Antyodaya Diwas is an annual occasion to commemorate the birth anniversary of Indian leader Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya, who was born on **September 25**, 1916.

— He was the co-founder of the Bharatiya Jana Sangh (BJS), the forerunner of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). He was also one of the thinkers of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS).

— The **term “Antyodaya”** translates to “upliftment of the last person,” epitomising Upadhyaya’s mission to address the needs of the most disadvantaged individuals in society.

— He also propounded the idea of Integral Humanism which talks about unity and harmony among the various components that make up a human individual, and among individuals and society as a whole.

• National Ayurveda Day

— Ayurveda Day was earlier celebrated on Dhanteras every year, in honour of Lord Dhanwantari, the physician of the gods. From this year, the government has fixed **September 23** to be celebrated as the National Ayurveda Day starting in 2025.

— The theme for this year is “**Ayurveda for People & Planet**” and emphasises that Ayurveda is not just a healthcare system but a science rooted in the principle of harmony between the individual and the environment.

• World Food India 2025

— The fourth edition of World Food India 2025 was organized at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi.

— India’s growing leadership in the global food economy finds powerful expression through World Food India — the Ministry’s flagship international platform for investment, innovation, and collaboration.

Polity

• Adi Vaani

— The Ministry of Tribal Affairs has rolled out the Beta version of ‘Adi Vaani’, an **Artificial Intelligence (AI) based translation tool** that will serve as a foundation for large language models dedicated to tribal languages.

— Made using AI and efforts of academicians and educators proficient in tribal languages, the app will translate Hindi and English to tribal languages and vice-versa, and also aims to help digitize and preserve these languages.

— It was developed by a consortium led by the IIT-Delhi with Birla Institute of Technology and Science-Pilani, IIIT Naya Raipur, in collaboration with tribal research institutes in Jharkhand, Odisha, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Meghalaya.

● **New GST slabs**

— The Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council, in its **56th meeting**, cleared the next-generation reforms under the eight-year old indirect tax regime.

— It provided a two-slab structure of **5 per cent** and **18 per cent** with a demerit rate of 40 per cent rate only for super luxury, sin, and demerit goods.

— Sin goods are the products that are considered harmful to society, which may cause harm to health, or if they are considered harmful by a moral prism.

— All the rate changes, except those for tobacco and tobacco-related products, will come into effect from September 22.

— The GST regime came into force after the Constitutional (122nd Amendment) Bill was passed by both Houses of Parliament in 2016. It came into effect in 2017.

— The President set up the GST Council as a joint forum of the Centre and the states, under **Article 279A (1)** of the amended Constitution.



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman with Minister of State Pankaj Chaudhary on Wednesday. (PTI)

● **BHARTI**

— Recently, the Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (APEDA) launched its new initiative, **BHARATI. BHARATI stands for Bharat's Hub for Agritech, Resilience, Advancement and Incubation for Export Enablement.**

— It has been designed to empower 100 agri-food and agri-tech startups, accelerate their journey, promote innovation and create new export opportunities for young entrepreneurs.

(Source: PIB)

● **Bihar Rajya Jeevika Nidhi Saakh Sahkari Sangh Limited**

— Recently, Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi launched the Bihar Rajya Jeevika Nidhi Saakh Sahkari Sangh Limited.

— The objective of establishing the **Jeevika Nidhi** is to provide easy access to funds at affordable interest rates to community members associated with Jeevika. All registered cluster-level federations of Jeevika will become members of the Society.

— For the operation of this institution, the Government of Bihar as well as the Central government, will contribute funds. The Jeevika Nidhi has been conceived as an alternative financial system to reduce dependence on microfinance institutions and ensure the timely availability of larger loan amounts at lower interest rates.

(Source: pmindia.gov.in)

● **Suspension of Operations (SoO) agreement**

— The revised SoO agreement was signed between the Ministry of Home Affairs, the Manipur government, and 24 Kuki-Zo insurgent groups.

— The SoO agreement is essentially a tripartite ceasefire deal to initiate political dialogue. Signed in 2008, the agreement was between the Centre, the Manipur state government, and the KNO and the UPF, two umbrella groups comprising 24 separate Kuki-Zomi insurgent groups.

— After the conflict erupted in May, as insurgent groups on both sides of the Kuki-Meitei ethnic divide facilitated and participated in the violence, the agreement lapsed in 2024.

● **Public Safety Act (PSA)**

— The Aam Aadmi Party's (AAP's) lone Jammu and Kashmir MLA, Mehraj Malik (Doda), became the first sitting legislator to be booked under the stringent Public Safety Act (PSA), a law promulgated in 1978 by then Chief Minister Sheikh Mohammad Abdullah.

— The legislation, which has been dubbed by human rights groups as “lawless law” and “fascist law”, allows the government to detain any person above the age of 18 without trial for a period of two years as an administrative measure.

— The power to issue detention orders under the PSA lies with the District Magistrate, who is also the Deputy Commissioner of the district concerned. Police first prepare a case file, known as a dossier – a form of chargesheet – against the accused and submit it to the District Magistrate. The dossier explains why a person needs to be detained under the PSA. Based on the dossier, the officer decides if the order to detain the accused must be issued or not.

— In rare instances, mostly concerning ordinary residents and not political leaders, District Magistrates return dossiers, rejecting police recommendations.

● **Himachal declared ‘fully literate’**

— Himachal Pradesh was declared a “fully literate state,” joining an elite club that only had three other states — Tripura, Mizoram, and Goa — and an Union Territory — Ladakh — as its members.

— Announcing the achievement, Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu said that the state has reached a 99.3 per cent literacy rate, way higher than the national benchmark of 95 per cent.

● **Schemes and campaigns launched on the occasion of PM Modi's 75th Birthday**

— To mark the 75th birthday of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the BJP governments in various states launched public welfare programmes and campaigns on Wednesday (September 17).

— Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited Madhya Pradesh, where he launched the '**Swasth Nari Sashakt Parivar**' and the '**8th Rashtriya Poshan Maah**' campaigns, highlighting the government's commitment to nutrition and family well-being.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addresses the gathering during the foundation stone laying ceremony of the PM MITRA Park and inauguration of various campaigns, in Dhar, Madhya Pradesh. (PMO via PTI Photo)

— **Suman Sakhi Chatbot:** This chatbot aims to raise awareness on maternal and child health, and provide timely and accurate information to pregnant women in rural and remote areas, ensuring access to essential health services.

— **Adi Seva Parv:** As part of the Adi Karmyogi Abhiyan, Prime Minister launched the "Adi Seva Parv" for Madhya Pradesh. The Adi Seva Parv, symbolising the pride of tribal communities and nation-building, will continue until October 2.

— The Aadi Karmayogi Abhiyan, launched this year by the Union Ministry of Tribal Affairs, is an initiative for the socio-economic development of tribal communities across the country.

● **National Policy on Geothermal Energy 2025**

— The Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) has released the "National Policy on Geothermal Energy 2025" to facilitate the exploration and development of untapped geothermal energy resources.

— The policy aims to establish geothermal energy as one of the major pillars of India's renewable energy landscape, reinforce the commitment to achieve the **2070 Net Zero Goal**, and ensure **energy security**.

— Geothermal energy refers to the heat and electricity produced by **using the heat from the interior of the Earth**. It is a **site-specific renewable source** of energy specifically suitable for catering to the energy needs of remote/interior localities.

— The Geological Survey of India (GSI) has mapped **381 hot springs** nationwide with surface temperatures between 35°C and 89°C.

● **National Makhana Board**

— On 15th September, Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched the National Makhana Board in Purnea, Bihar.

— The announcement for the creation of the Makhana Board was made in the Union Budget 2025-26.

— The Centre is also establishing the National Institute of Food Technology in Bihar which will provide a strong fillip to makhana processing activities.

— Makhana, commonly known in English as fox nut, is the dried edible seed of the prickly water lily or gorgon plant (*Euryale ferox*). This plant is found in freshwater ponds throughout South and East Asia.

— Bihar accounts for approximately 90% of India's makhana production. This production is primarily concentrated in nine districts located in northern and eastern Bihar.

— In 2022, 'Mithila Makhana' was conferred a Geographical Indication tag.



Makhana is hailed as a superfood (Source: Freepik)

● **World's largest bamboo-based ethanol plant**

— The world's largest bamboo-based ethanol plant was inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in eastern Assam's Golaghat district on September 14.

— Two bamboo types from at least three of the eight northeastern States are used to run the ₹5,000-crore bioethanol plant optimally. These species are balco (*Bambusa balcooa*) and tulda (*Bambusa tulda*).

● **Form 7 of the Election Commission of India**

— Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi alleged that there were attempts to delete the names of 6,018 voters from the electoral rolls in Karnataka's Aland constituency in 2023.

— **Section 22 of the Representation of the People (RP) Act, 1950**, empowers the Electoral registration officers (EROs) of Parliamentary constituencies to make corrections and deletions to the electoral roll either on their own or acting on applications made to them.

— The Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, provide for the forms for new applications, corrections, and deletions from electoral rolls. **Form 7** is the one for making "objection for proposed inclusion/deletion of name in existing roll".

— Electors can file a Form 7 if they want to delete their own name or if they want to object to any other elector in their constituency.

— Form 7 requires the applicant to provide their own name, EPIC number and phone number, as well as the name, EPIC number (if available) and address of the person against whom they are objecting.

● **AI for Viksit Bharat Roadmap and Frontier Tech Repository**

— NITI Aayog launched two transformative initiatives, **AI for Viksit Bharat Roadmap: Opportunity for Accelerated Economic Growth** and **NITI Frontier Tech Repository** under its Frontier Tech Hub.

— The AI for Viksit Bharat Roadmap delivers a clear, sector-specific action plan, while the Frontier Tech Repository inspires states and districts to scale technology for real-world impact.

— The Niti Aayog Frontier Tech Hub convenes leading experts across government, industry, and academia to assess frontier technologies—such as AI, quantum, and biotechnology—evaluate their opportunities and risks for India, and design strategies to harness them for Viksit Bharat@2047.

— Niti Aayog also launched the **Frontier 50 Initiative** to amplify grassroots adoption of technology and scale impact creation. It will support 50 Aspirational Districts / Blocks to pick use cases from the Repository and deploy those frontier technologies that have the potential to accelerate saturation of services across ADP/ABP themes.

— **NITI Frontier Tech Impact Awards for States** will recognize three states excelling in the use of tech to improve governance, education, healthcare, livelihood etc., and supporting them to scale measurable, transformative outcomes.

● **Bihar's Mukhyamantri Mahila Rojgar Yojana**

— Prime Minister Narendra Modi has launched Bihar's Mukhyamantri Mahila Rojgar Yojana on September 26. The Rs 7,500-crore scheme, an initiative of Bihar's NDA government, is aimed at promoting women's empowerment through self-employment and livelihood opportunities.

— Under the scheme, financial assistance will be provided to one woman from each family, for livelihood activities of their choice, fostering economic independence and social empowerment.

— Each beneficiary will receive an initial grant of Rs 10,000 via direct benefit transfer, with the possibility of additional financial support of up to Rs 2 lakh in subsequent phases.



The prime minister launched the scheme virtually from Delhi, with Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, his deputy Samrat Choudhary and other ministers joining it through video conference from Patna. (Source X/@narendramodi)

● **Capacity Building and Human Resource Development Scheme**

— The government has approved the Department of Scientific and Industrial Research / Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (DSIR/CSIR) Scheme on “Capacity Building and Human Resource Development” for the period of the Fifteenth Finance Commission Cycle 2021-22 to 2025-26.

— The scheme is implemented by the CSIR and will cover all R&D institutions, national laboratories, Institutes of National Importance, Institutes of Eminence, and Universities across the country.

— The Scheme plays an important role in the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) for the S&T sector in India by increasing the researchers per million population. The Scheme has demonstrated its relevance by building capacity and expanding the pool of high-quality human resources in the S&T sector.

(Source: PIB)

● Visakhapatnam Declaration

- The **28th National Conference on e-Governance (NCeG)** was held at Vishakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh on 22nd and 23rd of September. The conference concluded with the adoption of the “Visakhapatnam Declaration.”
- It was co-hosted by the Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG), the Ministry of Electronics and IT (MeitY), and the Government of Andhra Pradesh.
- The theme of the conference was “**Viksit Bharat: Civil Service and Digital Transformation.**”
- The declaration called for a whole-of-government approach to strengthen civil services with digital competencies and agile, data-driven frameworks.
- It proposed **scaling up AI-driven platforms** like Digital India BHASHINI, Digi Yatra, and NADRES V2 to deliver multilingual, real-time, and sector-specific citizen services with a focus on ethical and transparent adoption of AI.
- The Visakhapatnam Declaration sets the tone for India’s digital governance strategy over the coming years, with an emphasis on inclusivity, security, and innovation to empower citizens and strengthen service delivery.

(Source: nceg.gov.in)

International Cooperation

● SCO Summit

- The 25th Meeting of the Council of Heads of State of the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) was held in Tianjin, China, from 31 August to 1 September 2025.
- The SCO declaration condemned the Pahalgam terror attack, which reference was omitted during the defence ministers meeting of SCO in June.
- PM Modi outlined India’s vision and policy regarding SCO. It is built on three pillars that are
 - S – Security
 - C – Connectivity
 - O – Opportunity
- **Civilisation Dialogue Forum:** PM Modi also proposed the formation of a ‘**Civilisation Dialogue Forum**’ to enhance people-to-people ties in the SCO, stating that this would provide a global platform for the countries to share ancient civilisation, culture, traditions, and literature.
- **Global Governance Initiative (GGI):** Chinese President Xi Jinping proposed the **Global Governance Initiative (GGI)** at the SCO plus leaders’ summit as he advocated practising multilateralism.
- **Dialogue Partner Status to Lao People’s Democratic Republic:** A decision was taken to grant the Lao People’s Democratic Republic the status of SCO Dialogue Partner and to grant SCO Observer status with the Commonwealth of Independent States.
- **City of Cholpon-Ata designated “Tourist and Cultural Capital of the SCO” for 2025–2026:** In accordance with the Organization’s tradition, the city of Cholpon-Ata in Kyrgyzstan was designated the “Tourist and Cultural

Capital of the SCO” for 2025–2026.

— **Kyrgyz Republic to host next SCO Summit:** The chairmanship for 2025–2026 has passed to the Kyrgyz Republic. The head of Kyrgyzstan named the theme of the Kyrgyz chairmanship as “25 years of the SCO: together for a stable world, development, and prosperity”.

About SCO

SCO was established on **June 15, 2001**, in Shanghai as an international organisation. It consists of 10 member countries- India, Iran, Kazakhstan, China, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, and Belarus. India and Pakistan became full members in 2017. Belarus is the latest to join in 2023.

The organisation has two permanent bodies: the **Secretariat in Beijing, China**, and the **Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) in Tashkent**.

Russian and Chinese are the official languages of the SCO.

● **Burkina Faso bans homosexuality**

— Burkina Faso’s government has passed a law **banning homosexuality**, with those found guilty facing two to five years in prison.

— Burkina Faso joins the list of more than half of Africa’s 54 countries that have laws banning homosexuality with the penalties ranging from several years in prison to the death penalty.

— Burkina Faso has been run by the military under President Ibrahim Traore, following a coup in 2022 that the soldiers said was to stabilize the country amid a worsening security crisis and provide better governance.

— Last year, Burkina Faso along with **Niger and Mali** withdrew from the West Africa bloc known as **ECOWAS**.

● **Nepal’s GenZ Protest**

— A couple of months ago, some Facebook pages, including one called Next Generation Nepal, began to post on the grim political situation in Nepal and the massive corruption in high places.

— No specific individuals appeared to be promoting the posts, but it was clear that most of them belonged to a generation that was born between 1996 and 2012, the cohort known as “Generation Z”, or ‘Gen Z’.

— The young people, teens and those in their 20s, expressed their anger and frustration at the corrupt political system — and the immunity that politicians who have run Nepal by turns since the republic was created in 2008, have given themselves from investigation or accountability.

— The criticism especially targeted the extravagant lifestyles of the children and wards of senior politicians, and expressions like ‘Nepo Babies’ and ‘Nepo Kids’ trended online.

— A couple of weeks ago, the government banned 26 social media platforms, including prominent ones like Facebook, WhatsApp, Instagram, X, and YouTube, for failing to register with the authorities by a certain deadline.

— The digital ban took away the primary avenue that Gen Z was using to vent, comment, and seek solidarity among

themselves, and greatly aggravated their anger.

— The frustration boiled over last week, when large numbers of young people came out on the streets, and 19 were killed after police and security forces opened fire.

● **Strategic Mutual Defense Agreement (SMDA)**

— Pakistan and Saudi Arabia on Wednesday (17th September) signed a Strategic Mutual Defense Agreement (SMDA) during Pak Prime Minister Shahbaz Sharif's and Army Chief Asim Munir's visit to Riyadh.

— According to a joint statement issued after the meeting, "the agreement states that any aggression against either country shall be considered an aggression against both".



Saudi Arabia's Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, Saudi Arabia's Defence Minister Khalid bin Salman, Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, and Pakistan's Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir, pose for photographs after signing a mutual defense pact. (Photo: AP)

● **WTO Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies**

— On 15th September, WTO Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies came into effect, which commits members to curbing billions of dollars in annual spending on the most harmful subsidies that contribute to the depletion of marine fish stocks.

— It is the WTO's first multilateral agreement with environmental sustainability at its core. It prohibits government support to illegal fishing activities and overexploitation of stocks, contributing to the protection of marine life.

— Adopted by consensus at the WTO's 12th Ministerial Conference in June 2022, the Agreement's disciplines prohibit subsidies for illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing, for fishing overfished stocks, and for fishing on the unregulated high seas.

— A WTO Fish Fund was also established to provide developing economies and least-developed countries (LDCs) with technical assistance and capacity-building needed to implement the new obligations and manage their own fisheries more sustainably.

— India has **not signed** the agreement.

(Source: wto.org)

● **H-1B visas**

— US President Donald Trump has signed an executive order that requires companies hiring overseas talent through the H-1B visa to pay \$100,000 a year for each H-1B worker visa.

— Until now, H-1B visas have carried various administrative fees totalling around \$1,500.

— People born in India are the largest beneficiaries of the H-1B program. Data from the US government show that Indians account for more than 70% of all H-1B petitions approved each year since 2015.

- **The US imposed a 100 per cent tariff on branded or patented pharmaceutical products**

— The Trump administration has announced to impose a 100 per cent tariff on branded or patented pharmaceutical products, a 50 per cent tariff on all kitchen cabinets, bathroom vanities, and associated products, and a 25 per cent tariff on heavy trucks. It will be imposed from October 1st, 2025.

— The US is India's largest market for pharmaceutical exports, accounting for an almost 40 per cent share. India's contribution of nearly 6 per cent of the total US imports is largely dominated by generic medicines. As the tariff is not on generic medicines, the Indian pharmaceuticals for now will not be impacted to that extent.

Environment

- **Sahyadri Tiger Reserve**

— The Union Environment Ministry has approved the capture of eight tigers from the **Tadoba-Andhari and Pench reserves** for their translocation to the Sahyadri Tiger Reserve in western Maharashtra, a move aimed at reviving the big cat's population in the northern Western Ghats.

— The ministry's approval is learnt to have come after the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), which is working with the Sahyadri reserve's field staff, gave a positive appraisal of the preparations to host translocated tigers.

— The Sahyadri Tiger Reserve, named after the Sahyadri range in the Western Ghats, is spread over 1,165 sq km, straddling Kolhapur, Sangli, Satara and Ratnagiri districts. It was notified in 2010, combining the Chandoli National Park and Koyna Wildlife Sanctuary area.

— The technical committee of the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) had recommended approval for the translocation project in October 2023. The translocation is part of the second phase of the long-term tiger recovery plan being implemented in the Sahyadri Tiger Reserve. In the initial stage, the state forest department and WII worked to strengthen the forest habitat and prey base.

— As per the NTCA's management effectiveness evaluation of tiger reserves, the Sahyadri Tiger Reserve forms the catchment for Koyna and Warna rivers, which are crucial for livelihoods in neighbouring districts.

- **Super Typhoon Ragasa**

— Recently, Typhoon Ragasa, one of the strongest storms to hit Asia in years, made landfall in South China's Yangjiang, in Guangdong province.

— A super typhoon is a very violent storm, equivalent to a Category 5 hurricane, packing winds of 253km/h (157 mph), BBC News highlighted.

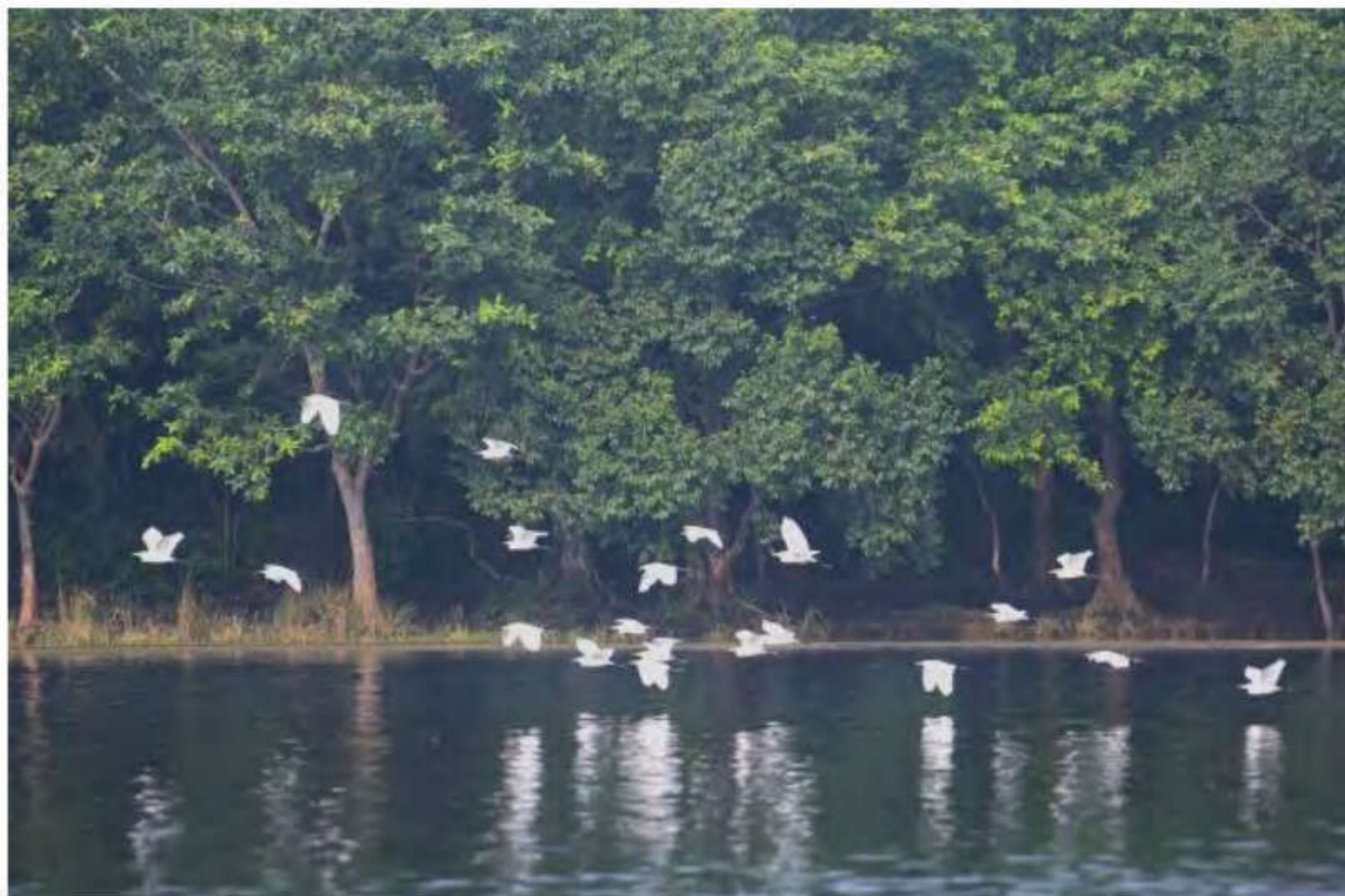
— Typhoons, including a super typhoon, generally form in the West Pacific, close to places like China, Japan, and the Philippines, it noted. It is locally known as Nando in the Philippines.

• **New Ramsar sites from Bihar**

— Two sites from Bihar — **Gokul Jalashay** (448 hectares) in Buxar district and **Udaipur Jheel** (319 hectares) in West Champaran district — were declared Ramsar sites.

— This brings the total to **93 Ramsar Sites**, spanning 13,60,719 hectares, underscoring India's resolve to safeguard its rich wetland ecosystems for biodiversity, climate resilience, and sustainable livelihoods.

(Source: pmindia.gov.in)



New Ramsar sites from Bihar. (X/@byadavbjp)

Science and Technology

• **Jarosite Mineral in Matanomadh**

— **Matanomadh**, a thinly populated village nearly 100 km west of Bhuj town in **Gujarat's** Kutch district, might end up as a potential test bed for the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) ahead of its Mangalyaan-2 mission to Mars.

— Recently, the **jarosite mineral** found in Matanomadh in 2016 was confirmed to be around 55 million years old, corresponding with the Paleocene period in the geological timeline.

— The dating of this mineral, found in a few rock structures in Matanomadh, suggests that there was a similar geological occurrence on both the planets millions of years ago.

— The Matanomadh site could thus offer field-analogue missions for Mars, where rover motion, instrument testing, drilling, and geochemistry experiments could be performed.

— ISRO has been trying to simulate the living conditions and environment of Mars and Moon in a desolate high-altitude village in Ladakh through its **HOPE (Himalayan Outpost for Planetary Exploration) mission**.

• **Vikram 32-bit Chip**

— India has marked a milestone in its chip-making journey at the Semicon India 2025 with the launch of its first fully 'made in India' 32-bit microprocessor, named Vikram.

— Vikram-32 is **India's first fully homegrown 32-bit microprocessor**, built by ISRO's Semiconductor Laboratory (SCL).

— The device can operate over a large temperature range -55°C to +125°C and it is packaged in a hermetic sealed 181 pin grid array package.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw during the inauguration of 'Semicon India 2025' at Yashobhoomi, in New Delhi. (PMO via PTI Photo)

● **Spyware ‘graphite’**

— Recently, the Trump administration has unfrozen a stalled Biden-era contract with Paragon Solutions, a spyware company founded in Israel. With this, the US Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) can gain access to the company’s powerful hacking software — **known as Graphite**.

— Graphite is designed to gain remote access to a mobile phone and essentially take control of it.

— The user of the spyware can not only access the mobile user’s photos, read their messages, and track their whereabouts, but also monitor encrypted messages sent on platforms such as WhatsApp and Signal.

— The spyware also enables the phone to be used as a listening device by manipulating its recorder.

● **Gyanex**

— Gyanex is the Gaganyaan Analog Experiments. Before it sends the actual human spaceflight mission under the Gaganyaan programme, the ISRO has been conducting simulation missions — known as ‘analog’ experiments — during which selected astronauts are spending several days in confined spacecraft-like conditions.

— Apart from getting the astronauts accustomed to space-like conditions, these experiments are meant to help ISRO develop protocols for processes such as communication and resource management for a human space mission.

— The only thing missing in these Gaganyaan Analog Experiments, or Gyanex, is the absence of gravity.

— During the Gyanex missions, the astronaut designates, and others, live in a confined crew module and space station, carrying out all activities that the astronauts would have to do in space, including following the routine and conducting scientific experiments.

— The participants have access to only things that would be available on the space station or crew module. And, during this period, they eat the food developed by DRDO.

— These experiments are being conducted in a static mock-up simulator, a model of the spacecraft, in Bangalore.

● **“Smog-eating” photocatalytic coatings**

— The Delhi government will conduct a time-bound feasibility study on the use of “smog-eating” photocatalytic coatings on roads, pavements and public spaces to reduce pollutants such as nitrogen dioxide (NO₂) and harmful hydrocarbons.

— The field trials and evaluation of titanium oxide (TiO₂)-based surfaces will be carried out.

— Experts have noted that using titanium dioxide as a coating has its advantages for being low-cost and chemically stable. It is also known for its compatibility with traditional construction materials.

● **2025 PN7**

— The 2025 PN7 asteroid was spotted this summer. It has an orbit that’s similar to Earth’s trajectory around the Sun. It is known as a **quasi-moon** and could be the smallest of its kind, perhaps no longer than 52 feet.

— Quasi-moons orbit the Sun, not Earth, spending hundreds or thousands of years in lockstep with Earth’s orbit. This protracted proximity makes them good targets for planetary science missions.

— Earth has several mini-moons as well. Mini-moons are objects that orbit our planet, but they make for fickle fans: they tend to swing around Earth only for a few months.

MAINS VALUE ADDITION

This is a case study of an IAS officer whose strategies during the COVID pandemic emphasised inclusion and trust, which became crucial to Tamil Nadu's early success in containing the virus. This is Beela Venkatesan, a senior civil servant and physician who became the public face of Tamil Nadu's fight against Covid-19, who recently passed away at the age of 55.

Her stance, both scientific and humane, helped steer public discourse away from stigma. Her team traced thousands of potential contacts, enforced quarantines, and prevented an outbreak from engulfing the state. Doctors said her medical training allowed her to cut through bureaucratic clutter.

Even as other states, including Kerala, barred the entry of migrant workers and returnees from high-risk zones like, Venkatesan chose a different path. She insisted no Tamil would be stopped at the state's borders. Instead, she led a system of screening at checkpoints, on highways, railway stations, and bus depots, welcoming thousands while trying to minimise spread – which was seen as a high-wire act that balanced science, compassion, and political sensitivity.

Diseases

(**Just FYI:** UPSC has consistently included questions on health and diseases in its examinations over the years. For instance, in 2014, a question about the Ebola virus appeared in the Prelims, and in 2017, a question about the Zika virus was featured. Therefore, it is crucial to stay updated on diseases that are currently in the news.)

● Ebola

— The 16th outbreak of Ebola in Congo is suspected of causing 15 deaths among 28 people with symptoms.

— The Ebola virus can spread quickly and be fatal in up to 90% of cases. Symptoms include fever, vomiting, diarrhea, muscle pain and at times internal and external bleeding.

— According to the WHO, the **Ebola virus** is transmitted to people from wild animals (such as fruit bats, porcupines and non-human primates) and then spreads in the human population through direct contact with the blood, secretions, organs or other bodily fluids of infected people, and with contaminated objects such as sheets.

— The Ebola virus was first described in **1976** near the Ebola River in what is now the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

— Ebolavirus is one of 3 members of the **Filoviridae family (filovirus)**, along with genus Marburgvirus and Cuevavirus

Defence

● New Defence Procurement Manual

— Defence Minister Rajnath Singh approved the Defence Procurement Manual (DPM) 2025 — the document governing defence revenue procurements including those for spares and ammunition — which adds a new chapter to

promote self-reliance through innovation and indigenisation, among other changes.

— Last promulgated in 2009, this manual was under revision in the Ministry in consultation with the Armed Forces and other stakeholders.

● **‘Samudra Pradakshina’**

— Defence Minister Rajnath Singh virtually flagged off ‘Samudra Pradakshina’ on September 11— a historic and first Tri-service all-women circumnavigation sailing expedition from the Gateway of India in Mumbai.

— In the expedition, 10 women officers from the Indian Army, Navy and Air Force aboard the indigenously-built Indian Army Sailing Vessel (IASV) Triveni will cover over 26,000 nautical miles across the globe for nine months, braving treacherous waters, freezing winds and unpredictable storms. The 50-foot yacht Triveni has been indigenously-built in Puducherry.



In the expedition, 10 women officers from the Indian Army, Navy and Air Force aboard the indigenously-built Indian Army Sailing Vessel (IASV) Triveni will cover over 26,000 nautical miles across the globe for nine months. (Image source X/@rajnathsingh)

— The crew, which set sail from Mumbai, will cross the Equator twice, round the three great Capes (Cape Leeuwin, Cape Horn and Cape of Good Hope) and cover all the major oceans, including the Southern Ocean and the Drake Passage.

— The crew will also make four port calls at Fremantle (Australia), Lyttelton (New Zealand), Buenos Aires (Argentina) and Cape Town (South Africa) and is scheduled to return to Mumbai in May 2026.

● **‘Ghost Bat’ drone**

— The two onyx-colored aircraft took off within a minute of each other, disappearing over an expanse of red desert stippled with low shrubbery. The aircraft were MQ-28A Ghost Bats, 38-foot-long military drones that function as robot wingmen of sorts.

— Australia is investing heavily to develop and produce these so-called collaborative combat aircraft, which will help the country defend its shores at a time when military threats are encroaching ever closer and wiping out what was once its strongest bulwark against potential conflict: distance.

— Australia has invested about \$650 million so far in a partnership with Boeing to develop the drones, which will be the first to be designed and manufactured in Australia in more than half a century.

— It is a tidal shift for the close American ally, which after decades of relying on the United States for its military equipment is trying to jump start its defense industry, one that had atrophied since the end of the Cold War.

• Air Defence (AD) radars

— The Army has sought to procure a range of **advanced air defence (AD) radars** — 45 Low Level Light Weight Radars (Enhanced), up to 48 Air Defence Fire Control Radar-Drone Detectors (ADFCR-DD), and 10 Low Level Light Weight Radars (Improved)

— These AD radars can detect, track, and engage aerial objects with small radar cross-sections (RCS), like the Pakistani drones which infiltrated Indian airspace in May.

— Radar is the acronym for RAdio Detection And Ranging. It is a specialised electronic system that uses radio waves to determine the direction, distance, and velocity of target objects. AD radars are used by the military to search, detect, identify, and help destroy aerial threats.

— A radar comprises two basic components: a transmitter which sends out radio signals, and a receiver which collects any reflected signals from a target.

— There are primarily two kinds of AD radars: **surveillance radars** and **fire control radars**.

— Surveillance radars are not directly connected to any anti-aircraft weapon system unlike fire control radars, which help surface-to-air guns or missiles target aerial threats.

— RCS, or radar signature, is a measure of how detectable an object is by radar, usually represented in square metres; larger the RCS, greater the detectability.

• Agni-Prime missile

— In a first-of-its-kind launch, India successfully carried out the test firing of the Agni-Prime (Agni-P) missile from a rail-based mobile launcher system. Thus far, **only Russia**, the **US**, **China**, and possibly **North Korea** had the capability of launching long-range ballistic missiles from rail-based platforms.

—It has the capability to move on the Rail network without any pre-conditions, which allows the User to have cross-country mobility and launch within a short reaction time with reduced visibility.

— The mass of the Agni-P missile is **11,000 kg**, and it is a **two-stage solid-fuel propelled missile**. It has an operational range of 1,000 km to 2,000 km. It can carry high explosive, thermobaric, or nuclear warheads.

• Cold Start Exercise

— In the first week of October, the Army, Navy, and Air Force will conduct a joint exercise to test drones and counter-drone systems. It is named ‘Cold Start’ and likely to be conducted in Madhya Pradesh.

• MiG-21 bows out

— The Indian Air Force (IAF) on September 26 bid farewell to its iconic MiG-21 fighter jets. Marking the occasion, Rajnath Singh released a special commemorative day cover and stamp honouring the legacy of MiG-21.

— India procured more than 700 MiG-21 aircraft of different variants from Russia, such as the Type-77, Type-96, BIS and the Bison, since the aircraft’s induction in the IAF in 1963.

— The MiG-21s are among the six fighter jets flown by the Indian Air Force (IAF), and have for long been the

backbone of the IAF.

— The MiG-21s are single-engine, single-seater multi-role fighter/ground attack aircraft. While they were first inducted in 1963 as an interceptor aircraft, over the next few decades, they were upgraded to perform a variety of roles performed by a fighter aircraft, including ground attack.

Persons in News

(Just FYI: Noting historical personalities' anniversaries aids UPSC prep. UPSC often includes such personalities in questions, so revisiting their lives refreshes your static syllabus.)

• Anutin Charnvirakul

— Thailand's parliament on September 5 overwhelmingly voted to elect Anutin Charnvirakul of the **Bhumjaithai Party (BJT)** as the country's next Prime Minister.

— He is Thailand's third Prime Minister in two years, a week after Paetongtarn Shinawatra was dismissed from the post by the Constitutional Court.

• Sushila Karki

— Kathmandu is bracing for a new chapter in its turbulent political history as former chief justice Sushila Karki was sworn as Nepal's interim prime minister (PM). The swearing-in ceremony took place at the presidential residence in Shital Niwas.

— The agreement to appoint Karki, 73, was reached after marathon negotiations between President Ramchandra Paudel, leaders of the Gen Z-led protest movement, and Nepal Army chief General Ashok Raj Sigdel. The deal came after days of unprecedented unrest that culminated in the resignation of Prime Minister KP Sharma Oli.



Kathmandu: Nepal's interim prime minister Sushila Karki chairs a meeting with security force and government officials after taking charge of the office, in Kathmandu, Nepal, Sunday, Sept. 14, 2025. (PTI Photo)

• Chandrapuram Ponnusami Radhakrishnan

— C P Radhakrishnan was sworn in as the country's 15th Vice-President. President Droupadi Murmu administered the oath of office to the 67-year-old at an event attended by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, several Union Ministers, and other dignitaries.

— He defeated B Sudershan Reddy by a margin of 152 votes.

— The electoral college for the V-P election comprises members of the two Houses of Parliament. Together, they

number 788 – 245 MPs in the Rajya Sabha and 543 in the Lok Sabha. Of these, six seats are vacant in the Rajya Sabha and one in the Lok Sabha. Of the 781 who comprised the electorate, 767 cast their votes (98.2% turnout), of which 752 votes were found to be valid, Rajya Sabha Secretary General P C Mody, the Returning Officer for the election, said.

- **Anuparna Roy**

— Anuparna Roy became the first Indian to receive the Best Director Award in the Orizzonti section at the 82nd Venice Film Festival for her film ‘Songs of Forgotten Trees’.

- **Bhupen Hazarika**

— For poet, singer, composer and filmmaker Bhupen Hazarika, whose centenary celebrations began on September 8 — exactly a year before he would have turned 100 — the Brahmaputra remained an enduring metaphor. So much so that his voice has often been equated with the river, next to which he grew up, lived and died.

— Born in Assam and rooted in the traditions of the Northeast, his songs – about the river, about the boatman, about other lesser-known folk idioms from and about a relatively overlooked and disturbed region, went on to become the links to the rest of the country. The universality of his themes, of solidarity, dignity, humanity, and resistance, has echoed for decades.

- **Surekha Yadav**

— Surekha Yadav, Asia’s first women locopilot, is set to retire on September 30 after 36 years of service.

— She became India’s first woman train driver in 1988 and was also the first loco pilot of the ‘Ladies Special’ local train for Central Railways in 2000. Further, she became the first woman loco pilot of the CST to Pune Deccan Queen train.

- **Mithun Manhas**

— Former Delhi batsman Mithun Manhas is set to become the next president of the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI).

— Manhas was the convener of the North Zone for Duleep Trophy and he was also support staff of the IPL franchise Gujarat Titans before, and is currently administrator of the Jammu and Kashmir Cricket Association (JKCA).

Places in News

(**Just FYI:** The location of the place is important, considering that UPSC has asked several questions about places that were in the news, such as Aleppo and Kirkuk, in the 2018 UPSC Prelims. The best way to remember them is to plot them on a world map.)

- **Al-Nuri Mosque**

— Iraq’s historic al-Nuri Grand mosque and its leaning minaret was reopened after militants from the Islamic state group destroyed the mosque.

— The mosque, famous for its 12th-century leaning minaret, was destroyed by IS in 2017 and has been a focal point of UNESCO's restoration efforts since 2020.

— The Nuri mosque was named after Nuruddin al-Zanki, a noble who fought the early crusaders from a fiefdom that covered territory in modern-day Turkey, Syria and Iraq. It was built in 1172-73, shortly before his death, and housed an Islamic school.

● **Sudan Landslide**

— A deadly landslide devastated a village in the **Marra Mountains area** of western Sudan with reports stating that over 1,000 people have been killed.

— The Sudanese movement that controls the affected area located in the Darfur region appealed to the United Nations and international aid agencies to help in recovering the bodies of the victims, which includes men, women and children.

● **Chabahar port, Iran**

— The United States has said it is withdrawing the sanctions waiver granted to **Iran's Chabahar port**, which is being developed by India.

— Chabahar, which sits at the mouth of the Gulf of Oman, is Iran's first deepwater port that puts the country on the global oceanic trade route map.

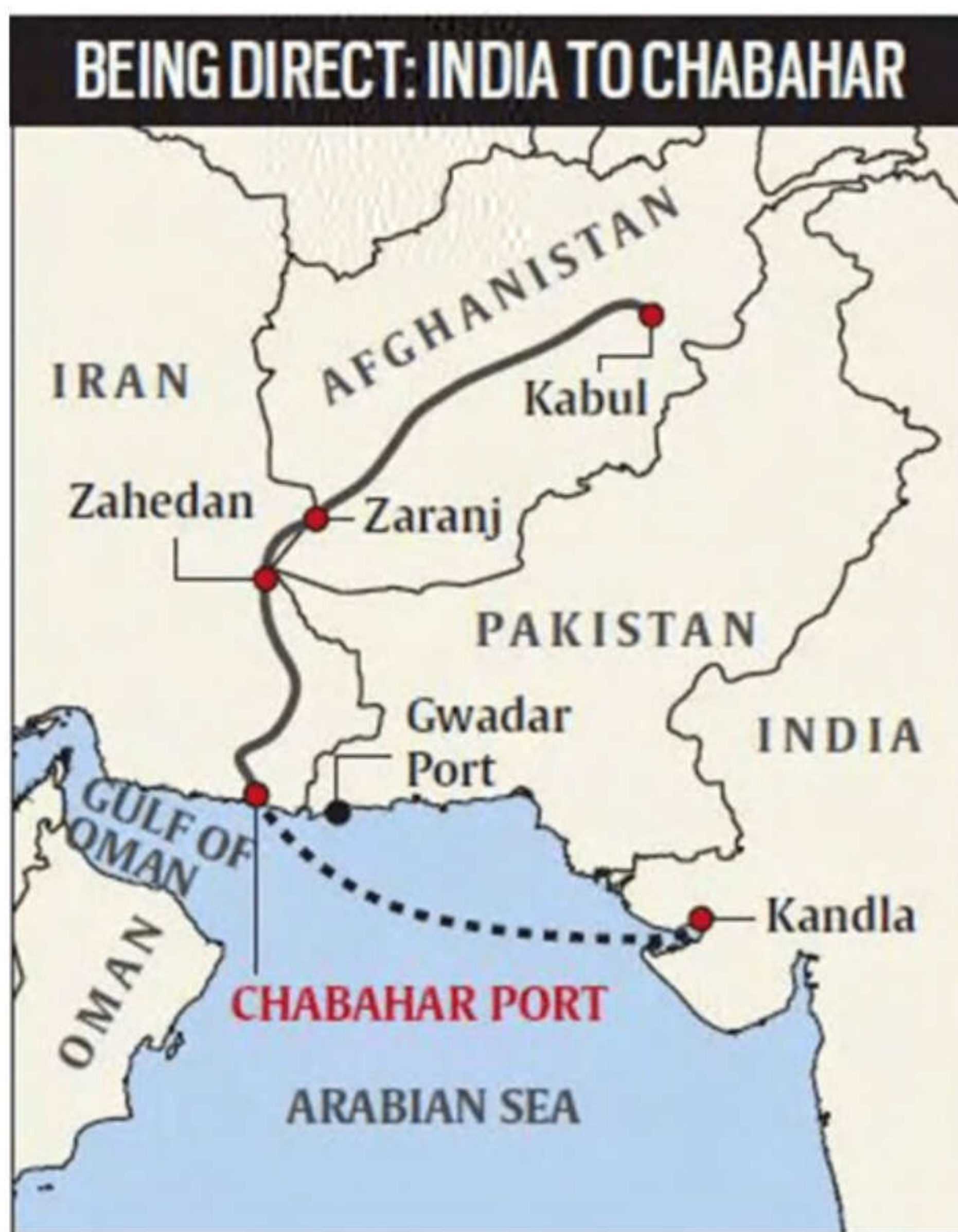
— The port lies to the west of Iran's border with Pakistan, about as far as Gwadar (a competing port developed by China in Pakistan) which lies to the east of the border.

— The port is also part of the proposed **International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC)**, a multi-modal transportation project linking the Indian Ocean and Persian Gulf to the Caspian Sea via Iran, and onward to northern Europe via St Petersburg in Russia.

— There are two distinct ports in the Chabahar project, **Shahid Beheshti** and Shahid Kalantari. India's investment is restricted to the Shahid Beheshti port.

— India, Iran, and Afghanistan signed a trilateral agreement in April 2016, after which the Indian Shipping Ministry worked at a rapid pace towards developing the port.

— In December 2017, the first phase of Shahid Beheshti port was inaugurated, and India sent its first consignment of wheat to Afghanistan through Chabahar that same year.



Chabahar port location.

● **Oju Hydroelectric Project**

— An expert panel of the Union Environment Ministry has recommended environmental clearance for the **2,220 MW Oju hydroelectric project** proposed on the **Subansiri river** in Taksing near the China border.

— The Oju project is proposed on the Subansiri river, 5 km downstream of Redi village of Taksing block in Upper Subansiri district of Arunachal Pradesh.

— The Subansiri River is a major tributary of the **Brahmaputra**.

● **Bagram Air Base**

— Recently, Donald Trump, in his Truth Social post, again demanded control over Bagram Air Base in **Afghanistan**.

— Bagram Air Base is the largest air base in Afghanistan, which lies some 60 km to the north of Kabul, in the strategic Parwan province.

— In Parwan lie the keys to controlling much of Afghanistan due to its linkages to key cities, including Kabul, Kandahar and Bamiyan.

— The air base was originally built by the Soviets in the 1950s, when both the US and the USSR were jockeying for influence in Afghanistan.

— After September 11, 2001, the US and its allies took over, as they toppled the Taliban regime. Today, the base is under Taliban control. However, the US has long been concerned about China making inroads into Afghanistan after its exit.



Bagram map.

● **Sawalkote dam**

— The stalled Sawalkote dam on the Chenab River in Jammu and Kashmir, is back at the centre of India's strategy to tap the river's hydropower potential.

— First initiated in 1984, the project has faced delays due to Centre-state tussles. Under the IWT, the west-flowing Chenab, Indus and Jhelum rivers are under the control of Pakistan.

— The project will divert 846 hectares of forest in Udhampur, Mahore, Batote and Ramban. This will include cutting of 2,22,081 trees, with the maximum – 1,26,462 – to be felled in Ramban district. The project's installed capacity will be 1,406 MW in Stage-I and 450 MW in Stage-II.

Awards

● **Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF)**

— Neeraj Ghaywan-directed **Homebound** and Jitank Singh Gurjar-directed **In Search of The Sky (Vimukt)** won at the TIFF.



TIFF 2025: Homebound became the second runner-up in the International People's Choice Awards category, while In Search of The Sky got the NETPAC Award.

— While Homebound is the second runner-up in the International People's Choice Awards category and In Search of The Sky is the recipient of the NETPAC Award.

— Homebound is also India's official entry for the Oscars 2026 in the Best International Feature category.

— Homebound documents the socio-political realities of contemporary India and captures the unprecedented displacement of migrant workers across the country following the outbreak of the COVID.

● **Dadasaheb Phalke Award 2023**

— Malayalam **superstar Mohanlal** will be honoured with the prestigious Dadasaheb Phalke Award for his services to cinema at the 71st National Film Awards ceremony to be held on Sept 23, 2025.

— Mohanlal has also won five National Film Awards and multiple Kerala State Film Awards.

— He was honoured with the Padma Shri in 2001 and the Padma Bhushan in 2019.

— **About Dadasaheb Phalke Award:** It was instituted in 1969 to commemorate Dadasaheb Phalke's contribution to Indian cinema who directed India's first full-length feature film, **Raja Harishchandra in 1913**.

— The first recipient of the award was Devika Rani. This award is considered the highest award in the field of cinema.

— The award comprises a Swarna Kamal (Golden Lotus) medallion, a shawl, and a cash prize of ₹10 lakh.

● **Emmy Awards 2025**

— The Emmy Awards are the most prestigious television honours in the United States. They celebrate excellence in acting, writing, directing, programming and technical fields across genres

— The first Emmy Ceremony took place on January 25, 1949, at the Hollywood Athletic Club in Los Angeles. **Ventriloquist Shirley Dinsdale** won the first Emmy for “Most Outstanding Television Personality.”

— **How the winners are selected:** Emmys operate on peer voting. Members of the academies are divided into professional peer groups – actors, writers, directors, technicians, producers – and they can only vote within their field of work.

— Shows should be submitted for consideration, following which nominations are announced, which is then followed by the final round of voting.





SOME EMMY FIRSTS OVER THE YEARS

1949: Shirley Dinsdale won the first Emmy for the Most Outstanding Television Personality

1960: Harry Belafonte became the first Black artist to win an Emmy in 1960 for his performance in The Revlon Revue: Tonight With Belafonte.

1970: Gail Fisher became the first African-American woman to win Outstanding Supporting Actress in a Drama Series for Mannix.

2015: Viola Davis became the first African-American to win Outstanding Lead Actress in a Drama Series for How to Get Away with Murder.

2017: Riz Ahmed became the first man of Asian descent to win Outstanding Lead Actor in a Limited/Anthology Series or Movies for The Night Of.

2022: Lee Jung-jae became the first Asian man to win Outstanding Lead Actor in a Drama Series for Netflix's Squid Game.

2024: Anna Sawai became the first Asian-born performer to win Outstanding Lead Actress in a Drama Series for Shōgun.

2025: Tramell Tillman became the first Black man to receive the Outstanding Supporting Actor in a Drama Series for Severance.



Category	Winners
Drama Series	The Pitt
Comedy Series	The Studio
Limited or Anthology Series	Adolescence
Lead Actor in a Drama Series	Noah Wyle – The Pitt
Lead Actress in a Drama Series	Britt Lower – Severance
Lead Actor in a Comedy Series	Seth Rogen – The Studio
Lead Actress in a Comedy Series	Jean Smart – Hacks
Lead Actress in a Limited or Anthology Series	Cristin Milioti – The Penguin
Lead Actor in a Limited or Anthology Series	Stephen Graham – Adolescence
Talk Series	The Late Show With Stephen Colbert

● 71st National Film Awards

— The **National Film Awards** were first given out in 1954, at that time it was called ‘state awards’. Nargis won the inaugural Award for Best Actress, for her performance as a schizophrenia patient in ‘Raat Aur Din’, while Uttam Kumar won the Best Actor award for both ‘Antony Firingee’ and ‘Chiriyakhana’.

— The first-ever Best Feature Film winner was the Marathi movie Shyamchi Aai. The most awarded film in the history of the awards remains Ashutosh Gowariker’s Lagaan, which received eight honours in 2002.



Shah Rukh Khan received the Best Actor National Film Award for his performance in Jawan (2023). (Express photo by Praveen Khanna)

Winners of the 71st National Film Awards	
Dadasaheb Phalke Award	Mohanlal
Best Feature Film	12th Fail
Best Feature Actor	Shah Rukh Khan (Jawaan), Vikrant Massey (12th Fail)
Best Feature Actress	Rani Mukerji (Mrs. Chatterjee vs Norway)
Best Feature Director	Sudipto Sen for The Kerala Story
Best Debut Film	Ashish Bende for his film Aatmapamphlet (Marathi)
Best Popular Film providing wholesome entertainment	Karan Johar-directorial Rocky Aur Rani Kii Prem Kahaani
Best Feature Film promoting national, social, and environmental values	Meghna Gulzar’s Sam Bahadur
Best Children’s Film	Naal 2 (Marathi) directed by Sudhakar Reddy Yakkanti
Best Film in the animation, visual effects, gaming and comic	Hanu-Man (Telugu)

Sports

(Just FYI: With the unpredictability of the UPSC examinations and questions like the ICC World Test Championship question 2021, you can’t be sure of anything. It is wise to know what it is and not go into too much detail.)

● Hockey Asia Cup 2025

— India won the 4th Asia Cup hockey title after defeating South Korea 4-1 at the Rajgir Sports Complex, Bihar. With this win, India have ended the eight-year wait to regain the title.

— With this win, India have qualified for the FIH Men’s Hockey World Cup 2026 in the Netherlands and Belgium. They have now won the Asia Cup title four times overall, behind only South Korea’s total of five.

— The 12th Men’s Asia Cup Hockey Championship was organised at the Rajgir International Stadium in Rajgir, Bihar, from 29th August to 7th September.

— The mascot of the Asia Cup Hockey, named “**Chand**,” is inspired by the national animal, the tiger. The name “Chand” is inspired by hockey legend **Major Dhyan Chand**, who created history in the game by practising under moonlit nights.

— Eight nations and 150 players participated in the championship.

● **BWF World Championships 2026**

— The 2026 BWF World Championships will be held in New Delhi, India. India last hosted the BWF World Championships in Hyderabad in 2009.

— **P.V. Sindhu** is the first and only Indian to win a gold medal at the BWF World Championships in 2019. So far, eleven Indian badminton players have won 15 medals at the BWF World Championships over the years.

● **US Open 2025**

— Wimbledon, French Open, US Open, and Australian Open are the most prestigious events on the annual tennis calendar, bestowed with the moniker of “Grand Slam”, a term that has been in use for almost a century.



*Carlos Alcaraz, of Spain, holds up the championship trophy after defeating Jannik Sinner, of Italy, in the men’s singles final of the U.S. Open tennis championships, Sunday, Sept. 7, 2025, in New York.
(AP Photo/Kirsty Wigglesworth)*

Winners of the US Open 2025		
Category	Winners	Runner up
Women’s Singles	Aryna Sabalenka(Belarusian)	Amanda Anisimova (American)
Men's Singles	Carlos Alcaraz (Spanish)	Jannik Sinner (Italian)
Women’s Double	Gabriela Dabrowski and Erin Routliffe	Katerina Siniakova and Taylor Townsend
Men’s Double	Marcel Granollers and Horacio Zeballos	Joe Salisbury and Neal Skupski
Mixed Double	Sara Errani and Andrea Vavassori	Casper Ruud and Iga Swiatek

● **World Boxing Championship 2025**

— India wrapped up their campaign at the World Boxing Championships 2025 in Liverpool with four medals, including two golds.

— **Jaismine Lamboria (57kg)** and **Minakshi Hooda (48kg)** were crowned world champions, while Nupur Sheoran (80+kg) secured a silver and Olympian Pooja Rani (80kg) settled for bronze.



*What has set apart Minakshi's World Championships run has been the ability to steam through three rounds without skipping a beat.
(World Boxing)*

● **CAFA Nations Cup**

— India finished third at the CAFA Nations Cup and it was sealed with a victory on penalties (1-1 in full time, 3-2 in spot-kicks) against Oman. Only two teams out of the eight playing in the 2025 CAFA Nations Cup were placed below India on the FIFA Rankings.

— The 2025 CAFA Nations Cup was the second edition of the CAFA Nations Cup, the biennial international men's football championship of Central Asia organized by the Central Asian Football Association (CAFA).

— The event was held in Tajikistan and Uzbekistan from August 29 to September 8. Iran were the defending champions.

— The final took place on 8 September at the Olympic City Stadium in Tashkent, between hosts Uzbekistan and Iran. Uzbekistan won the match 1–0 to claim their first CAFA Nations Cup title.

— In June 2025, it was confirmed the second edition would be co-hosted in Uzbekistan and Tajikistan on 29 August to 8 September 2025 for the six member associations along with Malaysia and Oman as the guest teams.

— On 15 July 2025, Malaysia announced their withdrawal from the competition, citing reasons including problems with logistics and players' availability. On 30 July 2025, India was announced as the guest team, replacing Malaysia in Group B.

● **World Speed Skating Championships**

— India has secured **three Gold Medals** and **two Bronze medals** at the World Championships 2025.

— **Anandkumar Velkumar** won India's first-ever gold medal at the Speed Skating World Championships, clocking 1:24.924 in the senior men's 1,000m sprint event. He followed up with **another Gold** in the Men's marathon event and also secured a bronze in the 500 m sprint.

— **Krish Sharma** has also won the Gold medal in the 1000-meter race in the junior category.

— **Anish Raj** claimed a Bronze in the junior men's one-lap sprint event.



*Anandkumar Velkumar became India's first World Champion in skating.
(X/@narendramodi)*

— The Speed Skating World Championships were organised in Beidaihe, China, from September 13 to September 21.

● **FIDE Grand Swiss tournament 2025**

— Vaishali Rameshbabu has won the FIDE Grand Swiss tournament for the second time in two editions after drawing her final game against former women's world champion Tan Zhongyi.

— Vaishali winning the title is historic because no player in the short history of the event has won the Grand Swiss twice.

● **World Athletics Championships 2025**

— The 2025 World Athletics Championship was held in Tokyo from September 13 to 21. The World Athletics Council has selected Beijing, China, as the host of the 2027 World Athletics Championships.

— **Sachin Yadav**'s fourth-place finish in the men's javelin throw emerged as the country's standout performance. **Neeraj Chopra**, who was the reigning champion heading into Tokyo25, had to settle for an eighth-place finish in the final.

— **Sarvesh Kushare** scripted history by becoming the first Indian high jumper to qualify for the final of a World Athletics Championships.

— Indian athletes have won three medals at the world championships - **Anju Bobby George**'s long jump bronze at Paris 2003, **Neeraj Chopra**'s javelin silver at Oregon 2022, and his historic gold at Budapest 2023.

(Source: olympics.com)

● **World Para Athletic Championships 2025**

— The 2025 World Para Athletics Championships is being organised in New Delhi from 27 September to 5 October. It is the 12th edition of the World Para Athletics Championships and the largest Para sport event ever held in India.

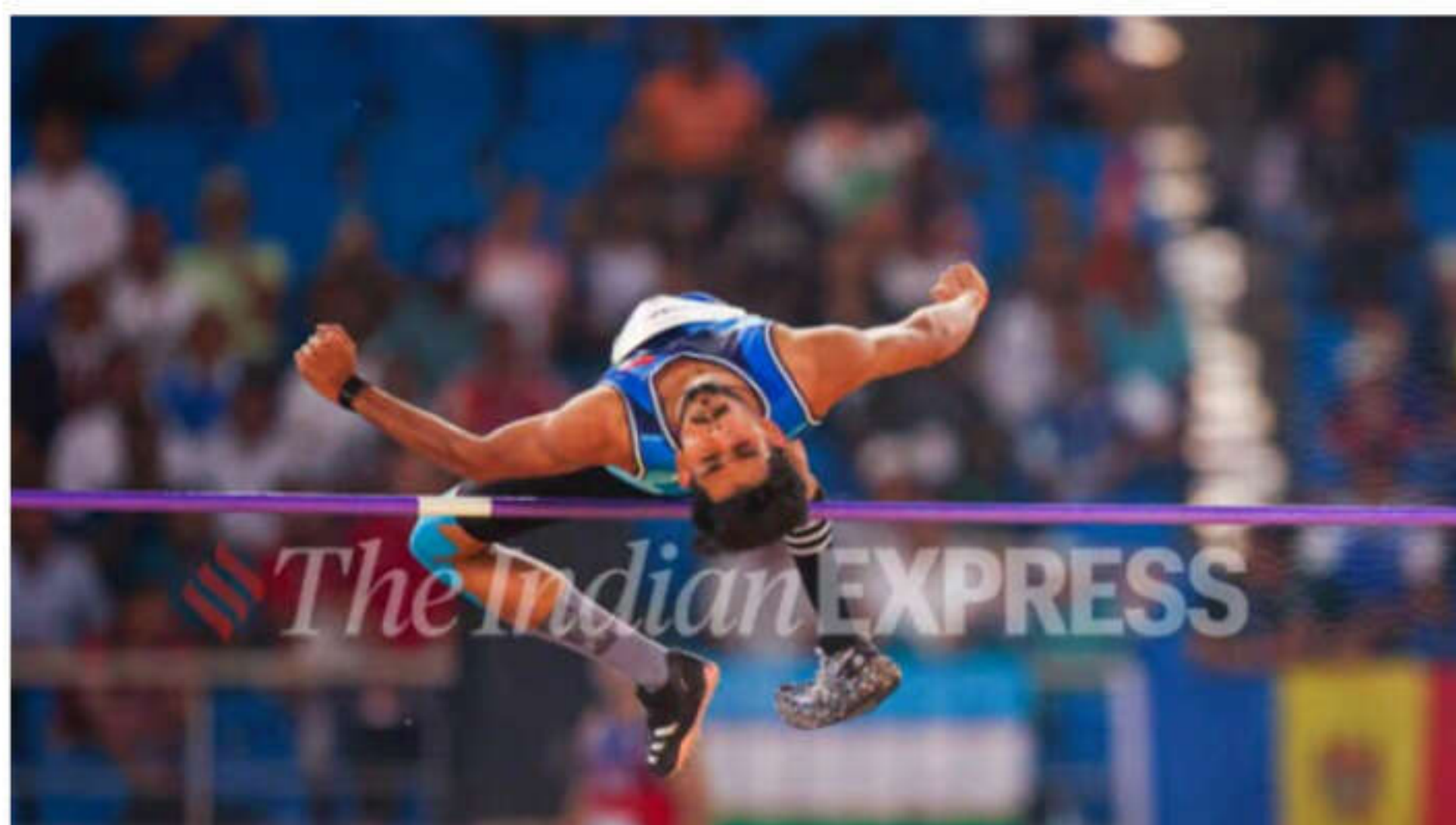
— **Shailesh Kumar** became World Champion in the men's high jump T63 category. He is from Bihar's Jamui district.

— **Deepthi Jeevanji** won the silver medal in the women's 400m T20 class.

— **Varun Singh Bhati** (T42) grabbed bronze in Men's high jump.



India's Sarvesh Anil Kushare makes an attempt during the men's high jump final at the World Athletics Championships in Tokyo, Tuesday, Sept. 16, 2025. (AP Photo/Bernat Armangué)



India's Shailesh Kumar competes in the Men's High Jump T63 event during World Para Athletics Championships 2025 in New Delhi. (Express Photo by Praveen Khanna)

- **World Archery Para Championships 2025**

— The World Archery Para Championship, which is organised every two years, was organised in Gwangju, Republic of Korea, from 22 to 28 September 2025.

— Eighteen-year-old Indian armless archer **Sheetal Devi** made history, defeating Turkiye's world No.1 Oznur Cure Girdi to bag the women's compound individual category gold.

— **Toman Kumar** joined her as the men's compound individual champion.

— Sheetal had earlier won a mixed team bronze in the compound event with Toman Kumar, defeating Great Britain's Jodie Grinham and Nathan MacQueen 152-149.

— In the compound women's open team event, **Sheetal and Sarita** won silver after losing to Turkey in the final.

Practice Quiz

Current Affairs Revision MCQs

Brush Up Your Current Affairs Knowledge And Consolidate Your UPSC CSE Preparation.

Compiled by **Nitendra Pal Singh**

QUESTION 1

With reference to the National Security Act (NSA), consider the following statements:

1. The NSA, 1980, empowers the Centre and states to detain individuals to prevent them from acting in a manner “prejudicial to the defence of India, relations with foreign powers.
2. The power to exercise the powers under the Act is with District Magistrates only.
3. NSA detention is punitive.
4. A detention order under the NSA cannot be executed like a warrant of arrest.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) Only three
- (d) All four

QUESTION 2

With reference to the India-EU trade ties, consider the following statements:

1. India is the EU’s largest trading partner in the Global South.
2. EU foreign direct investment in India in 2023 almost doubled in five years.
3. India accounts for around 30 per cent of the EU’s trade in goods and services.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 3

The term ‘Bison’, often seen in news, refers to which of the following?

- (a) a military exercise of India with Russia
- (b) the upgraded variant of India’s MiG-21 fighter aircraft
- (c) a ballistic missile developed by DRDO
- (d) an indigenous Armoured Personnel Carrier

QUESTION 4

With reference to the Agni-P missile, consider the following statements:

1. Agni-P is a two-stage solid-fuel propelled missile with an operational range of 1,000 km to 2,000 km.
2. It can carry high explosive, thermobaric or nuclear warheads.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

QUESTION 5

With reference to the enrichment of the Uranium, consider the following statements:

1. It is the process of increasing the concentration of U-235 in a uranium sample.
2. A 40 per cent enrichment of the Uranium is for civilian power reactors,
3. A uranium sample enriched beyond 20 per cent is called highly enriched uranium, or HEU.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 6

Typhoons are a common phenomenon in:

- (a) Indian Ocean
- (b) Atlantic & Northeast Pacific
- (c) Southern Pacific
- (d) East and Southeast Asia

QUESTION 7

With reference to the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution of India, consider the following statements:

1. Ladakh is included under the Sixth Schedule.
2. The Sixth Schedule under Article 244 of the Indian Constitution provides for the formation of autonomous administrative regions called Autonomous District Councils.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only

- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

QUESTION 8

The Digital Bharat Nidhi aims to:

- (a) promote India's traditional handicrafts in global markets
- (b) provide crop insurance to farmers against natural disasters
- (c) bridge India's digital divide and empower rural communities.
- (d) establish new institutions for higher medical education in rural areas.

QUESTION 9

With reference to the PM-KISAN scheme, consider the following statements:

1. It is a government scheme offering financial support to small and marginal farmers across India.
2. Under this initiative, eligible farmers receive ₹9,000 annually in two equal installments directly into their bank accounts.
3. It is partially funded by the Government of India and partially by the state government.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 10

Mount Desert Island was in the news. It is located in:

- (a) United States
- (b) Australia

- (c) Mexico
- (d) Indonesia

QUESTION 11

With reference to the GI tag, consider the following statements:

1. GI tags are issued per the Geographical Indications of Goods (Registration and Protection) Act, 1999 (GI Act).
2. Maharashtra is the leading GI state with the maximum-tagged products.
3. India does not have GI-tagged Natural products.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 12

Consider the following statements:

1. In the last 27 months, this state has witnessed prolonged periods of violence and displacement, a collapse of law and order, the strengthening of armed groups, a Lok Sabha election, and the imposition of President's Rule.
2. The state's porous international border with Myanmar faces the challenge of unregulated illegal immigration.

The above mentioned statements refer to:

- (a) Mizoram
- (b) Manipur
- (c) Nagaland
- (d) Arunachal Pradesh

QUESTION 13

With reference to Operation Polo, consider the following statements:

1. It was the military operation launched by India to annex the state of Goa.
2. It was led by General J N Chaudhri.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

QUESTION 14

With reference to the APAAR (Automated Permanent Academic Account Registry) IDs, consider the following statements:

1. The APAAR ID simplifies the processes of credit recognition and transfer right from the school level.
2. It empowers students to accumulate and store their academic accomplishments.
3. It is a 10-digit identifier for students in India.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 15

The development of the 'Koti Tirth corridor' has been approved recently. It will be constructed at:

- (a) Rameswaram (Tamil Nadu)
- (b) Jagannathpur (Odisha)
- (c) Dwarka (Gujarat)
- (d) Divar island (Goa)

QUESTION 16

Consider the following statements:

1. Longitudes are horizontal lines that indicate the north-south distance of a place from the equator.
2. Latitudes are vertical north-south lines that determine the east-west distance of a place from the prime meridian.
3. Any location can be described by the point where a specific latitude and longitude intersect.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 17

With reference to the Gyan Bharatam Mission, consider the following statements:

1. The mission intends to cover more than one crore manuscripts.
2. It is part of the Ministry of Culture.
3. It replaces the existing National Manuscripts Mission.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 18

Consider the following statements about the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972:

1. Schedule I lists species requiring the highest level of protection due to their endangered status.

2. Schedule II lists animals that do not need protection and can be hunted.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

QUESTION 19

Which of the following Tiger Reserves is located in the northern Western Ghats?

- (a) Sahyadri Tiger Reserve
- (b) Melghat Tiger Reserve
- (c) Pench Tiger Reserve
- (d) Palamau Tiger Reserve

QUESTION 20

With reference to 'literacy', consider the following statements:

1. The Ministry of Education defines literacy as "the ability to read, write, and compute with comprehension.
2. It defines 'full literacy' as "achieving 99% literacy in a State/UT".
3. There is only one state/U.T which has achieved full literacy.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 21

With reference to the Sarnath: Buddhist site, consider the following statements:

1. It is the place where the Mogaliputta Tissa is said to have delivered his third sermon.
2. Buddhist texts refer to this location as Mrigadava or Rishipatana.
3. Ashoka constructed a lion pillar at Sarnath which acts as the emblem of the Republic of India.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 22

With reference to the Manki-Munda system, consider the following statements:

1. The system was purely an internal, self-governing mechanism, with no sovereign authority outside or the concept of paying taxes.
2. The Manki and Munda had responsibilities for revenue or land-related issues.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

QUESTION 23

With reference to the Pamba River, consider the following statements:

1. It originates from the Pulachimalai hill in the Peerumedu plateau of the Western Ghats.
2. It is the longest river in Kerala.

3. It empties into the Bay of Bengal through various channels.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 24

What is the correct order of these states in terms (high to low) of the debt-to-GSDP ratio according to a first-of-its-kind report by the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG)?

1. Punjab
2. Nagaland
3. Maharashtra
4. Gujarat

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1—2—3—4
- (b) 2—1—3—4
- (c) 4—1—2—3
- (d) 3—1—2—4

QUESTION 25

With reference to the Assam Rifles, consider the following statements:

1. It was established in 1835 as a paramilitary force.
2. It addresses regional challenges such as insurgency and cross-border smuggling.
3. Its principal responsibilities include guarding the Indo-Bangladesh border.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two

- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 26

With reference to the Great Nicobar Island (GNI) infrastructure project, consider the following statements:

1. It was conceived by NITI Aayog and launched in 2024.
2. The project involves the construction of an international container transshipment terminal, a township and area development.
3. The project aligns with India's Maritime Vision 2030.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 3
- (d) 1 and 3 only

QUESTION 27

Operation Polo was the military operation launched by India to annex:

- (a) Goa
- (b) Sikkim
- (c) Hyderabad
- (d) Junagarh

QUESTION 28

With reference to the H-1B visas, consider the following statements:

1. It is valid for three years.
2. It is non-renewable.
3. There is no capping in H-1B visas.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one

- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 29

The Gyan Bharatam Mission is related to:

- (a) Manuscript
- (b) Space exploration and satellite navigation
- (c) Promotion of organic farming practices
- (d) Renewable energy transition and green hydrogen production

QUESTION 30

With reference to the layers of the Earth, consider the following statements:

1. The mantle is the uppermost layer where all forms of life and relief features are located.
2. The asthenosphere is part of the crust.
3. The core extends to the Earth's centre and is composed of iron and nickel.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 31

With reference to the particularly vulnerable tribal groups (PVTGs), consider the following statements:

1. These are a sub-category of Scheduled Tribes (STs) created based on the recommendations of the Dhebar Commission (1960-61).
2. PVTGs are enumerated separately in the census.
3. PVTGs are found only in Odisha.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 32

With reference to the infant mortality rate from the latest data of the 2023 Sample Registration Survey, consider the following statements:

- 1. India's IMR has increased in the last decade.
- 2. Kerala remains the only state with a single-digit IMR.
- 3. Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh have the worst rate in the country, last with IMRs of 37 each.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 33

The regions of Changthang, Mudh airstrip, and Suru Valley were in the news. They are located in:

- (a) Sikkim
- (b) Arunachal Pradesh
- (c) Ladakh
- (d) Himachal Pradesh

QUESTION 34

Which of the following organisations have signed the tripartite suspension of operation (SoO) agreement with the government of India and Manipur?

- 1. Kuki National Organisation (KNO)
- 2. National Democratic Front of Bodoland (NDFB)
- 3. National Liberation Front of Tripura
- 4. United People's Front (UPF)

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 3 and 4 only
- (d) 1 and 4 only

QUESTION 35

With reference to the UPI-PayNow linkage, consider the following statements:

- 1. It enables users of the two fast payment systems in either country to make convenient, safe and cross-border funds transfers.
- 2. It is between India and the Maldives.
- 3. Funds can be transferred to/from India using only a Virtual Payment Address (VPA) and not by mobile number.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 36

Which of the following acts have been replaced by the Immigration and Foreigners Bill, 2025?

- 1. The Passport (Entry into India) Act, 1920
- 2. The Registration of Foreigners Act, 1939
- 3. The Foreigners Act, 1946
- 4. The Immigration (Carriers' Liability) Act, 2000

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2, 3 and 4
- (c) 3 and 4 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3 and 4

QUESTION 37

With reference to the Right to Education (RTE) Act, consider the following statements:

1. The Act guarantees free elementary education for children aged 6-14.
2. The Act does not have provisions for minimum standards of pupil-teacher ratios.
3. Private unaided schools are required to reserve 25% of entry-level seats for children from disadvantaged groups reimbursed by the state.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

QUESTION 38

With reference to cancer in India, consider the following statements:

1. Men accounted for a higher proportion of the total cancer cases.
2. There has been an increase in the incidence of oral cancer in the country.
3. Lung cancers are easier to detect than Breast cancer.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two

- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 39

With reference to an earthquake, consider the following statements:

1. Shallow earthquakes generally have a depth of between zero and 70 km.
2. Deeper quakes are generally more dangerous than shallow quakes.
3. Shallow earthquakes spread farther as seismic waves move radially upwards to the surface.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 40

With reference to the Ebola disease, consider the following statements:

1. It is caused by a group of viruses, known as orthoebolaviruses.
2. It was first discovered in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and is found primarily in sub-Saharan Africa.
3. It can be contracted through bodily fluids.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 41

Which of the following indicators are included in the

Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI)?

1. Nutrition
2. Child and adolescent mortality
3. Drinking water
4. Unemployment
5. Pollution exposure

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1, 2 and 3
- (b) 2, 3, 4 and 5
- (c) 1, 3, 4 and 5
- (d) All of the above

QUESTION 42

The terms ‘American Grip’, ‘Finnish Grip’, and ‘Fork Grip’ are related to:

- (a) Shot Put
- (b) Javelin throw
- (c) Golf
- (d) Badminton

QUESTION 43

The dispute over Sir Creek was first officially addressed by the:

- (a) Government of Bombay in 1914
- (b) Government of India in 1925
- (c) British Political Agent in Sindh in 1910
- (d) Kutch State Administration in 1912

QUESTION 44

Which of the following metals is not among the Polymetallic Sulphides (PMS)?

1. Copper
2. Zinc
3. Gold
4. Magnesium

5. Potassium

6. Silver

Select the correct answer using the codes given below

- (a) 2, 3, 4 and 5
- (b) 1, 2 and 3
- (c) 1, 2, 3 and 6
- (d) 2, 4 and 6

QUESTION 45

Consider the following statements:

1. The Indian Government has announced two cross-border railway projects which will connect Bhutan with the bordering areas of Assam and West Bengal.
2. Currently, the Himalayan nation of Bhutan has only 40 km of railway network.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

QUESTION 46

Consider the following statements:

1. ‘Over-exploited’ blocks are where the stage of groundwater extraction is over 100 per cent.
2. Blocks with groundwater extraction between 90-100 per cent are categorised as ‘Semi-critical’.
3. ‘Safe’ blocks are those having the stage of groundwater extraction equal to or less than 70 per cent.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three

(d) None

QUESTION 47

With reference to Diethylene Glycol, consider the following statements:

1. It is a toxic industrial chemical.
2. It is used in the manufacturing of cough syrups.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

QUESTION 48

Recently, Cyclone Shakti has developed in the:

- (a) Southern Indian Ocean
- (b) Northern Bay of Bengal
- (c) Arabian Sea
- (d) Northern Indian Ocean

QUESTION 49

With reference to the Chikungunya disease, consider the following statements:

1. It is a bacterial infection.
2. The symptoms can include high fever and severe joint pain.
3. There are no specific treatments for this disease.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

QUESTION 50

With reference to the newly launched Sairang-Kolkata Express, consider the following:

1. It will be maintained and operated by the Southern Eastern Railway (SER) zone.
2. The train passes through Bangladesh.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Answer Key									
1. (a)	2. (b)	3. (b)	4. (c)	5. (b)	6. (d)	7. (b)	8. (c)	9. (a)	10. (a)
11. (a)	12. (b)	13. (b)	14. (b)	15. (d)	16. (a)	17. (c)	18. (a)	19. (a)	20. (a)
21. (b)	22. (a)	23. (a)	24. (a)	25. (b)	26. (b)	27. (c)	28. (a)	29. (a)	30. (a)
31. (a)	32. (a)	33. (c)	34. (d)	35. (a)	36. (d)	37. (c)	38. (a)	39. (a)	40. (c)
41. (a)	42. (b)	43. (a)	44. (c)	45. (a)	46. (b)	47. (a)	48. (c)	49. (b)	50. (d)

Detailed Explanations:

For a detailed explanation, visit indianexpress.com/section/upsc-current-affairs/. Click on the UPSC Quiz tab and explore weekly current affairs quizzes from September 2025.